Economic Opportunity for Musicians and Creative Workers: Austin in State and National Context

Earnings, venues, public support, 2001 to 2026

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This study gathers the public evidence on the economic position of musicians and creative workers in Austin and compares it with the city, state and federal programs directed at them. Austin musicians report median earnings from work of $28,700 against $62,500 for all Austin workers, about half, and 72.2% of them work for themselves, which places much of this workforce at or beyond the edge of the payroll statistics that public programs are designed around (see Section 4). Musicians sit at the low-earnings end of a wider creative workforce this study also examines. Pooling nine creative occupations[2] the Austin median rises to $52,100 and 40.1% work for themselves. The report reads mainly musicians because that is where the measurement record runs deepest, the earnings gap runs widest and the public programs are most concentrated; it turns to the wider creative workforce for occupation comparisons in Section 2 and for the state's arts-economy aggregate in Section 8.

> **What this study does.** It assembles what public data can measure about the economic position of people who work in music in Austin, and sets that record against the city and state programs aimed at them. It draws on federal statistics, city and state administrative records, and an original panel of monthly alcohol-sales receipts for 114 venues, a curated set of named Austin live-music rooms rather than a census of them, covering 2007 through mid-2026 (see Section 5).
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> **What it does not do.** It does not take a position in the running argument over whether musicians are paid fairly, or over what a venue owes a performer. That argument turns on judgments about value and risk that no dataset can settle, and the measurement record is too thin to resolve it either way. This study stays with what is traceable: earnings recorded in federal surveys, receipts recorded on tax filings, and dollars recorded in public budgets.

Summary

Austin calls itself the Live Music Capital of the World, and both the city and the state spend public money on that claim. This study asks a narrower question than the slogan: what can be measured about how the people who work in music are actually doing, and how do the programs aimed at them compare with what other states and cities run?

The city and the state have both built real institutions for music. Those institutions are small, unevenly administered, and pointed more at venues and tourism than at what musicians earn. The people they exist to serve are also largely invisible in the statistics governments use to make decisions.

$28,700	72.2%	2.90%	-18.6%
Median earnings from all work, Austin musicians, 2025 dollars	Of Austin musicians work for themselves, against 10.4% of all Austin workers	Of Austin hotel-tax revenue reaches the Live Music Fund	Real change in receipts at core live-music venues, 2019 to 2025

Sources for the four tiles: Austin musician earnings and self-employment, U.S. Census Bureau American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year Public Use Microdata Sample for Texas, Musicians and Singers only (occupation code 2752), 77 Austin records pooled over five years, downloaded from `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/`. Live Music Fund share of hotel-tax revenue, City of Austin open budget data on data.austintexas.gov, fiscal 2025 actuals. Real change in core live-music venue receipts, Texas Comptroller Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts (dataset `naix-2893`

[1] The analysis code, source data, and full evidence file behind every figure in this study are available from the author. All dollar figures are inflation-adjusted to 2025 dollars unless noted.

[2] Musicians and singers; music directors and composers; graphic designers; photographers; media, audio-visual and sound-equipment workers; producers and directors; actors; dancers and choreographers; writers and authors. These are the American Community Survey occupation codes that isolate creative and cultural workers in the Texas public use microdata; sound engineers are inside the combined media category and cannot be separated. This study reports the pooled figure and the musician figure separately, never one inside the other.

at https://data.texas.gov/) matched to 114 venues named Austin live-music rooms, deflated to 2025 dollars with the national consumer price index. Each source is developed in the section that uses it and listed in the technical appendix.

Austin musicians earn about half what other Austin workers earn, and hours worked do not account for it

Austin musicians report median earnings from work of $28,700 (+/- $9,400) against $62,500 for all Austin workers, both measured in the American Community Survey among employed adults aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings (developed in Section 2). Their median usual week is 40 hours and their median year 52 weeks, matching the Austin workforce on both. Across employed Texans, a model that holds age, sex, education, hours, weeks and metro area fixed still places music occupations -25.2% below otherwise similar workers, so schedule length is not where the gap comes from. That figure is an association among the characteristics the survey records, not the cost of choosing music. Comparing Austin with other large Texas metros requires a broader occupation definition, because Musicians and Singers alone yield too few records for a Houston or Dallas-Fort Worth cell. On the broader music-occupation definition (Musicians and Singers plus Music Directors and Composers), Austin's median is $31,400, against $36,700 in Dallas-Fort Worth and $43,900 in Houston. Austin has the lowest point estimate, but the Austin sample is small and the margins overlap in both pairwise comparisons, so the ordering is not statistically firm; the author makes no claim beyond that no comparison here supports the assumption that Austin pays musicians better than the other large Texas metros.

Most of this workforce is self-employed, which is why the official numbers miss it

The American Community Survey shows that 72.2% of Austin musicians work for themselves, against 10.4% of all Austin workers.[3] The Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program builds its wage series from employer reports rather than household responses, so it can see only payroll jobs.[4] That survey records 120 musician jobs in the Austin metro in 2025, a count much smaller than the household survey implies because self-employed musicians never enter the payroll survey at all (see Section 4). The City of Austin bought a third series, from the Creative Vitality Suite database, which combines federal wage data with self-employment records and so does count self-employed earnings.[5] That series put 2017 musician pay at 57.0% of the federal figure for the same occupation and year, direct evidence of what payroll data miss (see Section 1).

Live-music rooms are being lost; the ones that stay open trade like the market around them

The Texas Comptroller receives a monthly filing from every business selling liquor, reporting the location's gross mixed-beverage receipts. This study tracks the subset of those filings that come from named Austin live-music rooms.[6] Between 2019 and 2025, receipts changed -18.6% at the panel's core live-music tier (rooms whose main business is live performance) and +2.8% across the full citywide mixed-beverage universe. The two totals do not compare room for room, because the city added +30.5% more permit locations over the period; the tracked rooms held 8.9% of citywide receipts in 2019 and 8.0% in 2025. Once each venue's own trend and seasonality are absorbed, live-music rooms and other bars trade indistinguishably on log monthly receipts after March 2020, an average difference of 0.3% with a 95 percent interval running from about 14 percent below to about 17 percent above the rest of the market (Section 5). The aggregate decline is therefore explained by which rooms exist, not by weaker per-room trade among survivors. What changed is which rooms exist: 16 of 20 exits from the tracked

[3] Class-of-worker categories 6 and 7 (self-employed, unincorporated and incorporated), Musicians and Singers only (occupation code 2752), employed 18–64 with positive earnings, ACS 2020–2024 five-year PUMS. See Section 4 for the composition of that self-employed group and its trend since 2005.

[4] OEWS is a semi-annual establishment survey administered by BLS and the state workforce agencies; establishments report the wage of every worker on their payroll but report nothing for the self-employed, who fall outside the sampling frame. Program documentation: https://www.bls.gov/oes/oes_ques.htm. BLS also does not publish an *annual* musician wage for any city or year, because the work is too irregular to annualise from an hourly rate.

[5] City of Austin open data, *Median Earnings for Creative Occupations*, dataset 2qxc-8cme at https://data.austintexas.gov/, retrieved 1 August 2026. Creative Vitality Suite is maintained by Employment and Cultural Vitality Data (EMSI). The city's series covers 2016 and 2017 only.

[6] The venue panel comprises 114 venues Austin live-music rooms tracked monthly from January 2007 through June 2026, matched to Comptroller filings by taxpayer name and location address, and deflated to 2025 dollars with the national consumer price index. It is a *curated* set rather than a census, so it over-represents established rooms in the central city and excludes venues that hold no liquor permit. Receipts measure alcohol sales at each room, not attendance, ticket revenue or what performers were paid. Filings by festival companies operating under venue-linked names are excluded from the panel; leaving them in would make one room appear to grow more than thirteenfold. The panel and its construction are described in Section 5 and the technical appendix.

panel from 2020 onward were core live-music rooms, and the panel's net additions since 2016 come to -7 rooms against +80 over the previous nine years, a comparison Section 5 qualifies because the earlier figure counts every room already trading when the receipts file opens in 2007.

Census respondents expect to stay in music; renters are far less sure they will stay in Austin

The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census surveyed 2,227 people working in and around Austin's music economy: musicians and other music creatives (1,462 respondents), music-industry workers such as managers, technicians and studio staff (489), and venue operators or independent promoters (108), plus a smaller group outside those three sectors.[7] Of 1,900 respondents who answered both three-year questions, 88.8% expected to still be working in music in three years and 64.1% expected to still live in greater Austin. Housing tenure separates the Austin-retention answer more sharply than any other characteristic tested: 75.5% of homeowners expected to stay against 52.3% of renters, with years of experience the next strongest discriminant (Section 6). Most respondents who did not say yes to Austin answered "unsure" rather than "no."

Austin and Texas have built real music programs; the record shows how small and uneven they are

The left column is what the record shows has been built, the right what the same record shows about size and reach.

What is working	What is not
Austin runs a dedicated public fund for musicians, financed by a fixed share of hotel-tax revenue rather than by an annual appropriation.	The fund is 2.90% of city hotel-tax revenue, and historic preservation draws 4.42x as much from the same tax, because it draws on hotel-tax money beyond the equal share of the 2019 increase the ordinance gave each fund (see Section 7).
Texas is the only state compared here that subsidises operating music venues, and in the one rebate round with a published total it awarded its full annual dedication.	Through the same state office, Texas has dedicated moving-image money against music money for the 2026–27 biennium at 14.9 to 1 (see Section 8).
Federal shuttered-venue grants brought $238.4 million in nominal award dollars to Austin-area recipients, a one-off federal program in which motion picture theatre operators took slightly more than live venues did (see Section 8).	Neither the 2017 extended-hours pilot nor the 2024 venue grants left a detectable mark on venue receipts (see Section 5).
Health coverage among Austin musicians is 90.1% (+/- 8.5 points), indistinguishable within that margin from 87.7% for all Austin workers.	Neither the city nor the state provides that coverage, and private coverage runs 77.9% for musicians against 84.7% for the wider Austin workforce (see Section 2).
The city publishes an awardee list for each Live Music Fund cycle.	What a musician could receive depended heavily on the year they applied, and one cycle was skipped entirely (see Section 7).
Austin rents and home values have fallen further from their peaks than in any comparison metro (see Section 3).	Austin's own music census has not asked a musician what they earn since the 2014 fielding, whose income questions covered calendar 2013 (see Section 1).

The state Comptroller records every venue's alcohol sales and the city records what it spends. No public source records what a musician is paid for a night's work, the thing the argument is actually about. This study takes no position in that argument.

1 Austin stopped asking musicians what they earn

What Austin musicians earn depends on which source you ask, and the sources disagree in a patterned way. This section opens by placing Austin inside Texas and Texas inside the country, then traces what the city measured and then stopped measuring, follows one widely repeated income figure back to its origin, sets out what four federal statistical programs can and cannot see, and ends with the rules this study follows when sources conflict.

[7] Sound Music Cities and City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *Greater Austin Music Census*, 2022. The instrument was distributed through music-community mailing lists and city channels between 15 July and 12 September 2022. Respondent-level microdata downloaded from City of Austin open data, dataset `an3p-3yqx`, retrieved 1 August 2026. It is a self-selected online sample rather than a probability sample of Austin's music workforce, so its shares describe the people who answered and no margin of error can be computed for any of them; a probability-sample benchmark for the same population does not exist. This study treats the census as the best available direct measurement of the workforce's non-earnings answers, with that caveat carried into every figure it produces.

1.1 Austin is a concentrated music town inside a state that commits little to music

A reader meeting an Austin figure in this study needs two reference points: where Austin stands within Texas, and where Texas stands within the country. Austin accounts for 17.6% of Texas musicians and singers against 9.4% of employed Texans,[8] so the metro's share of the state's musicians is close to twice its share of the state's workers. Travis County registers more solo creative businesses per resident than Dallas, Bexar or Harris, the three other large Texas counties compared here.[9] Texas itself has a small arts economy for its size and pays out little per resident through its main music-specific incentive, though in the one rebate round with a published total the Texas Music Office awarded its full annual dedication.[10] The table below sets each comparison beside the section that develops it, where the margins, methods and caveats are given in full.

Measure	Austin or Texas	Comparison, and the section that develops it
Austin within Texas		
Share of Texas musicians and singers who work in the Austin metro	17.6%	The metro's share of all employed Texans is 9.4% (Section 2)
Independent-artist businesses per 10,000 residents, Travis County, 2023	64.26	Dallas 28.63, Bexar 25.10, Harris 22.60 (Section 4)
Median earnings in the pooled music occupations (musicians, singers, music directors and composers), Austin metro	$31,400	Dallas-Fort Worth $36,700, Houston $43,900; Austin has the lowest point estimate of the three and the margins overlap, so no gap is statistically firm (Section 2)
Texas within the nation		
Arts and cultural production as a share of economic output, 2023	2.5%	4.2% nationally; Texas ranks 36th of 51 (50 states + DC), and of the eight benchmark states only Louisiana (2.1%) is lower (Section 8)
State music money awarded, claimed or appropriated, per resident	$0.32	New York $4.52, Tennessee $1.07, Louisiana $0.48, Georgia $0.00 (Section 8)
Federal shuttered-venue grants, Austin area	$238.4 million	Dallas-Fort Worth $415.0 million, Houston $224.8 million, Nashville $159.9 million (Section 8)

Sources: American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year public use microdata, employed adults 18 to 64 with positive earnings, for the shares and the medians; Census Bureau Nonemployer Statistics, NAICS 7115, with Census Bureau population estimates, for businesses per 10,000 residents; Bureau of Economic Analysis Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account for the output share; state statutes and agency reports, with Census Bureau population estimates, for money disbursed per resident; Small Business Administration award file, July 2022 vintage, for the shuttered-venue grants. How to read it: the middle column is the Austin or Texas figure and the right column is what that figure is measured against, with the section that develops the comparison in parentheses. Caveats: the three metro medians rest on small samples and carry wide margins of error; independent-artist businesses cover writers and other performers as well as musicians, so that count is a proxy for solo creative work rather than a count of musicians; the shuttered-venue metro groupings are built from recipient city names rather than official metropolitan boundaries, and they are not built alike, since the two Texas figures use multi-place lists while the Nashville figure covers the consolidated city only and so understates its metro; **the Austin and Houston totals should not be read as a ranking**, because several cinema-chain awards filed at Austin-area corporate addresses fund operations in other states, and removing the two clearest of them alone puts Austin below Houston (Section 8); shuttered-venue awards are nominal dollars, an exception to the deflation rule below, because every award falls in one program period; the per-resident state figures are money that left the treasury or was awarded, claimed or appropriated, rather than dollars authorised, which is why Georgia appears at zero; and the Tennessee figure combines film, television and music scoring because no music-only breakout exists, so it is an upper bound rather than a music-specific number.

Those are the two reference points. The rest of this section asks how much weight any one of those Austin figures can carry.

[8]The Census Bureau's American Community Survey Public Use Microdata Sample is the only federal instrument that identifies a respondent's detailed occupation and attaches survey weights that project the sample to a state or metro population. The Bureau makes the raw records available for reanalysis, and both shares here are ratios of person weights from the 2020–2024 five-year Texas file at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/`. Population: Texas residents 18–64 who worked in the reference week (ESR codes 1, 2, 4 and 5) and reported positive earnings; the musician cell restricts that population to Musicians and Singers, occupation code OCCP 2752. Both shares are computed on the same weighted denominator and so cancel any common weighting artefact.

[9]The Census Bureau's Nonemployer Statistics program tabulates every U.S. business with no paid employees that files a federal income-tax return with receipts of at least $1,000, and publishes county-by-industry counts at `https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemp.html`. The count used here is NAICS 7115, Independent Artists, Writers and Performers, per 10,000 residents for 2023, with resident totals from the Census Bureau's Vintage 2025 Population Estimates Program. That industry code covers writers and other independent performers as well as musicians, so the count is a proxy for solo creative work rather than a musician-only census; the same NAICS boundary applies to every county compared, so the ranking is internally consistent.

[10]The Bureau of Economic Analysis measures the arts-economy share of state output through its Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account (ACPSA), which reweights the national GDP accounts to isolate arts and culture value added; program page at `https://www.bea.gov/data/special-topics/arts-and-culture`. The Texas music-incentive figure is the Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program awarded in FY2026, per the Texas Music Office program page at `https://gov.texas.gov/music/tmir`. Both figures appear later with method and vintage in Section 8.

1.2 The 2022 music census dropped the income questions the 2014 one asked

The City of Austin's Music and Entertainment Division commissioned Titan Music Group to field a music census in 2014, and that instrument asked what people earned from music. It drew 3,968 self-selected responses.[11] Of the 1,883 respondents who identified as musicians, 68.4%, or 1,288 people, reported earning under $10,000 from music, a threshold worth $13,800 in 2025 dollars.[12] The 2022 successor census dropped those income questions. Its authors explain why in the front matter: working "with the guidance of the community," they removed questions from the 2014 survey "that aimed to quantify the income of music people in a way that turned off many respondents."[13]

The 2022 census's silence on earnings is narrower than it first appears, because other measurement of Austin musician pay continued through other channels. The City of Austin bought a commercial series that put median musician earnings at $17.49 an hour in 2016 and $17.68 in 2017.[14] A University of Texas research project led by Professor Eric Drott interviewed roughly sixty Austin musicians and reported that their annual incomes clustered around $30,000 to $35,000.[15] The Health Alliance for Austin Musicians, a local nonprofit that provides health-care access to working Austin musicians, publishes an annual impact report that names the household-income ceiling its clients must fall under to qualify.[16] None of these three sources was designed as a representative measurement of the Austin music workforce, and none is one.

Austin's own music census has not asked a musician what they earn since the 2014 fielding, whose income questions covered calendar 2013. The city has since relied on that 2013 figure, the three sources above, and federal series never designed to capture irregular self-employed performance income.

1.3 One quoted income figure is a sideman's 1981 salary

When no current number exists, people quote whatever number they can find. The clearest example is $15,475, quoted as an Austin musician's annual income. It originates in a February 2022 KUT public radio segment in which the bandleader Marcia Ball described her own payroll from four decades earlier: "if you had worked for me for a full year as my sax player did, you would have made $15,475."[17]

A related claim about Austin journalism deserves the same scrutiny, even though it favours this study's own

[11] Titan Music Group, LLC (for the City of Austin Economic Development Department, Music and Entertainment Division), *The Austin Music Census: A Data-Driven Assessment of Austin's Commercial Music Economy*, fielded late 2014, published 1 June 2015, with income questions covering calendar year 2013; https://austin.widen.net/content/om7zqn1qbx/pdf/Austin_Music_Census_Interactive_PDF_53115.pdf. Recruitment ran through Austin music-industry mailing lists and social channels, so respondents self-selected into the sample rather than being drawn by probability method; the census itself flags that limitation, and the microdata were never publicly released. Every share below is a sample share, not a population estimate.

[12] The 68.4 percent figure appears on page 74 of the Titan report; it is the share of the 1,883 self-identified musician respondents who placed themselves in the "under $10,000" band of the pre-tax calendar-2013 earnings question. Converted with the Bureau of Labor Statistics's Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers, U.S. city average, all items, series CUUR0000SA0 (annual-average factor 1.3829 between 2013 and 2025), retrieved from the BLS Public Data API at https://api.bls.gov/publicAPI/v2/timeseries/data/. Inflation adjustment matters more here than usual: a reader comparing the 2013 threshold against present-day earnings without adjusting would understate today's bar by about 28 percent, since $10,000 is that much below the $13,800 the line is worth now.

[13] Sound Music Cities, *Greater Austin Music Census¸ Summary Report*, published February 2023, printed page 2; https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-SUMMARY-REPORT-v13-optimized.pdf. The team removed the income-quantification items specifically, not every income-related question, and the 2022 questionnaire kept items on the composition of music income, on spending, on housing and on whether respondents expected to remain in Austin, all of which Section 6 uses. Like the 2014 fielding, the 2022 census is a self-selected online convenience sample.

[14] City of Austin open data, *Median Earnings of Creative Sector Occupations*, dataset 2qxc-8cme, at https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/2qxc-8cme.csv, retrieved 1 August 2026. The city purchased the underlying figures from the Creative Vitality Suite, a commercial subscription database maintained by the labor-market data vendor Lightcast (formerly Emsi Burning Glass) that combines federal Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics with self-employment tax records. The vendor publishes no methodology detail on how the two sources are joined, so a reader cannot audit the resulting hourly figure. The city's series covers Musicians and Singers for 2016 and 2017 only.

[15] University of Texas at Austin (Prof. Eric Drott et al.), *Support Austin Musicians*, project website drafted July 2024, https://supportaustinmusicians.org/final-summary/. Recruitment ran through Austin music-community contacts rather than by any probability method, the sample was about 60 non-random interviews, the project has no named lead author on the public write-up, and the summary has not been peer reviewed. It is the direction of the finding rather than the point estimate that this study takes from that source.

[16] Health Alliance for Austin Musicians (HAAM), *Annual Impact Report* series, 2014 through 2025, at https://www.myhaam.org/. HAAM's eligibility ceiling is a program-design threshold set by the nonprofit each year rather than a measurement of what its members earn, and its member roster is a self-selected subset of the Austin music workforce (those who applied for HAAM services), so the figure indexes program eligibility rather than typical musician earnings. Some HAAM reports also restate 2015 Austin Music Census figures alongside current impact data; this study takes only the eligibility threshold from HAAM, not the reprinted census numbers.

[17] Elizabeth McQueen and Miles Bloxson, "Marcia Ball on the economics of being a working musician in Austin then and now," KUT 90.5 and KUTX, broadcast 15 February 2022. Marcia Ball is a Grammy-nominated Austin bandleader whose regional touring band worked out of Austin in the early 1980s; the $15,475 figure is the annual salary she paid her saxophone player in 1981, recalled from her own memory

case. Reporters and advocates often say that Austin news coverage keeps recycling 2013 income data. This study inventoried thirteen Austin news items published after the 2022 census that touched on musician earnings or the music program, and that description is too strong: three cite an earnings figure at all, one of them the 2013 census figure, under a subheading that flags its own staleness.[18] Coverage moved from earnings to program spending, reporting grant totals, award sizes and city booking rates. The recycling did happen earlier: two of the five 2022 items in the same inventory restated 2013 census income statistics as current.

1.4 Four federal series count this workforce, and each misses a different part of it

What the federal statistics can and cannot see

Picture a working Austin musician with a part-time day job, a dozen bar gigs a month, a few students and some streaming royalties. Four federal statistical programs observe that person, and none observes all of her.

- **The wage survey asks employers, so it sees only payroll.** The Bureau of Labor Statistics's Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program (OEWS) is a semi-annual establishment survey run jointly by BLS and the state workforce agencies. Employers in the sample report the wage of every worker on their payroll and report nothing for the self-employed, who fall outside the sampling frame; the program describes its coverage at `https://www.bls.gov/oes/oes_ques.htm`. OEWS records 120 wage-and-salary musician jobs in the Austin metro in 2025, against an estimated 2,126 people with positive earnings whom the American Community Survey records as working as musicians here over 2020 to 2024. Across every musician row in the OEWS extract used here, covering Austin, Texas and the nation from 2005 to 2025, the program publishes an hourly wage and no annual one.[a]
- **The quarterly payroll census is built from unemployment-insurance records.** The BLS Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages (QCEW) tabulates every job covered by state unemployment-insurance law, drawing directly from the wage records employers file with the state; program page at `https://www.bls.gov/cew/`. Because it is UI-covered employment only, an unincorporated self-employed performer is outside QCEW coverage by construction. Performers who incorporate as an S-corp or LLC and pay themselves wages do enter QCEW, which is part of why the independent-artists industry code (NAICS 7115) shows any employment at all.
- **Nonemployer Statistics does see the self-employed**, and counts their businesses. The Census Bureau builds Nonemployer Statistics (NES) from federal tax returns filed by businesses with no paid employees and receipts of at least $1,000, and publishes county-by-industry counts and gross receipts at `https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemp.html`. It reports receipts before any expense, and no federal source records what a performer spends to earn them. Separately, the 501 respondents to the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census who answered every spending category report a median of $5,394 a year spent on their own music work.[b]
- **Only the American Community Survey asks people directly** and adds self-employment income to wages. The Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS) is a continuous household survey with about 3.5 million respondents a year nationwide; the Bureau releases a Public Use Microdata Sample (PUMS) at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/` that lets analysts identify a respondent's detailed occupation, add wage and self-employment earnings on the same record, and attach person weights and 80 replicate weights for sampling error. Even ACS records one occupation per person, the current or most recent job, so a musician with a day job is counted as whatever the day job is.

The federal system measures this workforce continuously and undercounts it systematically. The more of a musician's income comes from gigs, teaching and royalties rather than from a payroll job, the less any of these series describes her.

[a] Annual mean and annual median are blank in all 63 musician rows of that extract, in every year and every geography. The Bureau states this as a standing convention for occupations with substantial part-year work rather than as intermittent suppression; the wage series therefore cannot be annualised from within its own tables. Any annual figure for Austin musicians built from OEWS would require assumptions about weeks and hours worked that OEWS itself does not supply, and this study does not construct one.

[b] Median from this study's own tabulation of the census microdata, dataset `an3p-3yqx` at `https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/an3p-3yqx.csv`, deflated to 2025 dollars with the CPI-U. The 2022 census is a self-selected online convenience sample with no survey weights, so this median describes the 501 respondents who answered the item rather than any wider population; it counts people rather than businesses, so it cannot be netted against NES receipts.

The pattern already shows up in Austin's own numbers. Two hourly-wage series for the same occupation, in the same metro, in the same year disagree by almost half. The City of Austin's purchased Creative Vitality Suite figure for Musicians and Singers in the Austin metro in 2017 was $17.68 an hour, against $31.03 an hour in the BLS Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics tabulation for the same occupation, metro and year: the purchased

and payroll rather than measured by any survey. The station's next sentence restated the figure in the present tense. A full-text search of every document this study gathered found the number in that KUT article and nowhere else; it appears in neither Austin Music Census and did not travel beyond its source. The KUT segment carried the number forward to about $47,865 in 2022 dollars; chaining the Bureau of Labor Statistics Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (series CUUR0000SA0) from its 1981 annual average to its 2025 annual average puts the 1981 salary at roughly $54,000 in 2025 dollars, which inverts the argument the figure is usually used to support.

[18] This study keeps that inventory in its Austin press-coverage evidence folder (`01_evidence/09_austin_press`), which the technical appendix describes in full. It was assembled by keyword search across the archives of KUT, KUTX, the *Austin Chronicle*, the *Austin American-Statesman*, *Austin Monitor* and *CultureMap Austin*, and it is a curated sample of coverage rather than an exhaustive census. Any share drawn from it is a share of the items this study gathered, not of Austin coverage generally.

figure came in at 57.0% of the federal one.[19] The federal series counts payroll jobs, and the purchased series appears to combine payroll wages with self-employment earnings, though the vendor publishes no methodology, so the size of the gap is a weaker piece of evidence than its direction. Section 3 returns to that disagreement when it asks what a one-bedroom apartment costs an Austin musician.

The 120 Austin jobs behind the federal series in 2025 are also a small base for a wage estimate, and that base size matters wherever this study uses the payroll wage: the Austin musician wage moves by several dollars an hour between adjacent years, so its level in any single year is uncertain. This study still uses the OEWS series, because nothing else records what payroll music jobs pay in Austin across two decades, and we suggest reading its direction over a run of years rather than any single year's value.

1.5 How this study keeps mismatched sources apart

The rules below apply to every number that follows. Each rule reports a source for what it measures, names the population behind the number, and keeps sources that measure different things in different sentences.

- Every dollar figure is adjusted for inflation to 2025 dollars using the Bureau of Labor Statistics Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers, U.S. city average, all items (series CUUR0000SA0), and the base year appears in every figure subtitle. Three kinds of figure are left nominal and are flagged as such where they appear: a ratio of two same-year dollar figures, where deflation cancels; a figure quoted as its source originally published it; and award totals whose payments all fall inside one program period.[20]
- Every American Community Survey estimate is reported with a margin of error computed by the Census Bureau's successive-difference replication method, using the 80 alternative person weightings the Bureau publishes alongside the main person weight (variables PWGTP1 through PWGTP80) so users can measure sampling error; the method and the replicate-weight file are documented in the Bureau's PUMS Accuracy of the Data at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/tech_docs/pums/accuracy/`. This study publishes no ACS estimate drawn from fewer than 50 unweighted records.
- The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census is a self-selected online survey with no survey weights, so its percentages describe the 2,227 people who answered it rather than the Austin music workforce as a whole; no margin of error is computable for any of them, and a probability-sample benchmark for the same population does not exist. Its shares never appear in the same comparison as an American Community Survey estimate.

Those rules cost the study some tidy comparisons. They are also why the Austin musician estimates in the next section come with wide margins of error.

2 What Austin musicians earn

The Census Bureau's American Community Survey (ACS) is the one federal instrument that interviews households directly, records the occupation of the person answering, and asks about self-employment income alongside wages and salaries.[21] That combination is what payroll surveys and administrative wage records cannot deliver: a payroll instrument sees only workers on someone else's payroll, and administrative wage records see only the

[19] City figure from dataset `2qxc-8cme` at `https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/2qxc-8cme.csv`; federal figure from the Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics May 2017 estimates at `https://www.bls.gov/oes/tables.htm`, SOC 27-2042, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA. Every dollar in this comparison is a same-year nominal figure, so no deflation applies.

[20] BLS publishes a bimonthly CPI for Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington, a bimonthly CPI for Houston-The Woodlands-Sugar Land and a monthly South regional series, but no separate CPI for Austin, so this study deflates Austin dollar figures with the national CUUR0000SA0 series retrieved via the BLS Public Data API at `https://api.bls.gov/publicAPI/v2/timeseries/data/`. No measurement in this study establishes whether Austin prices rose faster or slower than the national index over the period, so the direction of that substitution's effect on the estimates is unknown. October 2025 CPI collection was suspended during the federal funding lapse; the missing month is linearly interpolated in this project's file and flagged in the figures that touch it.

[21] The specific extract used throughout this section is the Census Bureau's ACS 2020–2024 five-year Public Use Microdata Sample (PUMS) for Texas, released 2026-03-05 and downloaded from `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/csv_ptx.zip`. The PUMS is the individual-record file that lets a researcher recompute any tabulation the Bureau publishes and many it does not; a parallel housing file supplies the household records used for the rent statistics later in this section. The Bureau samples roughly one percent of U.S. households each year and pools five successive samples to make small-cell estimates like the Austin-musician cell publishable, so the effective sample is the 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023 and 2024 waves stacked into one file. Musicians and singers are Census occupation code (OCCP) 2752; music directors and composers are OCCP 2751. The Austin metro throughout this section is the five-county Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos Metropolitan Statistical Area (Bastrop, Caldwell, Hays, Travis and Williamson counties), mapped from the survey's PUMA identifiers with the 2020 Census tract-to-PUMA relationship file. Employed status uses the Bureau's employment recode ESR in {1, 2, 4, 5} (civilian at work, civilian with a job but not at work, armed forces at work, or armed forces with a job but not at work).

covered universe of a particular tax or benefits program. Since Section 4 shows that most Austin musicians work for themselves, the ACS is the one instrument whose universe includes them at all. Every estimate below pools five years of Texas microdata[22] and apply two population definitions, each carried through to both sides of every comparison it enters. We compute the medians and the earnings regression on the positive-earnings base, employed adults aged 18 to 64 with personal earnings above zero. We compute the self-employment share, the health-coverage rates, the hours and weeks figures, and the earnings-threshold shares on the employed base, which drops the positive-earnings requirement so that people reporting zero or negative earnings from work stay in the denominator. Each figure below names the base it uses.[23] Margins of error come from the Census Bureau's replicate-weight method.[24]

2.1 Austin musicians earn about half what other Austin workers earn

Austin musicians report median personal earnings from work of $28,700 (+/- $9,400) against $62,500 (+/- $1,500) for all Austin workers on the same definition.[25] The estimation sample for the Austin musician median is 77 unweighted records over five survey years, enough to publish and not enough to break down further, so this study reports no Austin musician estimates by race, age or sex.

Figure 1 covers Texas, and what matters in it is less the ranking than the distance between each occupation's two bars. Actors show the widest pair, with total personal income roughly twice their earnings from work; musicians show a smaller but visible pair, and all Texas workers show almost none. The Austin cell shows the same pattern. Austin musicians report median total personal income of $36,900 against $28,700 in earnings from work. For all Austin workers the same two figures are $63,100 and $62,500, a difference of a few hundred dollars. The distance between two separately estimated medians is not any one person's non-work income, but it does say that Austin musicians as a group draw on income beyond their own work. The survey records income by source in seven separate fields (wages and salary, self-employment, interest and dividends, retirement, Social Security,

[22] We put dollar amounts on one basis in two steps, and the order matters. For person i the real value is $y_i = Y_i \times (\mathrm{ADJINC}_i/10^6) \times d_{2024}$, where Y_i is the amount as reported, ADJINC_i is the survey's own income adjustment factor for that person's survey year, which restates all five survey years on a common 2024 basis and is published with six implied decimals, which is what dividing by 10^6 removes. The second factor is $d_{2024} = C_{2025}/C_{2024}$, the ratio of Bureau of Labor Statistics Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U) annual averages, equal to 1.0270, and it carries 2024 dollars to this study's 2025 base. Housing dollars use the survey's housing factor, ADJHSG, in the same position. There is no merge on survey year and no year-specific deflator, because the survey factor has already removed the inflation inside the 2020 to 2024 window and applying a second one would remove it twice.

[23] Matching the base on both sides matters more here than in most analyses. Comparing musicians drawn from an unrestricted file, one that includes people out of the labour force and people reporting zero earnings, against a baseline restricted to employed workers moves the musician median from about $21,000 to about $12,800 on the mismatch alone. Every estimate in this section uses matched bases and reports the unweighted record count behind it.

[24] The Bureau's published variance method for this file is successive-difference replication, and it is the method it recommends for any statistic computed from the PUMS. We recompute every statistic on each of the 80 replicate weightings the Bureau distributes, and the spread of those 80 answers around the full-sample answer is the sampling variance:

$$\widehat{\mathrm{Var}}(\hat{\theta}) = \frac{4}{80}\sum_{r=1}^{80}\left(\hat{\theta}_r - \hat{\theta}\right)^2,$$

where $\hat{\theta}$ is the estimate computed with the full person weight PWGTP, $\hat{\theta}_r$ is the same estimate computed with replicate weight PWGTPr, and the constant $4/80$ is fixed by the Bureau's replicate design rather than chosen here. We take deviations around the full-sample estimate rather than around the average of the 80 replicates, the convention Stata labels `mse`, so the uncertainty on medians, means and regression coefficients in this section is directly comparable across statistics. The reported margin is $\mathrm{MOE}_{90} = 1.645\sqrt{\widehat{\mathrm{Var}}(\hat{\theta})}$, where 1.645 is the standard normal value that leaves 5 percent in each tail. Treating the records as an independent sample would understate the error substantially, because the Bureau's sample is clustered and its weights are calibrated to independent population controls. A small number of replicate weight cells are slightly negative, which the Bureau permits and which is an artefact of how the replicates are built; a weighted percentile is undefined with negative weights, so we floor the weight at zero inside the percentile calculation only, and means, shares and regressions use the replicate weights as published.

[25] The universe on both sides is employed adults aged 18 to 64 living in the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA with positive personal earnings from work, drawn from the ACS 2020–2024 five-year Texas PUMS. The musician cell uses OCCP 2752 (Musicians and Singers) and comes from 77 unweighted person records representing a weighted population of 2,126 people; the all-workers cell comes from 48,606 unweighted records representing 1.28 million people. Both figures use the Bureau's person weight PWGTP, so each record represents the number of people its weight says it represents. A weighted median is the smallest observed value at which the weight accumulated at or below that value reaches half of the total weight, $\hat{\theta}_{0.5} = \inf\{\, y : \sum_i w_i\, \mathbf{1}(y_i \le y) \ge 0.5 \sum_i w_i \,\}$, where y_i is record i's earnings in 2025 dollars, w_i is PWGTP, and $\mathbf{1}(\cdot)$ is one when the condition inside holds and zero otherwise; adjacent order statistics are averaged when the accumulated weight lands exactly on half. A weighted share of some group G is $\hat{p} = \sum_{i\in G} w_i a_i \big/ \sum_{i\in G} w_i$, with a_i equal to one when the record has the attribute being counted, so the denominator is the weighted size of the group and not the record count. Both are descriptive population estimates: they describe who the survey enumerated, and no statistical model stands behind them.

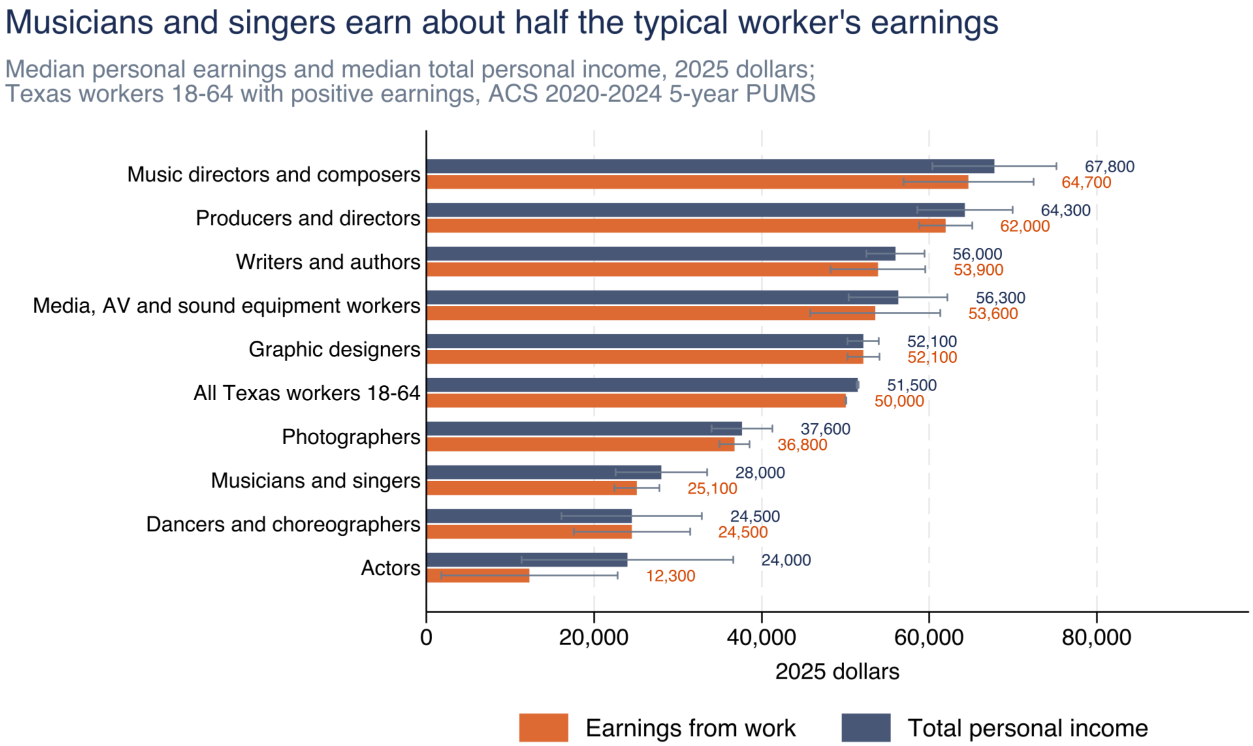

Figure 1: Median personal earnings from work and median total personal income by occupation, Texas workers aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings, 2025 dollars. Source: American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year public use microdata, person-weighted; whiskers are 90 percent margins of error from the 80 replicate weights. How to read it: the orange bar is what the work pays and the navy bar is total personal income from all sources, so the gap between them is income from somewhere other than the person's own work. Caveats: the survey records one occupation per person, so a musician who reports a day job as their main work is counted in that occupation instead; the combined media, audio-visual and sound-equipment category is a single Census code, not sound engineers alone.

Supplemental Security Income, and public assistance), and decomposing the gap into those fields would be a direct extension of the work here.

Hours worked do not account for the low earnings either. The median Austin musician reports a usual week of 40 hours (the survey variable WKHP) and 52 weeks worked in the past year (WKWN), matching 40 hours and 52 weeks for the median Austin worker. Both medians come from the same 77-record Austin cell and both equal the modal answers, so they say little about the tails: statewide, where the sample is larger, the median musician's usual week is 30 hours against 40 for all Texas workers. Firmer evidence comes from the regression below, which holds hours and weeks fixed and still leaves a difference.

To probe whether the raw gap comes from age, education, hours or geography rather than from something specific to music, we estimate a weighted least squares regression of log personal earnings on an indicator for music occupations, with the usual demographic and labor-supply controls and metro fixed effects.[26] Among employed Texans aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings from work, adjusting for age, sex, education, usual hours, weeks worked and metro area, music occupations show a -25.2% earnings difference, against a raw Austin shortfall of about half. Part of the raw gap therefore tracks those characteristics and part does not.

2.2 Most of this workforce works for itself

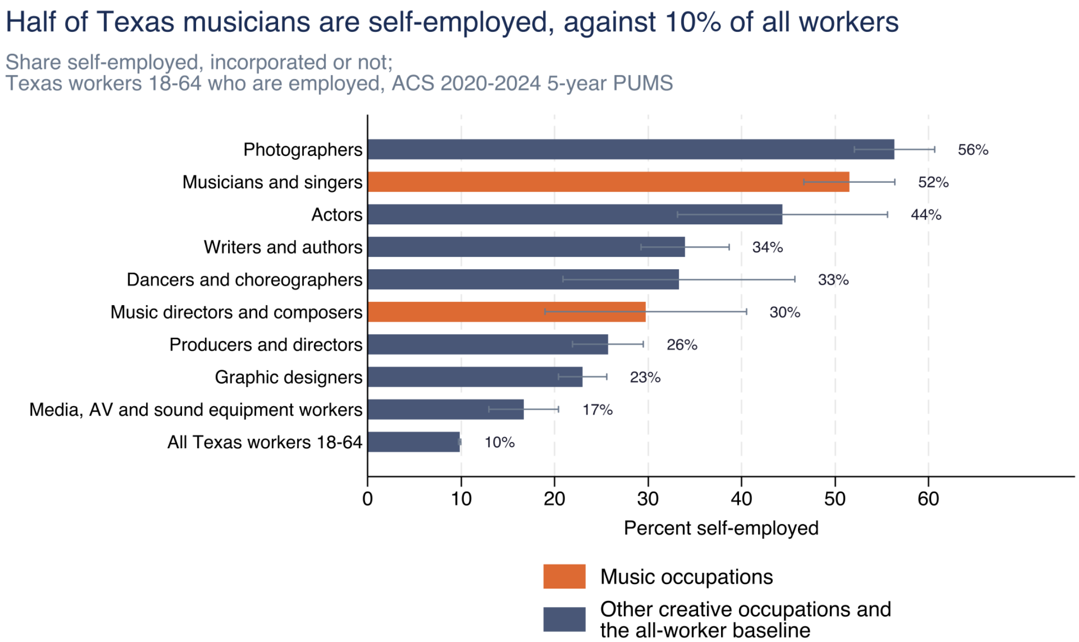

Figure 2: Share of workers who are self-employed, incorporated or not, by occupation. Source: American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year microdata, employed Texans aged 18 to 64; whiskers are 90 percent margins of error. How to read it: each bar is the share of workers in that occupation whose main job is their own business rather than someone else's payroll. Caveat: the survey records class of worker for the main job only, so a musician who also holds a payroll day job is counted under the day job.

72.2% (+/- 10.3 points) of Austin musicians work for themselves, against 10.4% (+/- 0.4 points) of all Austin workers, which makes an Austin musician about seven times as likely to be self-employed as the typical Austin

[26] The fitted equation is

$$\ln y_i = \alpha + \beta\,\text{music}_i + \gamma_1 \text{age}_i + \gamma_2 \text{age}_i^2 + \gamma_3 \text{female}_i + \sum_{k=2}^{5} \delta_k\,\text{educ}_{ki} + \gamma_4 \text{hours}_i + \gamma_5 \text{weeks}_i + \sum_m \lambda_m\,\text{metro}_{mi} + \varepsilon_i.$$

The dependent variable y_i is person i's personal earnings from work in 2025 dollars (the ACS PERNP field, deflated as described above). music_i is one when the person's occupation is musician, singer, music director or composer (OCCP 2751 or 2752) and zero otherwise; age_i is AGEP, age in years; female_i is one for women (SEX = 2); the educ_{ki} are indicators for four educational-attainment bands drawn from SCHL, measured against a base of less than high school (band 2 is high-school diploma or GED, band 3 is some college, band 4 is bachelor's degree, band 5 is graduate or professional degree); hours_i is WKHP (usual hours worked per week); weeks_i is WKWN (weeks worked in the past twelve months); and the metro_{mi} are Metropolitan Statistical Area indicators with the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA as the omitted reference, so each reported metro coefficient is a difference from Austin and the balance of the state enters as its own estimated term rather than as the base. ε_i is the residual. Estimation is by weighted least squares with the person weight PWGTP over the 554,672 employed Texans aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings, and the standard error comes from the same 80 replicate weights used for the medians, the Census Bureau's own successive-difference method, rather than from an assumption that records are independent. Because the dependent variable is in logs, a coefficient converts to a percentage difference as $100\,(e^{\hat\beta} - 1)$, and the same transformation applied to $\hat\beta \pm 1.96\,\text{se}(\hat\beta)$ gives the 95 percent interval. The music coefficient -0.290 with standard error 0.054 puts the 95 percent interval at -32.7 to -16.8 percent. Two things change at once between this estimate and the Austin medians above: the population is every employed Texan aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings rather than the Austin metro cell, and the occupation is musicians, singers, music directors and composers (OCCP 2751 and 2752) rather than musicians and singers alone (OCCP 2752). This is a descriptive conditional difference, not a causal estimate of what choosing music does to earnings: people who choose music differ from people who do not in ways the survey does not record, including talent, family resources and preference for the work itself. The full three-column table (metro fixed effects only, plus demographics, plus hours and weeks) is at `03_analysis/out/tables/table_earnings_regression.csv`, and the figures reported in this paragraph come from column (3).

worker.[27] Statewide the musician rate is lower, 51.5% (+/- 4.9 points) against 9.8% for all Texas workers, so the Austin estimate is well above the state estimate on a cell of only 77 records and should be read with that in mind.

Self-employment at that rate accounts for much of the distance between the payroll count and the survey count, though not all of it. Applying the Austin self-employment share to the 2,126 musicians the survey estimates leaves roughly 600 on someone's payroll, against the 120 jobs the federal wage survey recorded in the Austin metro in 2025.[28] It also explains why a payroll-based wage series can look healthy while a survey which counts self-employment income does not.

2.3 The distribution matters more than the median

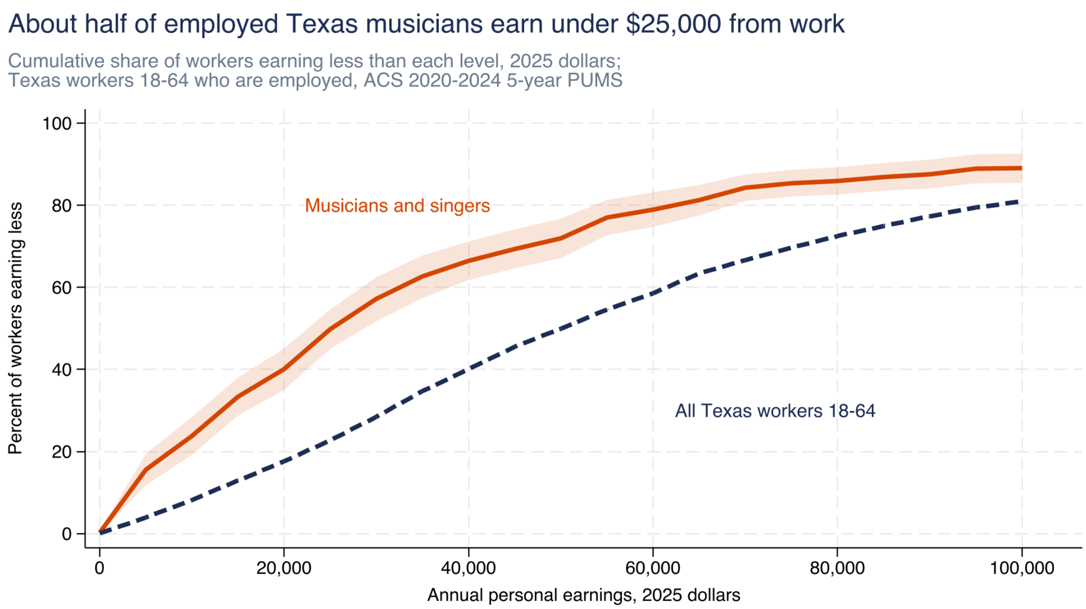

Figure 3: Cumulative share of workers earning below each level, musicians against all workers, Texas, 2025 dollars. Source: American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year microdata, employed adults 18 to 64 with positive earnings. How to read it: the height of a line at a given earnings level is the share of that group earning less than that amount, so a line sitting higher and further left means more of the group earns little. Caveat: earnings here come from all work, not from music alone, so a musician with a day job appears at the combined figure.

The spread below the median is wide. Figure 3 plots Texas, where the sample is large enough to draw a smooth curve; the shares below are for the Austin cell, which comes from 77 records and so has margins of error several times wider. 23.3% (+/- 11.3 points) of employed Austin musicians aged 18 to 64 earn under $10,000 from work, against 6.8% (+/- 0.3 points) of all employed Austin workers on the same base; 43.6% (+/- 12.7 points) earn under $25,000 against 17.5%; and 68.5% (+/- 12.1 points) earn under $50,000 against 39.5%. Measured against the threshold the 2013 Austin Music Census used to define low income, restated to today's prices,[29] 28.1% (+/- 11.3 points) of Austin musicians fall below the line that census drew, against 10.0% of the wider Austin workforce. That share is not comparable with the 2014 census's own 68.4 percent: the 2014 census measured music income

[27] Universe: employed adults aged 18 to 64 in the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA, ACS 2020–2024 five-year Texas PUMS. The numerator on both sides is class-of-worker categories 6 (self-employed, unincorporated) and 7 (self-employed, incorporated) from the survey's COW field; the denominator is the employed base on that geography. The musician share comes from 77 unweighted person records, so we do not break it down by demographic subgroup.

[28] The federal wage survey here is the Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS) program, a semi-annual establishment survey administered by BLS and the state workforce agencies. Program documentation: https://www.bls.gov/oes/oes_ques.htm. OEWS reports the wage of every worker on a sampled establishment's payroll and reports nothing for the self-employed, who fall outside its sampling frame; that is the arithmetic reason a survey which counts self-employment income and a payroll survey which does not disagree so widely on the same occupation and the same metro. Section 4 takes up the payroll count separately.

[29] The 2013 threshold is the $10,000 line the 2014 Austin Music Census applied to its respondents' 2013 pre-tax music income. Titan Music Group, LLC, for the City of Austin Economic Development Department, Music and Entertainment Division, *The Austin Music Census: A Data-Driven Assessment of Austin's Commercial Music Economy* (fielded late 2014; published June 1, 2015; income data are pre-tax calendar 2013), https://austin.widen.net/content/om7zqn1qbx/pdf/Austin_Music_Census_Interactive_PDF_53115.pdf. That census was a self-selected online convenience sample of 3,968 respondents drawn from the Austin music community; its published shares describe the people who answered, and no probability-sample margin of error attaches to them. Its microdata were never publicly released.

only, among self-selected respondents, while the ACS figure measures earnings from all work on a probability sample eight years later.[30]

2.4 Nothing suggests Austin pays musicians better than other Texas metros

Austin's median-musician earnings are lower than the medians in Dallas-Fort Worth and Houston, but only by amounts small enough that the sampling error in each metro cell easily covers the difference. These three metro figures pool musicians, singers, music directors and composers (OCCP 2751 and 2752), a wider grouping than the musicians-and-singers headline above, which is what makes the metro cells large enough to publish.[31] Median personal earnings from work in these pooled music occupations are $31,400 (+/- $9,400) in Austin, $36,700 (+/- $14,800) in Dallas-Fort Worth and $43,900 (+/- $16,000) in Houston. Austin has the lowest point estimate of the three, and every margin is wide, so neither pairwise gap is statistically firm.[32]

2.5 Austin musicians hold health coverage at roughly the workforce rate

Health coverage among Austin musicians is 90.1% (+/- 8.5 points) against 87.7% (+/- 0.4 points) for all Austin workers, a difference well inside the musician margin, so the two rates are indistinguishable at the sample sizes at hand.[33] Private coverage runs the other way: 77.9% (+/- 12.0 points) of Austin musicians hold private insurance against 84.7% for the wider workforce, so the any-coverage parity holds up on the strength of public coverage and of Austin's music-specific nonprofit health infrastructure rather than on employer-sponsored plans.

The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census reports that 84 percent of its respondents held health coverage in 2022, up from 79 percent in the 2014 census, and its authors attribute that five-point rise to the Health Alliance for Austin Musicians.[34] The Health Alliance for Austin Musicians, HAAM, is a 501(c)(3) launched in 2005 that enrols low-income working Austin musicians (a 400 percent-of-federal-poverty-line eligibility ceiling) in a coordinated network of primary care, dental, vision, mental-health and hearing services at subsidised fees.[35] SIMS Foundation, founded in 1995, delivers mental-health and substance-use care to Austin musicians and their families on a similar reduced-fee model.[36] The ACS does not identify HAAM or SIMS enrolees, so the coverage rate here is not causally attributable to either organisation, but the parity is consistent with what the census reports.

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[30] Each share is the weighted proportion defined above, $\hat{p} = \sum_i w_i \, \mathbf{1}(y_i < \bar{y}) \big/ \sum_i w_i$, where $\bar{y}$ is the threshold and y_i is personal earnings in 2025 dollars. These four shares use the employed base (employed Austin musicians aged 18 to 64), rather than the positive-earnings base used for the medians above: people reporting zero or negative earnings from work stay in the denominator, because dropping them would remove the worst-off cases from a statistic whose subject is how many people fall below a low threshold. The 2013 threshold is carried forward as $\$10{,}000 \times d_{2013}$, where $d_{2013} = C_{2025}/C_{2013}$ is the ratio of CPI-U annual averages, equal to 1.3829, which puts the line at $13,800 in today's prices.

[31] The pooled sample sizes are: Austin 91 unweighted records representing 2,553 people; Dallas-Fort Worth 191 records representing 4,505 people; Houston 117 records representing 3,453 people. Each cell is drawn from the ACS 2020–2024 five-year Texas PUMS, employed adults aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings, and each metro is its full five- or ten-county MSA as defined by OMB's 2023 core-based statistical area delineation. Musicians and singers alone (OCCP 2752) yield 33 Dallas records and 26 Houston records, both under the 50-record suppression threshold this study uses.

[32] Austin against Houston is a difference of about $12,500 against a combined 90 percent margin of roughly $18,600; Austin against Dallas-Fort Worth is about $5,300 against roughly $17,500. The margin on a difference between two metro medians is $\mathrm{MOE}_{A-B} = \sqrt{\mathrm{MOE}_A^2 + \mathrm{MOE}_B^2}$, where MOE_A and MOE_B are the two 90 percent margins computed from the replicate weights. The square-root form assumes the two metro subsamples are independent, which is the usual assumption for non-overlapping geographies in this file, and it is narrower than adding the two margins; a gap smaller than that combined margin is one the data cannot distinguish from zero. Nothing in these three medians supports an assumption that the Live Music Capital pays its musicians better than the rest of the state, and nothing in them establishes that it pays them worse.

[33] Both shares use the survey's HICOV variable, which is one when the respondent reports any health insurance coverage (private, public or both) at the time of the interview, and zero otherwise. Universe: employed adults aged 18 to 64 in the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA, ACS 2020–2024 five-year Texas PUMS; the musician side comes from 77 unweighted records (OCCP 2752), the all-workers side from 48,643. Private and public coverage are recorded separately (PRIVCOV and PUBCOV) and overlap for respondents who hold both, so those two shares do not sum to HICOV.

[34] Sound Music Cities and City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *2022 Greater Austin Music Census*, Data Appendix pp. 72–73 and Summary Report p. 10. Both comparison figures are self-selected respondent shares rather than population estimates, and the two censuses are not comparable samples, so this is a change in reported coverage among the people who answered rather than a measured change in the workforce as a whole.

[35] Health Alliance for Austin Musicians, *Annual Impact Report*, 2005 through 2025 series at `https://www.myhaam.org/annual-reports`. Retrieved 1 August 2026. Membership rose from 450 in 2005 to 3,136 in 2022 and 3,149 in 2023; cumulative healthcare value delivered rose from an initial-year figure of $115,000 in 2005 to $46 million (2015), $73.7 million (2019), $123 million (2022) and $215 million (2025), figures drawn from HAAM's own annual reports. HAAM publishes a member-income share-below-threshold rather than a member median, so the report does not treat its threshold statistics as earnings measurements of the wider Austin musician workforce.

[36] SIMS Foundation, at `https://simsfoundation.org/about/`, retrieved 1 August 2026.

2.6 Musician households in Texas pay a higher median rent when they rent

Among Texas households with a working adult, musician households and other working households rent at close to the same rate: about 41 percent of musician households are renters, against 39 percent of working households as a whole.[37] *Among renter households*, musician households pay a higher median gross rent than working households as a group.[38] The median monthly gross rent is $1,700 for musician renter households against $1,500 for renting Texas worker households. The rent level is higher, but the burden is not: 45.9% (+/- 8.9 points) of musician renter households pay more than 30 percent of household income in rent[39] against 44.4% (+/- 0.4 points) of working renter households as a whole, a gap well inside the musician margin. Read together: a musician-renter household in Texas signs a lease on a more expensive unit than the average working-renter household does, but pays roughly the same share of household income for it, likely because a second earner or non-earnings income (a topic Section 3 takes up) makes the rent-to-income ratio hold even as the rent bill runs higher. What the household file cannot say is why the rent bill runs higher, since the ACS does not record which parts of the metro a household lives in or which features of the unit drive its rent.

3 Austin is an average-cost city with expensive housing

What Austin musicians earn matters only against what living in Austin costs. Austin is often described in local reporting and in national coverage as an expensive city across the board, from groceries to rent to services, but the federal price record narrows that picture: Austin runs close to the national average on most goods and services and above the national average only in housing.[40] The Bureau of Economic Analysis publishes an annual price comparison across metro areas called the Regional Price Parities (RPP), which measures the price of a common basket of goods and services in each metro against a national average set to 100 and reports it separately for four component baskets, one of which is housing services.[41] On the 2024 BEA figures, Austin's all-items index is 98.1 against the national average of 100, marginally below the national average across all goods and services. Austin's housing services index is 120.4, so housing costs in Austin run 22.3 points higher than everything else does in the same city. That place gap is the widest of the five metros compared here, ahead of Dallas 14.8 points, Nashville 8.3 points, Houston 5.9 points, and San Antonio essentially none at -0.1 points.[42]

The national price record shows the same relative movement over time, in a different measure. The Bureau of

[37] Renter shares are weighted-household ratios computed from the ACS 2020–2024 five-year Texas PUMS housing extract, using registered renter and owner weighted counts, so the two shares are computed on comparable denominators; the small difference is well inside the musician margin. Age composition is also similar: median age of the two household references is close, so tenure differences do not reduce to a younger-therefore-not-yet-owning composition effect at the level the household file can measure. The Austin metro sub-cell is too small to publish tenure shares for.

[38] The rent statistics come from the ACS housing extract for Texas (2020–2024 five-year PUMS), a separate file with its own household weight WGTP and its own 80 replicate weights (WGTP1–WGTP80), used in the same successive-difference formula as above. Rent is put on 2025 dollars by ADJHSG (which restates the five survey years on a 2024 basis) and the same CPI-U 2024-to-2025 factor. Universe: Texas households with at least one employed resident aged 18 to 64. A household counts as a musician household when at least one of those employed residents reports OCCP 2752 (Musicians and Singers) as their current or most recent occupation; the comparison group is every Texas household with at least one employed resident, so the two groups nest rather than partition, and the comparison is musician households against all working households, not against a mutually exclusive remainder. The two sample sizes are 160 unweighted musician-renter households (representing 4,552 weighted households) and 101,799 unweighted worker-renter households (representing 3.14 million). Both figures are Texas households rather than Austin ones, because the Austin-only musician cell is too small in the household file to publish.

[39] The rent-burden variable is GRPIP, gross rent as a percentage of household income, computed by the Bureau from monthly gross rent (GRNTP, which is contract rent plus tenant-paid utilities) and household income (HINCP). GRPIP is a ratio of two same-year quantities, so no inflation adjustment applies; it is top-coded at 101, a category the Bureau also uses for households reporting zero or negative income. The 30 percent line is the standard federal cost-burden threshold used by HUD.

[40] Framings that treat Austin as broadly expensive appear in national coverage such as U.S. News & World Report's cost-of-living rankings and in Austin American-Statesman and Axios Austin coverage of city-affordability trends; this study does not enumerate that literature here, and the BEA Regional Price Parities cited in the next sentence are the federal counterpoint.

[41] The BEA program is the *Regional Price Parities and Implicit Regional Price Deflators by MSA*, currently released in its 2024 vintage covering years 2008 through 2024, and available from the Bureau of Economic Analysis at `https://apps.bea.gov/regional/zip/MARPP.zip`. The universe is the population of each metropolitan statistical area, and the basket weights come from the Consumer Expenditure Survey. Each metro's all-items index is a weighted average of the four component indexes, so the housing component and the all-items index sit on the same national base of 100 and their difference in the same metro is in index points rather than percent. BEA publishes no sampling error for these estimates because the underlying price series are themselves published indexes rather than sample statistics.

[42] The gap reported for each metro is $g_m = \mathrm{RPP}_m^{\mathrm{hous}} - \mathrm{RPP}_m^{\mathrm{all}}$, the difference in index points between that metro's housing parity and its own all-items parity, so it measures how much more expensive housing is than everything else in the same place rather than how expensive that place is against another one. Because both terms are indexed to the same national base of 100, the difference is in index points and is not a percentage. Austin's housing parity peaked at 126.4 in 2023, a peak year the two independent housing series in Figure 4 corroborate.

Labor Statistics tracks the price of a fixed consumer basket each month in its Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U), for a universe of the urban population of the United States, and reports the all-items index and its components on a common base.[43] Rebased so that each series equals 100 in 2005, the housing component reaches 177.3 by 2025 against 165.0 for all items, so national housing prices have risen 12.3 points faster than the broad basket since 2005.[44]

For Austin musicians the cost problem concentrates in housing, the one BEA category that prices well above the national norm in Austin. The rest of this section follows housing: what market rents have done since 2015, how many hours of work a month of rent costs at Austin wages, and why those two figures appear to disagree.

3.1 Rents rose sharply, then fell further than in any comparison metro

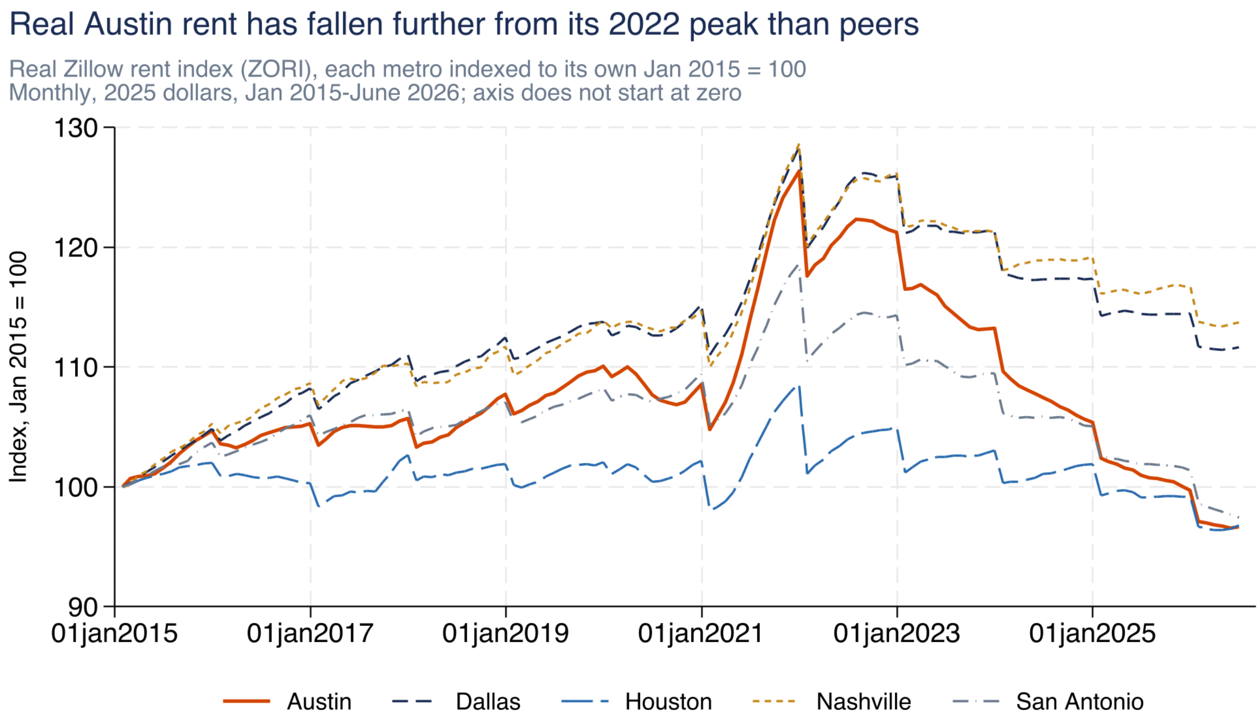

Figure 4: Real market rent indexed to each metro's own January 2015 level, 2025 dollars, through June 2026. Source: Zillow Observed Rent Index (ZORI), seasonally adjusted, deflated with the national Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers. How to read it: each line shows how far that metro's real rent has moved from its own 2015 starting point, so the lines compare trajectories rather than rent levels. Note on timing: Austin's real peak is December 2021, about a year before the widely quoted nominal peak, because deflating during the sharp inflation of 2021 to 2023 shifts the turning point earlier. Both readings are correct and answer different questions. Caveat: the small step every line takes at each January is the annual deflator changing, not a change in rents, because a single year-average price index is applied to twelve months of rent data.

Zillow's Observed Rent Index estimates the typical asking rent in each metro each month by weighting an internal repeat-rent index against local rental market shares, and it is the closest thing in the public record to a monthly Austin rent series, because BLS publishes no Austin-area consumer price index.[45] On that series, Austin's

[43] The series are the CPI-U All items (series identifier CUUR0000SA0) and the CPI-U Housing component, U.S. city average, monthly, and this study rebases each to its 2005 annual average and takes the 2025 annual average of each rebased series. Program documentation is available from BLS at https://www.bls.gov/cpi/. BLS publishes no Austin-area CPI at all, so every real-dollar figure in this report deflates by the national U.S. city average CPI-U, and given the RPP evidence above that Austin housing runs above the national norm, this national deflator most likely understates the true Austin price rise. The 2025 annual average of the housing component uses an interpolated October, because the federal funding lapse suspended BLS price collection that month.

[44] Rebasing on 2005 puts $I_t^s = 100 \times C_t^s / C_{2005}^s$, where C_t^s is the annual average of the CPI-U for series s, either all items or the housing component, in year t. Putting both series on the same base year is what makes them comparable, and the gap is the difference of the two rebased levels in 2025, $I_{2025}^{\text{hous}} - I_{2025}^{\text{all}}$, again in index points rather than percent. This national CPI comparison and the BEA metro parity above answer different questions and are not comparable in level: the CPI-Housing figure describes the national price rise for housing since 2005, and the RPP-Housing figure above describes where the Austin metro sits against the current national average.

[45] Zillow Group publishes the seasonally adjusted metro-level ZORI series at https://www.zillow.com/research/data/, together with

real market rent peaked at $2,108 in December 2021 and has fallen -23.5% since, the steepest decline among the five metros in Figure 4, with San Antonio the nearest at -17.8% and Dallas -13.0% and Houston -10.9%.[46] Home values fell further still. Zillow's Home Value Index (ZHVI), a repeat-sales estimate of the typical market value of a single-family home in the metro, records an Austin peak of $640,261 in June 2022 and a real decline of -34.9% from it.[47] A report that showed only the run-up and stopped in 2022 would be describing a market that no longer exists.

The federal housing-assistance benchmark moved differently. The Department of Housing and Urban Development publishes an annual Fair Market Rent (FMR) for each metropolitan area, one figure per bedroom count, and sets it near the 40th percentile of standard-quality rents in the area, using a rolling five-year window of American Community Survey responses updated with more recent private data.[48] HUD's Austin one-bedroom FMR peaked later, at $1,679 in FY2024, and has come down only -9.2% since.[49] Austin's assistance benchmark turned about two and a half years after the market series did. That lag matters for any program priced off the benchmark rather than off the market, and it is the larger part of the tension between the next two figures. The rest of that tension is that the payroll musician wage the next figure divides by fell back from an unusually high 2022 reading in the years HUD's FMR was still rising.

3.2 The payroll wage understates what rent takes from musicians

The federal payroll wage this figure divides into rent is the Austin-metro median hourly wage in the BLS Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program (OEWS), a semi-annual establishment survey that BLS and the state workforce agencies run jointly.[50] On that payroll wage, a month of one-bedroom rent costs an Austin musician 52.4 hours of work, against 60.3 hours for the median Austin worker in 2025 (Figure 5).[51] By that measure

a methodology document. The universe is rental listings on the Zillow platform, weighted to the U.S. Postal Service's count of the rental housing stock in each geography, so ZORI captures the rent asked on newly available units rather than the rent paid on all standing leases. It is not a probability sample of dwellings, and Zillow does not attach a sampling error to it. It runs monthly at the metro level and picks up cyclical turns faster than the Census Bureau's American Community Survey median gross rent, which pools five years of household responses and moves slowly by construction.

[46] The plotted series deflates each metro first and rebases second. The real level is $R^{\text{real}}_{m,t} = R_{m,t} \times d_{y(t)}$, where $R_{m,t}$ is the seasonally adjusted ZORI value for metro m in month t, $y(t)$ is the calendar year containing that month, and $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$ is the ratio of national CPI-U annual averages that carries year y dollars to 2025 dollars. The plotted line is then $I_{m,t} = 100 \times R^{\text{real}}_{m,t}/R^{\text{real}}_{m,\text{Jan 2015}}$, each metro against its own base month, which removes the level and leaves the trajectory, so metros at different rent levels can share one axis. The peak-to-latest change is $100\left(R^{\text{real}}_{m,\text{latest}}/R^{\text{real}}_{m,\text{peak}} - 1\right)$ on the deflated series. Deflating with an annual CPI-U during the sharp inflation of 2021 to 2023 is what moves the real peak about a year ahead of the nominal one: the step in d_y between 2021 and 2022 outweighs the further nominal rent increase in that year.

[47] Zillow Group publishes the metro-level ZHVI (all homes, seasonally adjusted) at the same research portal, https://www.zillow.com/research/data/. The universe is the middle tier of homes valued between the 35th and 65th percentiles in each geography, estimated monthly from Zillow's proprietary automated valuation model and transaction records. ZHVI is a market-value estimate rather than a transaction-price series, so it can move faster than recorded sales prices where turnover thins, and no sampling error attaches to it.

[48] The all-years FMR history is available from HUD at https://www.huduser.gov/portal/datasets/FMR/FMR_All_1983_2026.csv. The FMR is the reference point for what the federal Housing Choice Voucher program, and other HUD rental-assistance programs, will pay in each metro area. It is a benchmark, not an observed rent: HUD constructs it from ACS five-year survey data on gross rent for standard-quality units and then trends it forward with more recent private rent indexes. The universe is recent movers within the metro, so FMR turns later than a market series like ZORI. Two breaks in the source sit inside this study's window and make the peak date and the peak-to-latest change approximate: the nominal one-bedroom Austin rent jumps 18.0 percent between FY2023 and FY2024, the same year the file's percentile-basis field goes blank, and the FY2026 value is published for a redefined metro area, Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos rather than Austin-Round Rock.

[49] Both housing series in this subsection use the same deflator and dating rule as the market rent above, $F^{\text{real}}_y = F_y \times d_y$ followed by $100\,(F^{\text{real}}_{\text{latest}}/F^{\text{real}}_{\text{peak}} - 1)$, so both are in constant 2025 dollars. The hours-of-work ratio in the next subsection uses the same HUD Fair Market Rent in nominal dollars instead, because there the rent is divided by a same-year wage and deflating both sides would cancel.

[50] BLS publishes the OEWS Austin Metropolitan Statistical Area estimates in its annual tables at https://www.bls.gov/oes/tables.htm, the most recent vintage being May 2025. Establishments in the sample report the wage of every worker on their payroll but report nothing for the self-employed, who fall outside the sampling frame, so the Austin musician wage in this figure describes only the 120 musician jobs the 2025 OEWS Austin sample found on a payroll, and Section 1 develops that measurement gap in full. BLS does not publish an *annual* musician wage for any city or year because musician work is too irregular to annualise from an hourly rate, so the ratio here uses the hourly median.

[51] The ratio is $h_{o,y} = F_y/w_{o,y}$, where F_y is the Austin one-bedroom HUD Fair Market Rent for fiscal year y in dollars per month, $w_{o,y}$ is the Austin-metro OEWS median hourly wage for occupation group o in the same year in dollars per hour, and $h_{o,y}$ is therefore in hours per month. This ratio needs no inflation adjustment, and both sides are left in nominal dollars on purpose: multiplying numerator and denominator by the same factor d_y leaves $(d_yF_y)/(d_yw_{o,y}) = F_y/w_{o,y}$, so deflating would change nothing except to invite a mismatch of years. The two sides are matched within year for the same reason. BLS did not publish the musician wage for 2016 and the figure draws a straight segment across that year, so the 2015-to-2017 stretch of the orange line should not be read as an observed path. This is a ratio

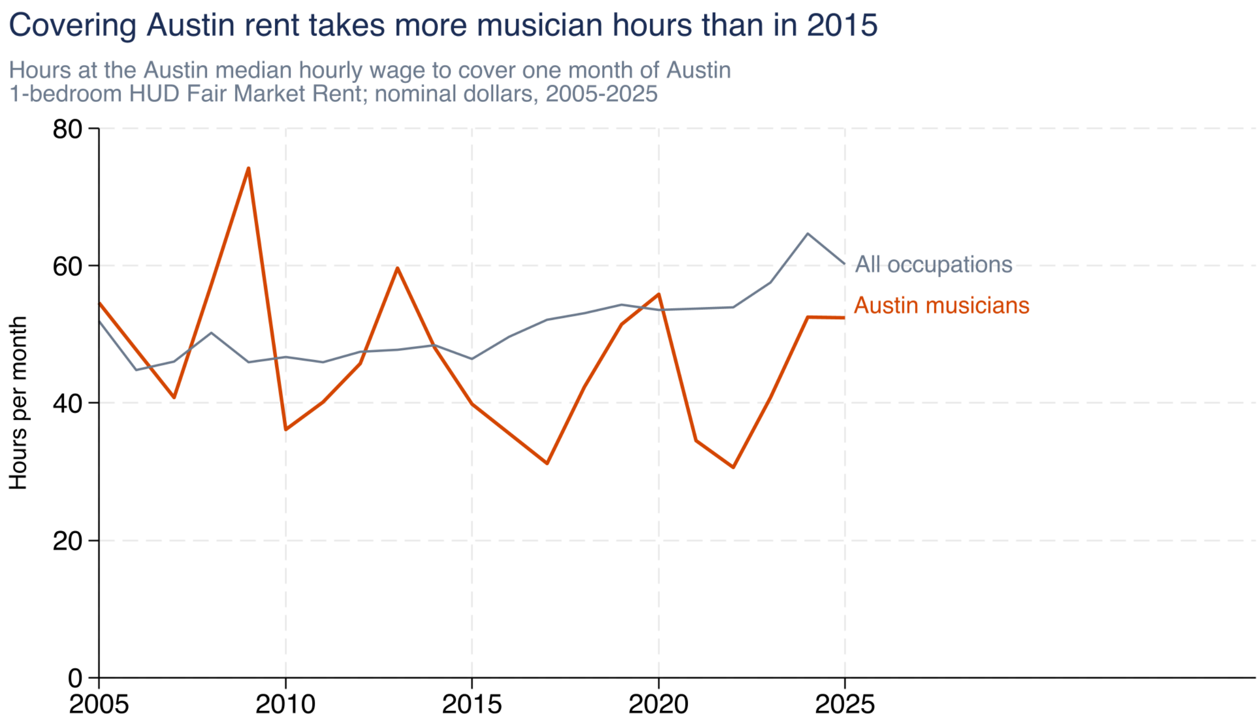

Figure 5: Hours of work at the median hourly wage needed to cover one month of Austin one-bedroom Fair Market Rent. Sources: Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics for the Austin metro; HUD Fair Market Rents; and the City of Austin's purchased earnings series, dataset `2qxc-8cme`. Wages and rents are matched within year in nominal terms, because the ratio of two same-year dollar figures needs no inflation adjustment. How to read it: a higher line means rent costs more hours of work. Critical caveat: the federal wage series counts payroll jobs only and excludes the self-employed, who are 72.2% (+/- 10.3 points) of employed Austin-metro musicians aged 18 to 64 over 2020 to 2024, and the Austin musician estimate rests on between about 100 and 700 payroll jobs depending on the year, and 120 in 2025, which makes it volatile from year to year. The city's own purchased earnings series, which appears to include self-employment income, exists for only two years and is not plotted; in 2017 it put musician pay at 57.0% of the federal figure for the same occupation.

Austin musicians look better placed than the typical Austin worker, because the OEWS payroll wage covers only the 120 musician jobs the 2025 OEWS Austin sample recorded, the measurement gap Section 1 describes, and those payroll jobs pay above the Austin all-occupation median. That ordering is a real feature of the payroll data and a poor description of the occupation, and on so thin a base the shape of the orange line across the full period is firmer evidence than the 2025 point on its own.

The picture changes when the earnings measure includes the self-employed. The Census Bureau's American Community Survey Public Use Microdata Sample (ACS PUMS) samples households rather than employers, so it captures earnings for the self-employed alongside payroll earners, at the cost of thinner samples in any single year.[52] Measured against ACS median earnings from Section 2, a year of one-bedroom HUD Fair Market Rent would equal 61.6% of the median annual earnings of employed Austin-metro musicians aged 18 to 64 over 2020 to 2024.[53] The numerator here is a benchmark rent rather than an observed one. Separate corroboration comes

of two published medians, not a sample estimate, so it has no standard error; its year-to-year movement still reflects sampling noise in the thin musician wage estimate underneath it.

[52]The ACS is an ongoing annual household survey the Census Bureau administers to approximately 3.5 million addresses each year; the five-year PUMS pools respondents across 2020 through 2024 to produce metro-level estimates on smaller occupations, at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/`. The Austin-metro musician cell used here is Musicians and Singers (occupation code OCCP 2752), employed 18 to 64 with positive earnings, weighted by PWGTP. Because the five-year file is one pooled cross-section rather than five annual observations, this share is a point estimate for the pooled period rather than a series that can be plotted year by year.

[53]The share is $s = 100 \times 12\bar{F}/\tilde{y}$, where $\bar{F}$ is the average Austin one-bedroom HUD Fair Market Rent across fiscal years 2020 to 2024 in 2025 dollars, the same five years the microdata pool, and $\tilde{y}$ is the weighted median personal earnings from work of Austin musicians in 2025 dollars on the positive-earnings base. Averaging the five fiscal years rather than picking one is what makes the numerator and the denominator cover the same period. The numerator is a housing cost for a dwelling and the denominator is one person's earnings, so s is affordability arithmetic rather than an observed housing outlay, and it carries the margin of error of the earnings median in its denominator. Measured against the FY2026 rent, which replaces $\bar{F}$ with that single year, it is 63.8%. Both are far above the 30 percent share the federal

from Section 2, which reports that across Texas, renting households with a musician in them pay a higher median gross rent than renting worker households generally, while carrying about the same rent-to-income burden. On that evidence, Texas musician households are not renting more cheaply than other working households.

3.3 Real market rents fell while the nominal assistance benchmark kept climbing through 2025

Figure 4 shows real rents falling. Figure 5 shows hours of work per month of rent rising between 2023 and 2025. Both are correct, and a reader who noticed the tension without an explanation would be right to distrust what follows. The two figures rest on different rents and different denominators, as the table below sets out:

	Figure 4	**Figure 5**
Rent measure	Zillow Observed Rent Index, a market listings series deflated to constant 2025 dollars and indexed to each metro's own January 2015 level	HUD Fair Market Rent for a one-bedroom in Austin, nominal dollars, the annual benchmark for federal housing-assistance payments
Wage denominator	None: the line plots rent alone	The BLS OEWS median hourly wage across the 120 Austin musician jobs recorded in 2025
Direction, 2023 to 2025	Down: Zillow market rents fell in real terms in Austin more than in any other metro compared	Up: HUD's benchmark kept climbing while the OEWS musician wage fell back from an unusually high 2022 reading

Where this study needs a single number for what renting costs in Austin, it takes the Zillow market series and says so. The hours-of-rent figure also rests on an OEWS payroll wage that describes fewer musician jobs than it once did, and Section 4 follows that count across twenty years.

4 Payroll music jobs have fallen; solo creative businesses have risen

The Bureau of Labor Statistics has counted fewer payroll musician jobs in Texas every survey vintage since 2005, and higher real hourly wages for the jobs that remain.[54] On its own that pattern reads as an occupation getting smaller and better paid. Set against the household microdata in Section 2, a second reading opens: the same work has moved out of payroll and into self-employment, which no payroll wage series covers. The last subsection here tests that reading against the timing of the two series and finds it weaker than a first look suggests.

In Texas, OEWS records 2,870 payroll musician jobs in 2005 and 1,430 in 2025, a change of -50.2% over twenty years. The same program records a national change of -28.2% over the same window. For the payroll jobs that remained in Texas, the real median hourly wage rose +55.7%, from $21.58 in 2005 to $33.59 in 2025, both in 2025 dollars (Figure 6).[55]

4.1 Solo creative businesses grew while payroll music jobs fell

The U.S. Census Bureau publishes a separate account of solo creative work through Nonemployer Statistics, an administrative tabulation the Bureau builds from federal tax filings rather than from a survey.[56] That series counts a different unit (a solo business, not a job) over a different universe (all independent artists, writers and performers,

government treats as the ceiling for a rental burden a household can carry without cost-burden status, which is a statement about arithmetic rather than a claim about any individual's housing.

[54] The Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program (OEWS) is a semi-annual establishment survey the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics runs jointly with each state workforce agency. Sampled employers report the occupation and wage of every worker on their payroll; a self-employed musician, a musician paid off the books, and a musician performing under an independent-contractor arrangement never enter the sampling frame at all. This section therefore reads OEWS as a payroll-only ceiling on measured wage-and-salary music work rather than as a count of the workforce. Program documentation at `https://www.bls.gov/oes/oes_ques.htm`; the tables read here are the May 2005 through May 2025 state and metropolitan estimates for Musicians and Singers, Standard Occupational Classification code 27-2042, published at `https://www.bls.gov/oes/tables.htm`. BLS does not publish an annual wage for this occupation in most cells because the work is too irregular to annualise from an hourly rate.

[55] Every percentage change quoted in this section is an endpoint change over the whole span, $100\,(X_T/X_0 - 1)$, where X_0 is the first year with a published value and X_T the last, so it is not an annual rate and it says nothing about the path between the two years. Job counts are compared as published, because a count of jobs is not a dollar figure and nothing in it needs deflating. The wage is deflated before it is differenced, $w_y^{\text{real}} = w_y \times d_y$ with $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$ the ratio of national consumer price index annual averages, so the change reported here is the change in purchasing power and not the change in the posted wage. Where a series has no published value for a year, the endpoints move inward to the first and last years that do, which for the Austin musician wage shortens the window. These are the OEWS program's own published medians and counts; BLS publishes no margin of error for these cells, so none is shown.

[56] Nonemployer Statistics counts business establishments with no paid employees and at least one thousand dollars of annual receipts (one dollar in construction), drawn from the Internal Revenue Service's business tax records: Form 1040 Schedule C for sole proprietors, Form

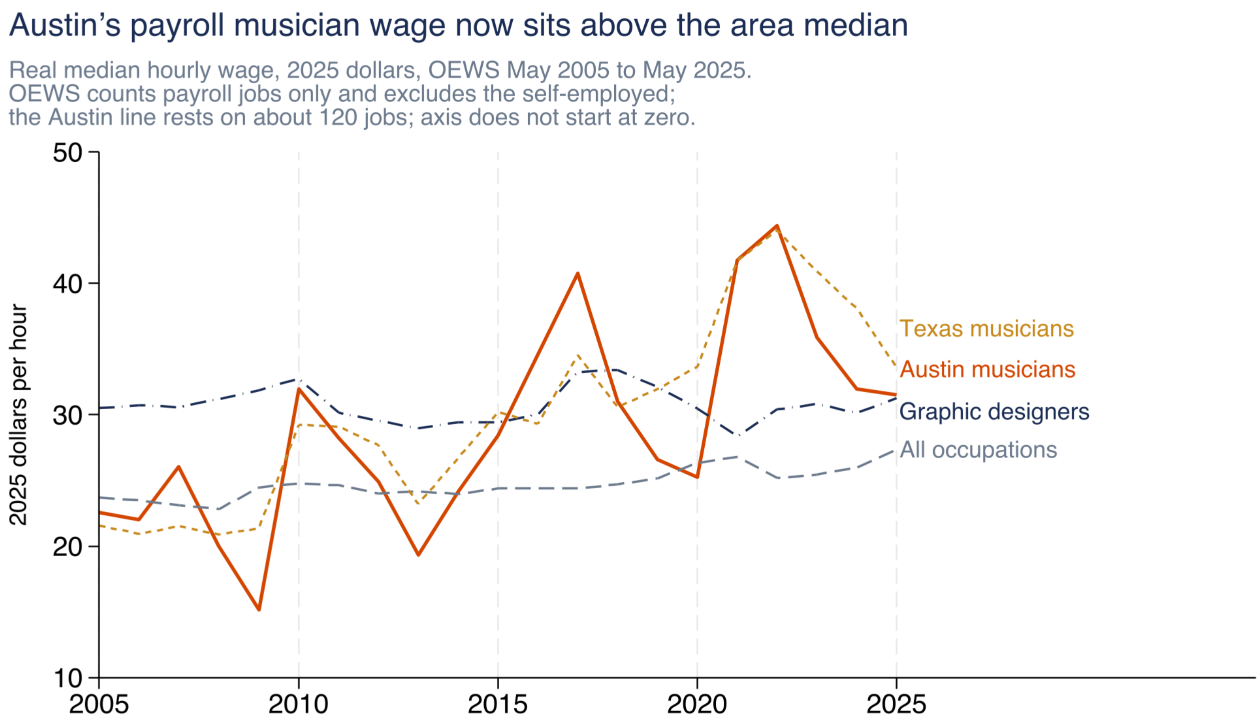

Figure 6: Real median hourly wage for selected occupations, Austin metro and Texas, 2005–2025, in 2025 dollars. Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2005 through May 2025 tables for Musicians and Singers (SOC 27-2042), deflated with the national consumer price index (CPI-U, annual average). How to read it: the axis does not start at zero. The Austin musician line swings widely because it rests on between about 100 and 700 payroll jobs depending on the year, so movements of several dollars between years reflect sampling variation rather than changes in what Austin musicians are paid. Caveat: OEWS excludes the self-employed by design, so this series describes a small and better-paid slice of the occupation rather than the occupation itself.

not musicians alone) than OEWS. The two files are therefore not additive, and Figure 7 draws them as separate panels so no reader adds them.

Nonemployer establishments in NAICS 7115 rose +61.6% in Travis County between 2012 and 2023 and +66.2% across Texas over the same window.[57] Texas payroll music jobs, measured over their own longer OEWS window of 2005 to 2025, changed -50.2%.[58] These two series do not count the same people. This study makes no estimate of the total size of the Austin music workforce, because no public source supports one.

Among the four large Texas counties compared here, Travis County has the highest rate of independent-artist businesses relative to its population: 64.26 nonemployer establishments in NAICS 7115 per 10,000 residents in 2023, against 28.63 in Dallas, 25.10 in Bexar and 22.60 in Harris (Figure 8).[59]

1065 for partnerships, and the corporate returns 1120 and 1120S. The sampling frame is therefore tax filings, not households or payrolls, so the file captures registered solo businesses that OEWS structurally cannot see but omits cash gig work that never enters the tax record. The industry code used here, NAICS 7115, is Independent Artists, Writers, and Performers, a category broader than musicians alone. County-level release: https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics/datasets/2023/historical-datasets/nonemp23co.zip. Program documentation: https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics.html. The Census Bureau protects county cells with noise infusion, adding small random errors to published values instead of suppressing them, which matters more for a county cell than for a state one.

[57] Nonemployer Statistics reports Travis County establishments in NAICS 7115 at 5,382 in 2012 and 8,696 in 2023, and Texas statewide at 45,021 and 74,834 over the same years. Both figures are business counts, not people, and the Bureau's noise-infusion procedure means a single county cell has a slightly larger measurement error than the state total.

[58] Figure 7 rebases each series on its own first available year, $I_{s,t} = 100 \times X_{s,t}/X_{s,t_0(s)}$, where $X_{s,t}$ is the level of series s in year t and $t_0(s)$ is that series' first year: 2005 for OEWS payroll jobs, 2012 for the Nonemployer Statistics establishment count. Rebasing is what allows two series measured in different units, jobs in one case and businesses in the other, to sit on a common vertical scale, and it is also the reason the two panels cannot be added or netted: an index number carries no unit and no count, only a direction and a rate of movement relative to its own starting point.

[59] The rate is $10^4 \times E_{c,y}/N_{c,y}$, where $E_{c,y}$ is the count of Nonemployer Statistics establishments in NAICS 7115 in county c and year y, and $N_{c,y}$ is that county's resident population in the same year, taken from the U.S. Census Bureau's Vintage 2025 Population Estimates Program release (https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/popest/datasets/2020-2025/counties/totals/). Both sides share a year, so

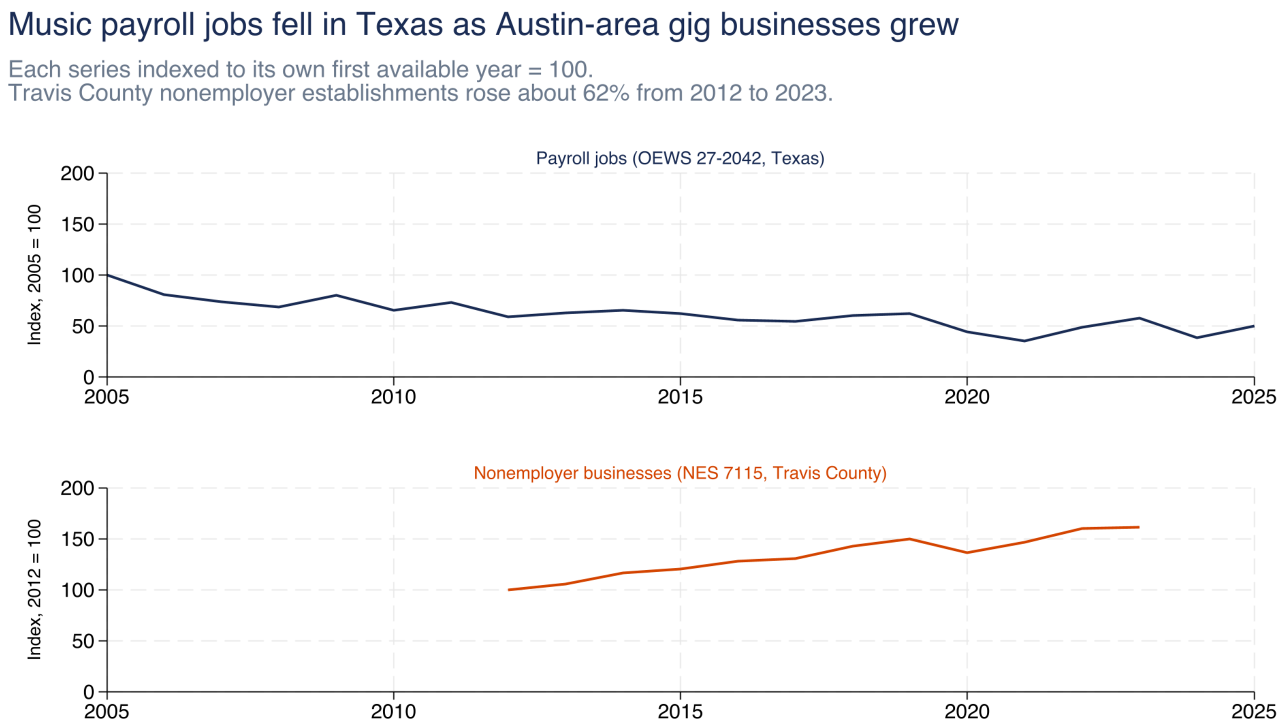

Figure 7: Payroll music jobs against independent-artist businesses without employees, each indexed to its own first available year. Sources: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, OEWS, for payroll employment in Musicians and Singers (SOC 27-2042); U.S. Census Bureau, Nonemployer Statistics, for establishments in NAICS 7115 (Independent Artists, Writers, and Performers). How to read it: the two series count different things over different universes, jobs against businesses and musicians against all independent artists, so the figure shows the direction each is moving and nothing more. The panels must not be added or netted.

Travis County's concentration of solo creative businesses is real; what those businesses take in is less clear. Nonemployer Statistics reports gross receipts before any expense: real receipts per Travis County establishment in NAICS 7115 rose +19.9% between 2012 and 2023, to $36,311 in 2025 dollars.[60] Alongside that receipts figure sits a separate reading of the cost side of solo music work. The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census, a self-selected online survey of Austin music workers with no probability sample behind it, asked respondents to report annual spending on their own music business across eight categories; the 501 music creatives who answered every one of those eight categories reported a median of $5,394 a year in 2025 dollars.[61] The receipts figure is Census Bureau administrative data on all Travis County solo businesses in NAICS 7115; the spending figure is a self-selected survey of Austin music creatives specifically. The two describe different populations in different years and cannot be subtracted from one another. They sit together here because a receipts figure alone overstates what a solo creative keeps.

the measure is a rate rather than a count and counties of different sizes can sit beside one another. The numerator counts businesses and not people, and one person can hold more than one, so this rate is a proxy for how common solo creative work is rather than a headcount of solo creatives. Four of Texas's 254 counties appear here, so the ranking is bounded by those four.

[60] Receipts per business is $\bar{r}_{c,y} = R^{\text{real}}_{c,y}/E_{c,y}$, where $R^{\text{real}}_{c,y}$ is total NAICS 7115 receipts in county c and year y, deflated to 2025 dollars by $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$, and $E_{c,y}$ is the establishment count. This is an arithmetic mean with no distribution behind it: the Census Bureau publishes only totals and counts for this category, so a small number of high-earning businesses can carry the average and no median is available. Noise infusion further complicates year-to-year comparisons at the county level.

[61] Sound Music Cities and City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *Greater Austin Music Census*, 2022; respondent-level microdata downloaded from City of Austin open data, dataset `an3p-3yqx`, at https://data.austintexas.gov/, retrieved 1 August 2026. The instrument was distributed through music-community mailing lists and city channels between 15 July and 12 September 2022, drew 2,227 respondent records, and carried no probability weights. The complete-spender base of 501 is 22.5 percent of respondents; the eight categories are gear and rentals, publicity and promotion, rehearsal or work space, new recordings, merchandise, supplies, web and social media, and accounting and legal. The median above is the median of respondent totals, not a sum of category medians.

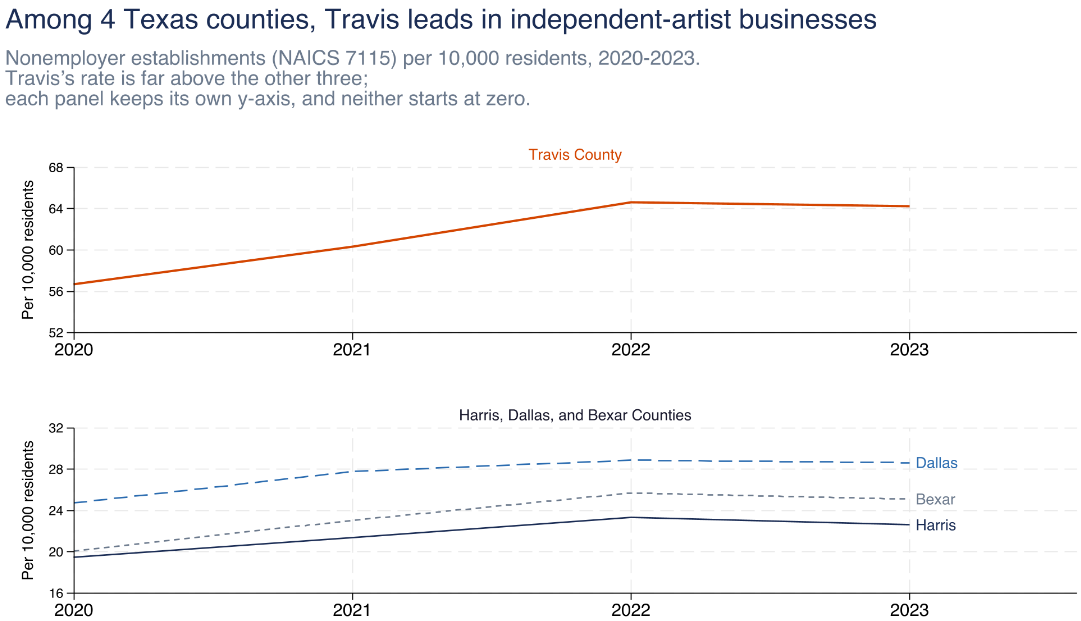

Figure 8: Independent-artist businesses without employees per 10,000 residents, four Texas counties, 2020–2023. Sources: U.S. Census Bureau, Nonemployer Statistics, NAICS 7115; county population from the U.S. Census Bureau's Vintage 2025 Population Estimates Program. How to read it: a higher line means more solo creative businesses relative to population. Caveats: NAICS 7115 covers independent artists, writers and performers together, so the count is a proxy for solo creative work rather than a headcount of musicians; the series is shorter than the 2012–2023 establishment counts because the population denominator comes from the Vintage 2025 estimates, which do not reach back to 2012; and four of Texas's 254 counties appear here, so the ranking is bounded by those four.

4.2 The substitution reading is an inference, not a tracked transition

The two series do not move in the same years, which weakens the reading that payroll music jobs became solo creative businesses rather than supporting it. Most of the Texas OEWS payroll decline happened between 2005 and 2012, and the payroll count has moved sideways since; the Nonemployer Statistics series begins in 2012, after that fall. What the two files show together is a payroll count far below its 2005 level and a nonemployer establishment count that has risen since 2012. Alongside them sits the ACS PUMS microdata finding that 72.2% (+/- 10.3 points) of Austin musicians worked for themselves over 2020 to 2024, which is a single pooled cross-section from a household survey and carries no time path of its own.[62] No public dataset follows individual musicians across employment arrangements, so nothing here shows that particular OEWS payroll jobs became particular Nonemployer Statistics businesses.

What the evidence does establish is narrower and still consequential: the number of music jobs any payroll statistic can observe is lower now than in 2005, while the count of solo creative businesses in the same broad category has risen since 2012, so payroll records describe less of Austin's music work than they once did. No public source estimates what fraction of Austin's music workforce now sits outside payroll records altogether, because no source combining the payroll and self-employed sides at the metro level exists. Section 5 turns from workers to workplaces, and tracks the Austin live-music rooms where those solo careers are performed, using the state Comptroller's monthly alcohol-tax filings as a room-level receipts record the payroll surveys cannot supply.

5 Austin's live-music capacity is shrinking through room loss rather than weaker trade

Musicians need places to play, and Austin's rooms are measurable in a way musicians themselves are not. The Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts collects a monthly filing from every business in the state holding a mixed-beverage

[62] Musicians and Singers (OCCP 2752), Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro, ages 18–64, employed (ESR 1/2/4/5), classified self-employed if Class of Worker equals 6 (unincorporated) or 7 (incorporated), from the U.S. Census Bureau's American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year Public Use Microdata Sample for Texas (`https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/csv_ptx.zip`). The share rests on 77 unweighted records; the margin of error uses the Bureau's successive-difference replication method against the 80 replicate weights.

permit (the state's license to sell liquor by the drink), reports each location's gross receipts, and publishes the file on the state open data portal.[63] This study matches those filings to named venues by taxpayer name and location address and follows a panel of 114 venues Austin live-music rooms monthly from January 2007 through June 2026, tracked across changes of owner and legal name.[64] With that panel this section asks whether the sector is contracting because surviving rooms trade worse than the rest of the licensed-beverage market, or because rooms close and no one replaces them.

5.1 Receipts fell at live-music rooms while the market around them added locations

Real receipts fell between 2019 and 2025 at the rooms the curated panel tracks: -7.0% across the 114 venues-room panel and -18.6% in its core live-music tier, the rooms whose main business is live performance.[65] The full Travis County and City of Austin mixed-beverage universe moved in the opposite direction over the same six years, changing +2.8% in real receipts, and the count of distinct permit locations filing during the year grew from 1,250 in 2019 to 1,631 in 2025.[66] Austin kept adding places to drink while its dedicated live-music rooms appeared to contract. Some live performance may also have shifted toward informal or non-dedicated settings this alcohol-tax panel cannot observe—coffee shops, restaurants, and breweries that host occasional acts—which typically pay performers less and less regularly, and are not where full-time musicians earn most of their income.

A separate City of Austin administrative record moves the same direction.[67] The Music & Entertainment Division issued 138 permits Outdoor Music Venue permits in both 2014 and 2017 at the series peak and 94 permits in 2025, a change of -31.9% from the peak.[68]

5.2 Surviving rooms lost ground, but no more than the rest of the market did

The aggregate gap invites an obvious explanation, that live-music rooms are weaker businesses than other bars. Rooms that stayed open did trade down: among the 63 venues venues filing in both 2019 and 2025, real receipts

[63] Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, *Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts*, Texas Open Data Portal dataset `naix-2893`, at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893, retrieved 2 August 2026. The population is every permittee filing under the mixed-beverage permit categories (MB, BQ, PE and their subtypes); the file is refreshed monthly and the extract used here covers obligation end dates January 2007 through August 2026. The dataset omits rooms operating on a beer-and-wine permit only, and it omits venues without a separable alcohol permit or folded into a hotel or nonprofit permit, so it undercounts several well-known Austin listening rooms; the panel construction below inherits those omissions. Every filing is a legal tax record rather than a survey response, which makes it a census of the licensed universe rather than a sample of it, and each row carries the permittee's taxpayer name, the location address and the reported gross receipts for the month.

[64] The panel is a *curated* tracking set of named Austin live-music rooms, not a census of the licensed universe and not a probability sample of it. Rooms enter by name identification against a research list of Austin live-music venues, so the panel over-represents established rooms in the central city (Red River, downtown, East Austin and South Congress), and it excludes venues without a separable liquor permit, which removes several well-known listening rooms including Cactus Cafe, Bass Concert Hall, Central Presbyterian, Carousel Lounge, Meanwhile Brewing, Whip In and Geraldine's. Receipts also measure alcohol sales rather than music activity: a room's mixed-beverage receipts say nothing directly about what performers were paid, only what the bar took at the register that month. Ten festival concession venue-months, in which a festival company filed under a venue-linked entity name for a month at a scale more than three hundred times the host venue's median month, are excluded from every venue-level figure that follows and are worth $43,290,954 in nominal dollars; the citywide totals used for comparison keep them, because there the money is real Austin licensed-beverage activity and only its venue label is misleading. The panel is compared against the full Travis County and City of Austin licensed-beverage universe throughout this section, and each comparison names the two sides in matching terms.

[65] Every filing is deflated before anything is added up: $R^{\text{real}}_{it} = R_{it} \times d_{y(t)}$, where R_{it} is venue i's nominal receipts in month t, $y(t)$ is the calendar year containing that month, and $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$ is the ratio of national consumer price index annual averages. Group totals are $S_{g,y} = \sum_{i \in g} \sum_{t \in y} R^{\text{real}}_{it}$, and the change quoted is $100\,(S_{g,2025}/S_{g,2019} - 1)$. Figure 9 plots the same totals rebased on 2019, $I_{g,y} = 100 \times S_{g,y}/S_{g,2019}$, which is why all three lines start at 100. These are totals over an unbalanced set of filers, so a group can fall because rooms closed as well as because open rooms took less; that distinction is the subject of the next subsection. Restricted to the 63 venues venues filing in both years, the change is -16.2%, and 48 of 63 of them were smaller in real terms in 2025.

[66] The two sides of that comparison are not built alike. The ten festival-aggregation venue-months are stripped out of every venue-level series but stay in the citywide market total, where the money is genuine licensed-beverage activity and only its venue label is wrong. On the same ex-festival basis the citywide change is about +1.6 percent rather than +2.8%. The citywide total also absorbs +30.5% more permit locations over the period, so it is not a per-room comparison; on a common basis, the tracked panel held 8.9% of citywide receipts in 2019 and 8.0% in 2025.

[67] City of Austin, *Sound Ordinance Permits*, Socrata dataset `ryu3-tuin` at https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/ryu3-tuin.csv, retrieved 1 August 2026. The Music & Entertainment Division issues an Outdoor Music Venue (OMV) permit under City Code Chapter 9-2 to any establishment that presents amplified sound outdoors, and the by-year counts used here are annual issuances tabulated from that permit file. The series is independent of the Comptroller receipts data because it is a city licensing series rather than a state tax filing, and it moves in the same direction as the receipts panel; that concurrence is why it is reported here.

[68] The change is $100\,(P_{2025}/P_{\text{peak}} - 1)$, where P_y is the count of outdoor music venue permits the City issued in calendar year y. A permit count is not a dollar figure, so nothing is deflated, and one room can hold several permits across years, so the series measures permitted outdoor music activity rather than a count of distinct rooms.

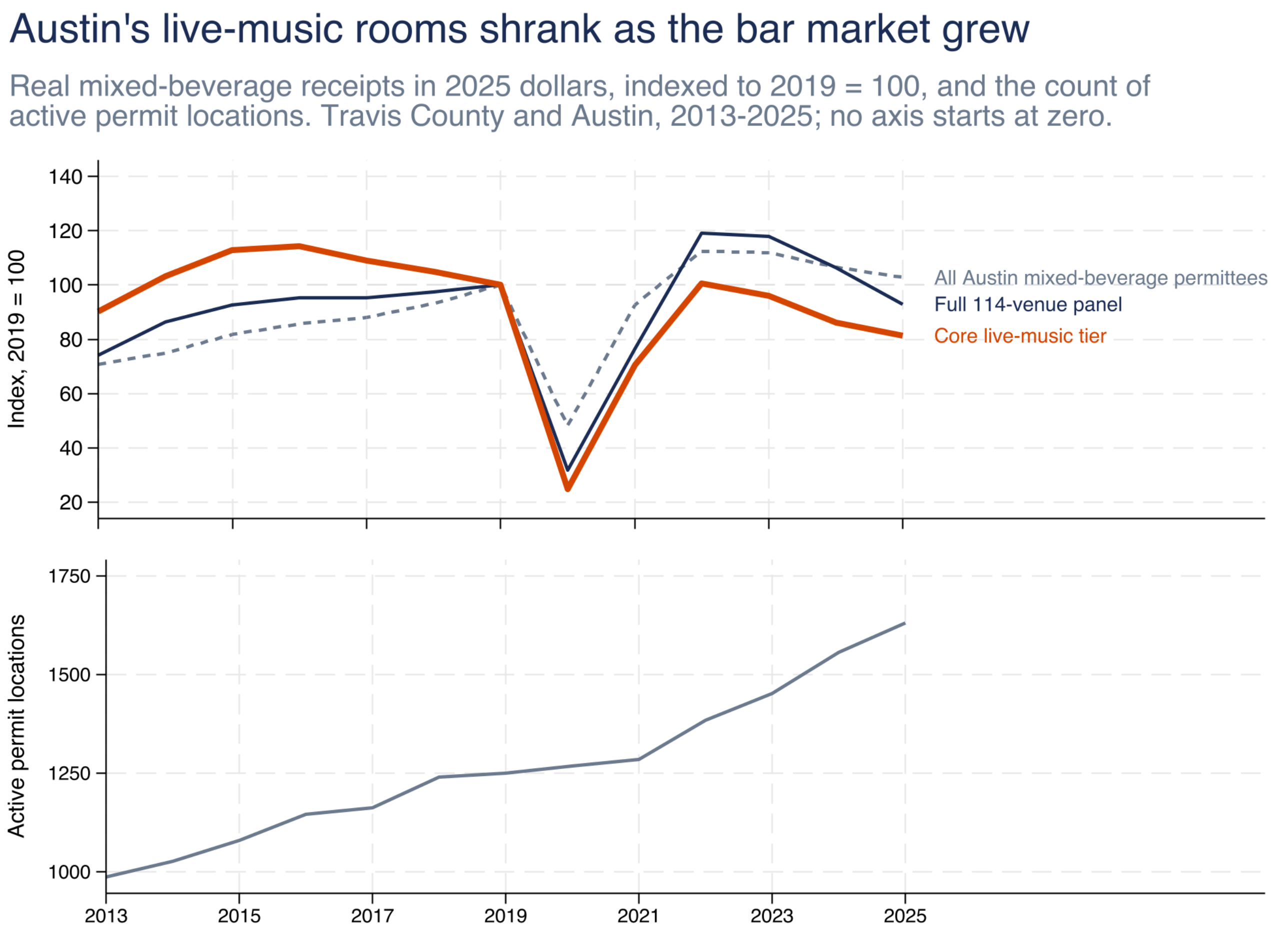

Figure 9: Real mixed-beverage receipts indexed to 2019, and the count of active permit locations, Travis County and City of Austin, 2013–2025, 2025 dollars. Source: Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, *Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts*, Texas Open Data Portal dataset `naix-2893`, matched to named venues by taxpayer name and location address and deflated with the national Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U, series `CUUR0000SA0`). How to read it: the upper panel compares three groups against their own 2019 level, so all three start at 100 by construction; the lower panel shows how many distinct permit locations filed receipts in each year. The three groups are the 114 venues-venue curated live-music panel; its core live-music tier of rooms whose main business is live performance; and the full Travis County and City of Austin mixed-beverage universe. Caveat: receipts measure alcohol sales, not attendance, ticket revenue or what performers were paid; the curated panel is not a census, so it is smaller and more central than the universe by construction.

changed -16.2% and 48 of 63 shrank. The 2019-to-2025 change by itself cannot tell whether the surviving live-music rooms fell further than the bars around them did, because the same 2019-to-2025 change at a citywide comparison group would carry the same seasonal weather, market-wide inflation and pandemic exposures that also hit the live-music rooms. The divergence test below strips those common shocks out, by holding each venue and each calendar month constant, and asks what is left after both sides have been controlled against themselves.

Comparing the core live-music tier against the rest of the Travis County and City of Austin mixed-beverage market before and after March 2020, with each venue and each month held constant, gives an average difference of 0.3%, and the 95 percent interval runs from about 14 percent below the rest of the market to about 17 percent above it (coefficient 0.003 log points, clustered standard error 0.077, $p = 0.9730$), across 171724 unit-months.[69]

[69]The specification is a two-way fixed-effects regression, meaning a linear regression that includes one intercept for every venue and one intercept for every calendar month, which together absorb any fixed characteristic of a room and any month common to the whole market. The dependent variable is log real monthly receipts, the regressor of interest is an indicator for core live-music venues interacted with the post-March-2020 period, and standard errors are clustered by venue (that is, they allow the residuals from the same room to be correlated across months, and treat venues as the independent units):

$$\ln R_{it}^{\text{real}} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \beta \left(\text{Core}_i \times \text{Post}_t\right) + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where R_{it}^{real} is venue i's mixed-beverage receipts in month t in 2025 dollars; Core_i is one for a core live-music room and zero for other

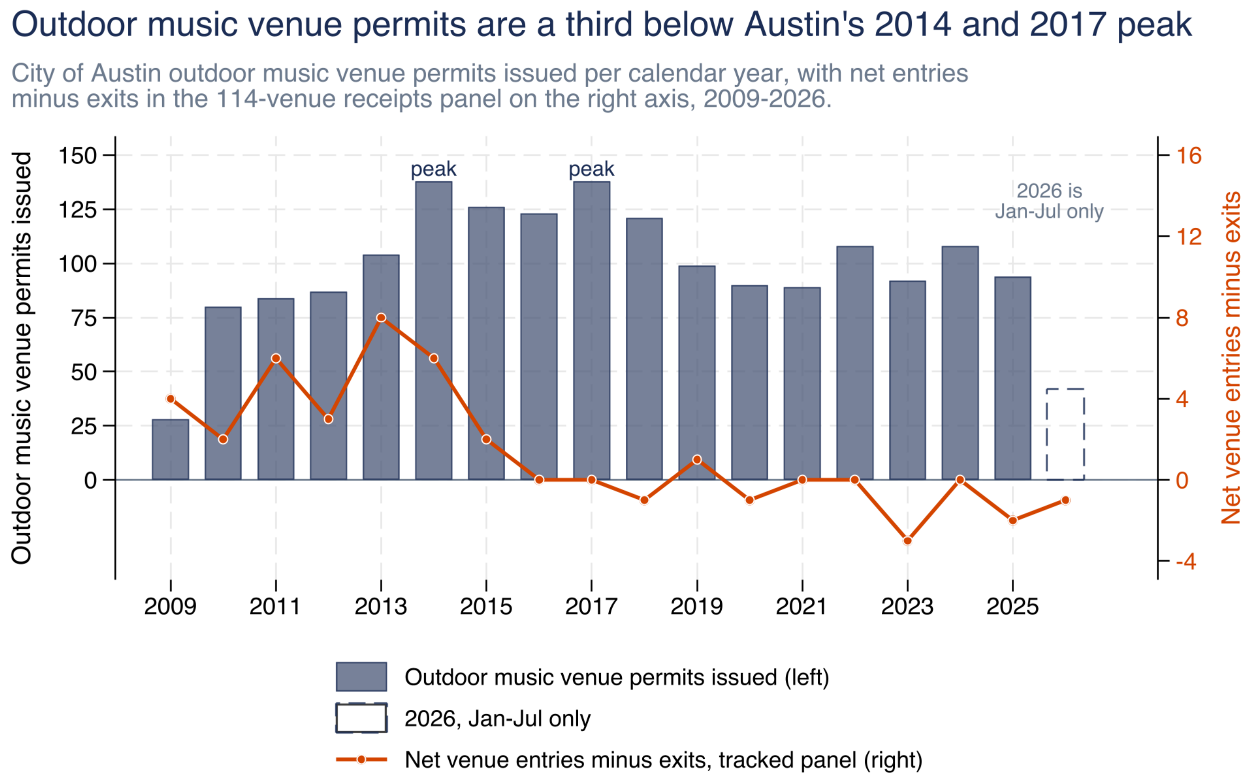

Figure 10: Outdoor Music Venue permits issued by the City of Austin each calendar year, with net venue entries minus exits in the curated live-music panel. Sources: City of Austin, *Sound Ordinance Permits*, Socrata dataset `ryu3-tuin`; Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, *Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts*, dataset `naix-2893`. How to read it: bars show permits issued on the left axis and the line shows net additions (entries minus exits) to the curated 114 venues-room panel on the right axis; the 2026 bar covers only the partial year available at extract. Caveat: a permit is not a venue, because one room may hold several across years, so the series measures permitted outdoor music activity rather than a count of rooms.

An event study, which is the same regression with a separate coefficient for each calendar year rather than one averaged post-March-2020 coefficient, gives the same reading year by year. Core live-music rooms dropped about 54 log points below the comparison group in 2020, returned to within statistical distance of it by 2022, and have tracked it since. The 2019 base is not a neutral reference, because the pre-2019 coefficients drift upward rather

mixed-beverage permit locations in Travis County or the City of Austin; the panel's live-music-adjacent tier is dropped from the estimation sample rather than coded zero, because those rooms programme live music intermittently and belong to neither the treated group nor the comparison group; Post_t is one from March 2020 onward; α_i is a venue fixed effect that absorbs everything constant about that room including its size, address and tier; τ_t is a year-month fixed effect that absorbs everything common to the whole market in that month including the pandemic, market-wide inflation and season; and ε_{it} is the residual. Only the interaction is estimable, because α_i absorbs Core_i and τ_t absorbs Post_t. The interaction is built as an explicit product variable rather than entered factorially: entered factorially it is collinear with the absorbed effects and Stata's `reghdfe` drops the term of interest. Estimation covers 171724 unit-months from January 2013 to December 2025. Months with zero receipts leave a log specification, so the coefficient describes venues conditional on trading at all. It converts to a proportional difference as $100\,(e^{\hat{\beta}} - 1)$. This is a descriptive divergence test: no policy switches on in March 2020 for one group and not the other, and nothing here is randomised. It is also a precise null rather than an absence of evidence: the 95 percent interval runs from about -13.7 to $+16.5$ percent, so a difference between core live-music rooms and the rest of the mixed-beverage market much larger than that in either direction is not consistent with these data.

than sitting flat, so a counterfactual that continued that drift would sit above zero after 2022 rather than at it.[70]

If the rooms that stay open trade no worse than other bars, the rest of the aggregate decline has to come from which rooms exist. 41 of 114 of the 114 venues tracked venues had stopped filing altogether by June 2026. 20 exits of those last filings fall in 2020 or later, and 16 of 20 of the post-2020 exits were core live-music rooms. Net additions to the panel (entries minus exits) came to +80 over 2007–2015 and -7 over 2016–2026.[71]

> **This distinction matters for policy.** Austin's live-music capacity is contracting because rooms stop filing and are not replaced, while the wider licensed-beverage market keeps adding permit locations. On receipts alone, rooms that stayed open trade at the same rate against 2019 as comparable non-music bars; the gap that separates the panel from the citywide total is not a gap in per-room revenue among survivors. The receipts file records what bars sell, not what venues spend, so it cannot say whether operating margins hold; it says only that the aggregate decline tracks which rooms exist rather than how the open ones sold liquor.

Panel venues with lower real receipts in 2025 than in 2019 appear in every part of Austin the panel can name (Figure 11). The ten largest dollar declines are concentrated where the panel's own coverage is concentrated: six sit downtown, on Rainey Street or in the Red River district, and the other four are in South Austin, in South Central and near the University of Texas campus. Because dollar size tracks venue size and the curated panel skews central by construction, that list of ten largest declines cannot be read as evidence about where decline is or is not spread within the city.

Between 2009 and 2018, permitted outdoor music activity concentrated in Council District 9, which covers downtown Austin and the central corridors, and District 9 accounted for 74.2% of the 1,029 permits Outdoor Music Venue permits the City issued in those years. Citywide, the Music & Entertainment Division's Outdoor Music Venue permits have since fallen -31.9% from their 2014–2017 peak, so the geography of permitted outdoor music activity may have moved since 2018. The curated receipts panel cannot test that distributional question independently, because its own coverage skews central by construction.

A separate news-derived timeline of 36 closures Austin live-music venue closures reported between January 2015 and June 2026, coded by primary reason, puts property pressure level with the pandemic: 13 of 36 closures cite COVID and 13 of 36 cite a property cause, meaning a rent increase, a sale of the building, a lease expiry or redevelopment.[72] Respondents to the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census who present live music, most of whom are not primary venue operators, ranked property tax first among the nine business pressures the census asked them to rank (Section 6). The two records both point at the cost and security of the building, though they measure different things: a tax on owners in the census answer, and rent, sale and tenure in the news timeline.

[70] The event study replaces the single interaction with one term per calendar year:

$$\ln R_{it}^{\text{real}} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \sum_{y \neq 2019} \beta_y \left(\mathbf{1}\{\text{year}(t) = y\} \times \text{Core}_i \right) + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where $\mathbf{1}\{\text{year}(t) = y\}$ is one when month t falls in calendar year y, 2019 is omitted, and every other symbol, the estimation sample and the clustering are as in the previous footnote. Each β_y therefore reads as the gap between core live-music rooms and the rest of the market in year y, measured against their own 2019 gap, and the 2020 term is the one quoted above. The year terms are constructed as explicit products with 2019 dropped by hand: asking the estimator to hold 2019 as the base is not honoured once venue and year-month effects absorb the alternatives, and it silently renormalises the whole path onto a different year. Pre-2019 coefficients drift upward instead of sitting flat, so parallel trends do not hold cleanly and the design is descriptive, not causal. A fourth specification in the exported table replaces the log with the inverse hyperbolic sine, which keeps zero-receipt months in the sample, and it returns a large negative coefficient rather than a null; that column answers a different question, conditioning on nothing rather than on trading, and no number quoted here comes from it, but a reader should know it points the other way. The full coefficient path is in the technical appendix.

[71] The two net-add figures are not built alike. The Comptroller receipts file begins in January 2007, so the 44 venues already trading then all register as 2007 entries; excluding 2007 entirely, the comparable 2008-to-2015 net is +36. The later figure is not left-censored but is right-truncated at June 2026. Ceasing to file usually means closure but can also mean a permit transfer, an entity restructuring, or a switch to a beer-and-wine permit, so these counts are stopped reporting rather than verified closures.

[72] The timeline lists 36 closures Austin live-music venue closures dated between January 2015 and June 2026, coded by primary reason from local news coverage in *Austin Chronicle*, *Austin American-Statesman*, KUT/KUTX, *Austin Monitor* and CultureMap Austin, plus follow-up items from *Do512* and *Texas Monthly*, compiled for this study and released as the project evidence file `01_evidence/08_venues_ecosystem/venue_timeline.csv`. Reasons are journalist-cited rather than audited, only the primary reason is coded when a venue reports more than one, and 3 of 36 closures have no reason stated in the sources examined. The timeline is a news-derived record rather than a register, so it misses venues the research team did not find coverage for, and an absence here means not found rather than nothing happened. A separate cross-check against the Comptroller mixed-beverage file found 11 of 36 venues still filing receipts after their reported closure date, which usually means the programming ended before the business did.

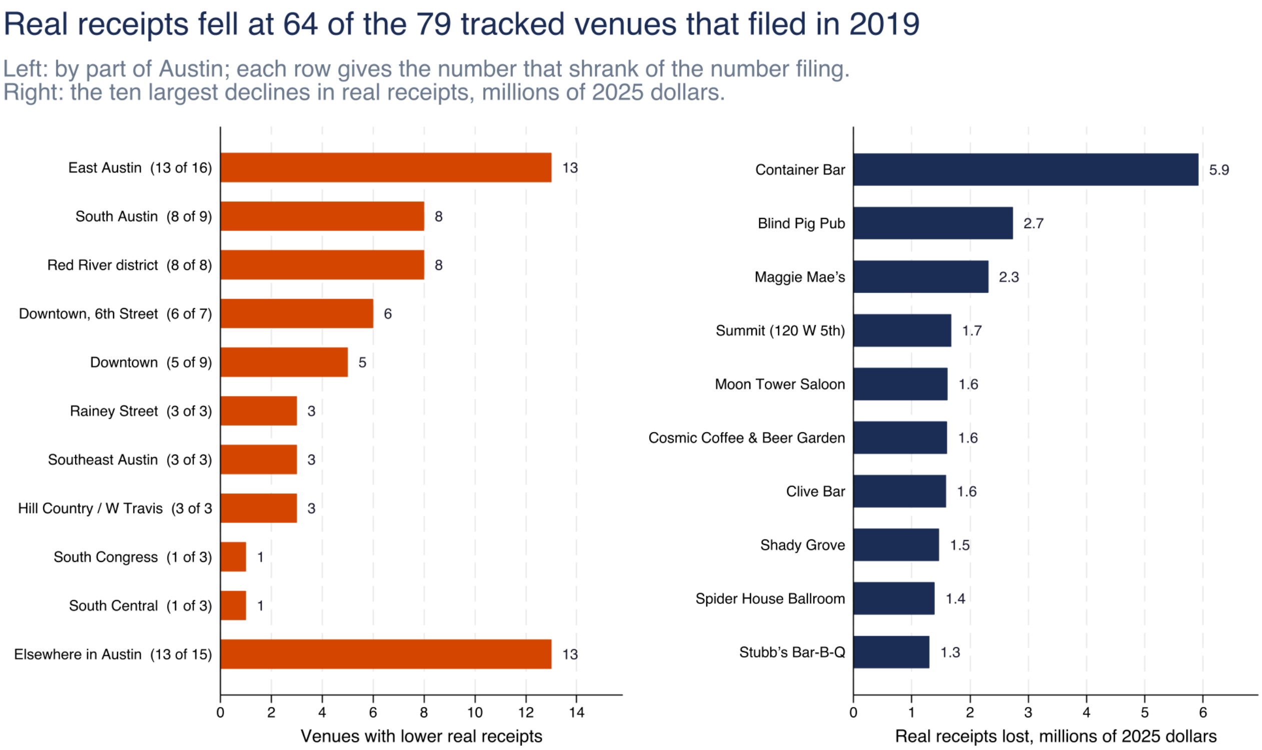

Figure 11: Venues in the curated 114 venues-room panel with lower real receipts in 2025 than in 2019, by part of Austin, and the ten largest dollar declines by venue name. Source: Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts, *Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts*, dataset `naix-2893`, deflated with the national CPI-U. How to read it: each row on the left gives the number of panel venues that shrank against the number that filed in 2019, so the denominators differ by area and several rows rest on only three venues; the right panel shows the size of the ten largest dollar declines by venue name. Caveats: named parts of Austin are assigned from venue addresses and are descriptive groupings rather than official boundaries; panel venues that stopped filing count as zero in 2025 and so appear as declines, which covers 16 of the 64 counted here, and three of the ten largest named declines are rooms with no 2025 receipts at all.

5.3 Three tests find no detectable change in the receipts

Each test below compares the panel venues exposed to a particular intervention against the rest of the mixed-beverage panel. The panel is the natural setting for these tests because each intervention hit a small, named set of Austin live-music rooms and left a monthly, room-level receipts trail on either side of the event, which is exactly what a before-and-after comparison against a non-treated group needs.

The 2017 extended-hours pilot. Five named Red River venues ran later outdoor music hours in 2017 under a City of Austin sound-ordinance pilot; the only ordinance text located names the pilot as a six-month experiment later extended to 30 April 2018.[73] Press accounts of a City evaluation reported a 22% rise in payments to local musicians, alongside 10 percent more local and regional acts booked and 13 percent fewer total tickets sold; the evaluation memo behind those figures has never been located and nobody has independently checked them. The Comptroller receipts contain no matching change in venue revenue. Once venue-specific seasonality is absorbed, which matters because six of the pilot window's seven months fall in the second half of the year, the estimate is 0.006 log points. The unadjusted specification gives -0.039 log points but fails its own pre-trend test. Randomization inference on the unadjusted specification, which asks how large an estimate the same regression produces when five other panel venues are labelled as treated at random, gives an exact $p = 0.6679$ across 5,000 placebo draws.[74] Nine in ten placebo assignments produce estimates inside roughly plus or minus 14 percent, so a receipts

[73]City of Austin, Law Department, *Draft ordinance amending City Code Chapter 9-2 (Red River extended-hours pilot)*, dated 30 March 2018, at `https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=296553`, retrieved 1 August 2026. The City evaluation memo referenced in the press has not been located, so the pilot window used in the reported city evaluation (May to November 2017) and the window the Law Department draft ordinance describes do not match; both are reported below.

[74]The specification is $\ln R^{\text{real}}_{it} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \beta\,(\text{Pilot}_i \times W_t) + \varepsilon_{it}$, where Pilot_i is one for the five named venues, W_t is one for the months of the reported pilot window from May to November 2017, and α_i and τ_t are venue and year-month fixed effects. The sample is the panel venues from January 2015 to December 2019 with the large ticketed rooms excluded. With five treated venues a cluster-robust standard error is not trustworthy, so inference is by randomization instead: the treatment dates are held fixed, five venues are drawn at random without

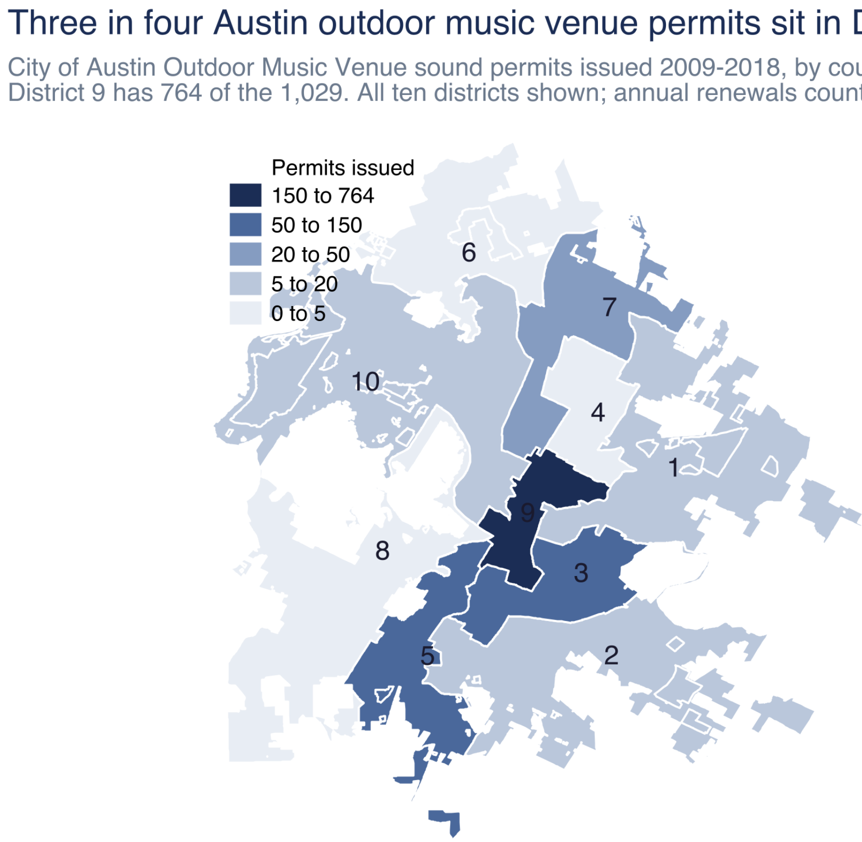

Figure 12: Outdoor Music Venue sound permits issued by the City of Austin, 2009–2018, by council district. Source: City of Austin, *Sound Ordinance Permits, geographic extract*, Socrata dataset `g3rj-dfgm` at https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/g3rj-dfgm.csv, retrieved 1 August 2026; council district boundaries from City of Austin open data. How to read it: darker districts issued more permits, and the class breaks are set by hand because the permit distribution is too concentrated in District 9 for equal intervals to separate anything. Caveats: annual renewals count as separate permits, so one room can appear many times and the map shows permitted activity, not distinct rooms; permits are assigned to the council district boundaries now in force, which took effect in January 2015, so the 2009-to-2014 permits are mapped retrospectively onto districts that did not exist when they were issued; and the series stops at 2018 because the geocoded file contains only a partial extract for 2019 (13 rows against the 99 the City by-year count reports).

effect much larger than that would probably have been visible here.[75] **This does not disprove the 22% claim.** Mixed-beverage receipts measure alcohol sales, not the door split between venue and performer, so a venue could raise what it pays performers by a fifth without changing its bar takings.

The 2024 Live Music Fund venue grants. The City of Austin awarded 17 venues Live Music Fund venue grants in fiscal 2024, all at the same dollar amount.[76] Against other tracked panel venues the estimate is 0.088

replacement from the panel venues filing in nearly every month of the window, the same regression is refitted on the placebo assignment, and the exact p-value is

$$p = \frac{1 + \#\{\, r \le R : |\hat{\beta}_r| \ge |\hat{\beta}| \,\}}{R+1},$$

where $\hat{\beta}$ is the estimate under the assignment that actually happened, $\hat{\beta}_r$ is the estimate under placebo assignment r, and R is 5,000, the number of draws. Adding one to numerator and denominator counts the observed assignment among the possibilities, which is what keeps the test exact rather than approximate. The bound quoted next comes from that same placebo distribution: 90 percent of placebo estimates fall inside roughly plus or minus 14 percent, so an effect larger than that would have shown. The five venues were named into the pilot rather than drawn into it, so this is descriptive.

[75] Pre-trends fail as first specified (p = 0.0003), but the cause is seasonality rather than divergence: the pilot window was six-sevenths second-half months. The pre-trend check replaces the single interaction with half-year terms, $\ln R^{\text{real}}_{it} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \sum_{h \neq h_0} \pi_h \left(\mathbf{1}\{\text{halfyear}(t) = h\} \times \text{Pilot}_i\right) + \varepsilon_{it}$, with the second half of 2016 as the omitted base h_0, and tests jointly whether the three half-years before the pilot are all zero, $H_0 : \pi_{2015\text{H1}} = \pi_{2015\text{H2}} = \pi_{2016\text{H1}} = 0$, by a Wald test with standard errors clustered by venue. Absorbing venue-specific seasonality, by adding a venue-by-month-of-year fixed effect that lets each room have its own December and its own March rather than only the seasonality the whole market shares, clears the pre-trend (p = 0.3551) and moves the estimate to 0.006. The reported May-to-November window also conflicts with the only ordinance text in hand, which describes a six-month pilot later extended to 30 April 2018.

[76] City of Austin, *Austin Live Music Fund, FY2024 Awardee List*, at https://austin.widen.net/content/bpzuacfkk8/pdf/FY24-AwardeeList_Austin-Live-Music-Fund.pdf, retrieved 1 August 2026. All 17 venues awards were made at $60,000. The full FY2024 award total,

log points, about 9 percent, with an exact randomization-inference $p = 0.4513$ across 2,000 placebo draws. No divergence between grantees and non-grantees is detectable in the years before the awards ($p = 0.2587$), though that window spans the pandemic and the parallel-paths test has little power with 15 treated venues; restricted to 2018 and 2019, the same joint test gives $p = 0.3557$.[77] Grants are competitively scored, so recipients differ from non-recipients in whatever the scoring rewarded, and the estimate is an association rather than a program effect. The 21 venue awards of the fiscal 2026 round cannot be tested at all: the city made those awards in March 2026 and the receipts panel ends that June.

The Moody Center. The Moody Center, a 15,000-seat multipurpose arena on the University of Texas at Austin campus, opened for public events in April 2022.[78] The test asks whether panel venues near the arena traded differently from panel venues farther out after it opened. Within four miles of the arena the post-opening pattern does not vary with distance ($p = 0.9111$). The design cannot say more than that: the comparison group is only six venues more than four miles out, every distance-band standard error is large, and no band is individually distinguishable from zero.[79]

These receipts describe what rooms sold at the register. They do not describe who played in them. Section 6 turns to the only current Austin-specific measurement of the people who work in those rooms, the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census, and takes up the retention question the receipts panel cannot answer. Federal pandemic relief, the one intervention with a visible signature in the mixed-beverage receipts, waits until Section 8, because that signature traces the eligibility rule rather than the program's effect and belongs with the state and national programs.

6 What musicians say about staying

Section 5 counted rooms. The only current Austin-specific measurement of the people who play in those rooms is the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census, an online instrument that Sound Music Cities fielded with the City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division between 15 July and 12 September 2022.[80] The 2022 instrument dropped

adding musician and non-venue promoter awardees, is 136 awards / $4,365,000 by independent line-item tally. Program mechanics and the fund's revenue source are the subject of Section 7.

77 The specification is $\ln R^{\text{real}}_{it} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \beta\,(\text{Grant}_i \times \text{Post2024}_t) + \varepsilon_{it}$, where Grant_i is one for a fiscal 2024 venue grantee and Post2024_t is one from January 2024 onward, on monthly observations from January 2018 to December 2025 with the large ticketed rooms excluded and standard errors clustered by venue. Grantees with too few filings in the base year to have a pre-period, and the one large room among them, leave the estimation sample, so the regression rests on fewer venues than received awards. The parallel-paths check is an annual event study with 2023 as the omitted base and a joint Wald test that the pre-award year terms are all zero, $H_0 : \beta_{2018} = \beta_{2019} = \beta_{2020} = \beta_{2021} = \beta_{2022} = 0$; that window spans the pandemic, so it asks whether the two groups followed the same path through it; the narrower 2018-and-2019 version quoted in the text rests on the 12 of 15 grantee venues already filing in 2019. Randomization inference draws the same number of placebo grantees from the venues meeting the same filing-coverage requirement and computes the exact p-value by the formula above, over 2,000 draws.

78 Moody Center, *About*, at https://www.moodycenteratx.com/about, retrieved 1 August 2026; opening event reported in local news coverage the same month. The arena competes for concert bookings at the top of the market rather than at the size of the tracked live-music rooms, so any spillover to the venue panel would appear as a proximity gradient in receipts, not as a shift in the market average.

79 All three bands enter one regression,

$$\ln R^{\text{real}}_{it} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \sum_{b=1}^{3} \beta_b \left(\text{Band}_{bi} \times \text{Post}_t\right) + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where Band_{bi} is one when venue i sits under one mile, one to two miles, or two to four miles from the arena, venues more than four miles away are the omitted reference group, and Post_t is one from April 2022 onward. Distance is straight-line miles from the arena's coordinates, computed by the great-circle formula $D = 2\rho \arcsin \sqrt{\sin^2(\Delta\phi/2) + \cos\phi_1 \cos\phi_2 \sin^2(\Delta\lambda/2)}$, with ϕ latitude, λ longitude, and ρ the Earth's radius in miles. The pre-period is January 2018 to December 2019 and the post-period July 2022 to December 2025, so neither period includes the pandemic. The quoted p-value is a Wald test of $H_0 : \beta_1 = \beta_2 = \beta_3$, which asks whether the post-opening pattern varies with distance at all rather than whether any single band moved; a continuous version replacing the bands with post-opening times log distance is registered separately, so nothing rests on where the band cuts fall. Standard errors are clustered by venue. Distance is not assigned at random: near venues are central-city rooms and differ from suburban ones in many ways at once, so this is a description of where the divergence sits. Note also that any market-wide arena effect is absorbed by the year-month fixed effects by construction, so this design tests proximity and not the arena's overall effect on venue receipts.

80 Sound Music Cities is the consultancy that has run the same instrument across a rolling cohort of U.S. cities since 2022 (Sacramento, Nashville, New Orleans, Washington D.C., Minneapolis, Cleveland, Baltimore, and others; the full roster is listed in the references). The Austin fielding was distributed through community mailing lists, the city's Music & Entertainment Division channels, and partner organizations. The city publishes the individual respondent records as an open dataset, *2022 Austin Music Census: Details*, Socrata identifier `an3p-3yqx`, at https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/an3p-3yqx.csv, retrieved 1 August 2026. The three Sound Music Cities reports that accompany the microdata (*Summary Report*, *Data Appendix*, and *DEI Data Appendix*) are the source for anything printed above the respondent level; the underlying 2,227 records are the source for this study. The Summary Report headline count is 2,260; the microdata release carries

the dollar-denominated income questions the 2014 fielding had asked, so it cannot say what a musician earns, but it kept a great deal else: work volume, workspace, tenure, insurance, business spending, three-year intent, and a ranked list of business pressures.[81] This study reads the census from the respondent-level file rather than the published tables, because a per-respondent construction is needed for two questions the printed report cannot answer: whether one person's two three-year answers move together, and whether the widely cited spending headline describes any actual person.

That file records 2,227 respondents across 107 variables. Every number in this section describes those respondents and not the Austin music workforce.[82]

6.1 Most respondents expect to stay in music; far fewer expect to stay in Austin

The same 1,900 respondents answered both three-year questions, so the comparison below is between one person's two answers rather than between two groups. 88.8% answered definitely or maybe yes to still working in music, and 64.1% answered definitely or maybe yes to still living in greater Austin, a within-person gap of 24.7 points.[83] Most of the complement to the Austin share is uncertainty rather than stated departure: among the 1,900 respondents, about a quarter answered "unsure" and roughly one in ten answered maybe or definitely no, which is a weaker claim than a third planning to leave.[84]

6.2 Housing tenure separates the answers most sharply; sector and workspace do not separate them at all

Who are the doubtful respondents? Of six respondent characteristics this study tested against the Austin-retention answer, housing tenure separates it most sharply: 75.5% of homeowners expected to stay in greater Austin against 52.3% of renters, with 63.2% of respondents in other or unstable housing situated between them.[85] Health

33 fewer rows and the release documents no reason. Every share in this section uses the 2,227-row microdata file, so a value here can sit a few tenths of a point away from a published percentage even where the two agree.

[81] The 2014 census, run by the same authoring team on behalf of the city, asked for calendar-year 2013 music income in banded form. The 2022 authors state that they dropped the item to raise completion rates and because respondents had told them the frame did not fit self-employed and mixed-income careers; see *Summary Report*, printed p. 6, at `https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/`. The consequence is that Austin's own music census has not asked what a musician earns for the twelve years running.

[82] The census was a self-selected online instrument with no design or post-stratification weights. It is not a probability sample of Austin's music workforce, and a probability-sample benchmark for the same population does not exist. Every share in this section is therefore a descriptive statistic on the people who answered, not a population estimate, and none is comparable with the American Community Survey estimates in Section 2, the Bureau of Labor Statistics wage series in Section 4, or the Comptroller receipts panel in Section 5. No standard error or margin of error is computed anywhere in this section. Item nonresponse is heavy and uneven, and several blocks were routed only to performers or only to venue operators, so every statistic in this section is reported against its own denominator. Six figures computed here reproduce the Sound Music Cities *Data Appendix* to within a percentage point (the two three-year retention shares, the mean and median distance travelled to work, the sum-of-means spending headline, and the local share of spending), which is the best available check that the file is being read correctly.

[83] Each share is an unweighted count over its own denominator, $\hat{p} = 100 \times n_{\text{yes}}/n_{\text{answered}}$, where n_{yes} counts respondents answering definitely or maybe yes and n_{answered} counts everyone who answered that item. A respondent who skipped the item is out of both numerator and denominator rather than counted as a no. The retention gap is the difference of the two shares on the same respondents, $\hat{p}_{\text{music}} - \hat{p}_{\text{Austin}}$, which is a within-person comparison and not a comparison of two groups. No weight enters anywhere in this section, because the release carries none, so no margin of error can be computed. Both retention shares reproduce the Sound Music Cities *Summary Report* p. 7 to the tenth of a percentage point on the microdata file.

[84] The Austin item's five options are definitely yes, maybe yes, unsure, maybe no, and definitely no. The full breakdown on the 1,900 respondents is 44.2% definitely yes, 19.9% maybe yes, 25.6% unsure, 6.7% maybe no, and 3.6% definitely no; the two shares combined into "definitely or maybe yes" produce 64.1%. Read the 25.6% unsure share as respondents who could not answer, not as respondents who leaned toward leaving.

[85] The homeowner–renter difference in expected-stay rates is unlikely to be chance among these respondents: chi-squared(2) = 84.2, p = 0.0000. The test is Pearson's chi-squared for independence in a two-way table, $X^2 = \sum_j \sum_k (O_{jk} - E_{jk})^2/E_{jk}$ with $E_{jk} = R_j C_k/N$, where O_{jk} is the number of respondents in row j and column k, R_j and C_k are the row and column totals, N is the number answering both items, and E_{jk} is the count expected if the two answers were unrelated. The number in parentheses after the statistic is the degrees of freedom, $(J-1)(K-1)$ for a table with J rows and K columns. In a logistic regression conditioning on primary music-ecosystem sector, years of experience, and health insurance, renters have 0.39 times the odds of expecting to stay in Austin that homeowners do, on 1,607 respondents who answered every item in the equation. The specification is

$$\ln \frac{\Pr(\text{stay}_i = 1)}{1 - \Pr(\text{stay}_i = 1)} = \alpha + \sum_s \beta_s \,\text{sector}_{si} + \sum_e \gamma_e \,\text{exper}_{ei} + \sum_h \delta_h \,\text{tenure}_{hi} + \theta\,\text{insured}_i,$$

where stay_i is one when respondent i answered definitely or maybe yes to still living in greater Austin in three years, the sector_{si} are indicators for primary music-ecosystem sector, the exper_{ei} for years-of-experience band, the tenure_{hi} for housing tenure with homeowner omitted, and insured_i is one for holding health insurance. The quantity quoted is the odds ratio $e^{\hat{\delta}_{\text{renter}}}$; a value below one means renters had lower odds of expecting to stay than homeowners who match them on sector, experience, and insurance. An odds ratio is not a ratio of

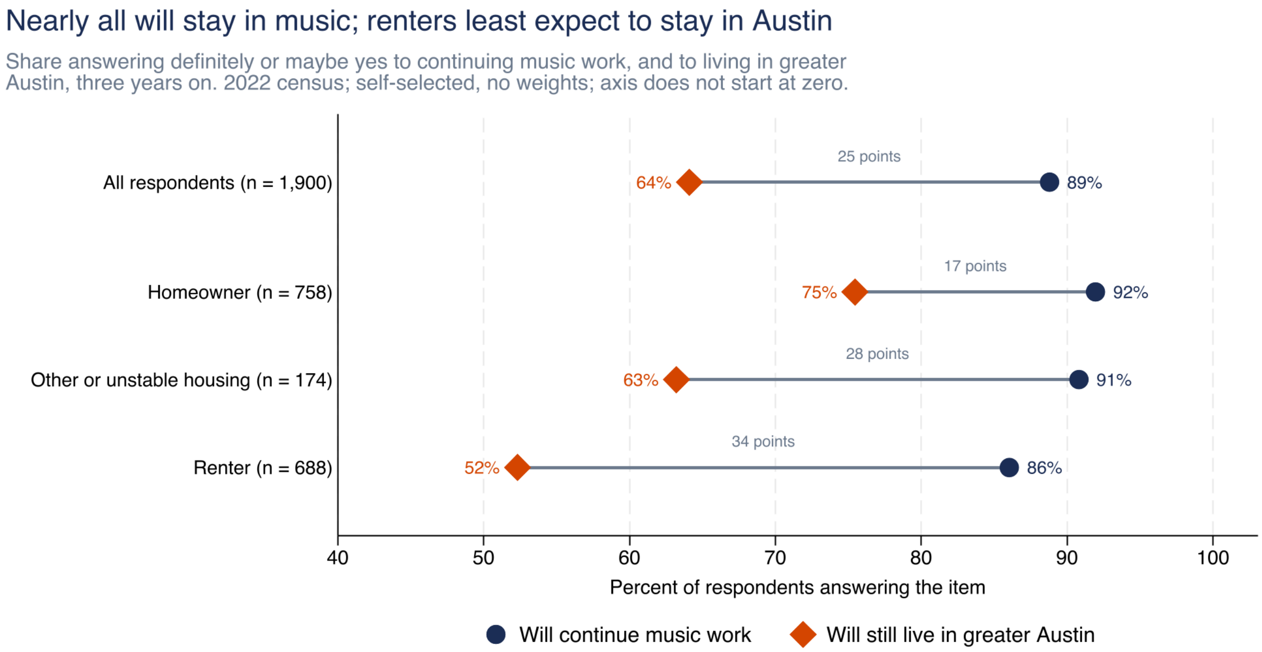

Figure 13: Share expecting to continue music work and to remain in greater Austin three years on, overall and by housing tenure. Source: 2022 Greater Austin Music Census respondent-level file, Sound Music Cities and City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, City of Austin open data dataset `an3p-3yqx`, retrieved 1 August 2026. How to read it: both questions were answered by the same 1,900 respondents, so the distance between the two bars is a within-person gap and not a comparison of two groups. Caveats: this is a self-selected online survey with no weights, so the percentages describe respondents rather than the Austin music workforce, and they are not comparable with the American Community Survey estimates in Section 2.

insurance separates the answers the same way: 66.1% of the 1,390 respondents with health insurance expected to stay against 53.1% of the 254 uninsured.[86]

Two music-career characteristics also separate the Austin-retention answer, though not in a straight line. Years of experience is the second strongest of the six discriminants (chi-squared(3) = 38.5, p = 0.0000), and it runs non-monotonically across the four experience bands the census reports: the lowest expected-stay rate belongs to the 6-to-10-year band at 49.7%, below both newer entrants at 66.7% (under three years of experience) and the most experienced at 67.8% (more than ten years). How much of a respondent's music income comes from local gigs also separates the Austin answer, on the same 1,900 respondents (chi-squared(4) = 14.4, p = 0.0061).

Two other characteristics do not separate the answers. Neither the respondent's primary music-ecosystem sector (music creative, music industry, or venue or presenter) nor the respondent's workspace status (owns, rents, provided or not needed, or needs but lacks) discriminates the Austin-retention answer at conventional levels; both are within the range chance would produce among respondents (chi-squared(2) = 1.3, p = 0.5349; chi-squared(3) = 4.9, p = 0.1811).

> That result ties together two parts of this study. Section 3 showed that Austin's cost problem is centered on housing more than on prices generally, and this section finds that housing tenure separates the census respondents' Austin-retention

probabilities and sits further from one than the probability ratio does when the outcome is common, as it is here. Estimation is by maximum likelihood on the respondents who answered every item in the equation, which is fewer than answered the retention question alone. Neither the test nor the regression is weighted, because the census carries no design weights, and both p-values assume a simple random sample, which a self-selected online survey is not. Read the test statistics as descriptive discriminants among respondents rather than as inference to the Austin music workforce. Tenure was not assigned at random, and income, age, and family stage all move with it, none of which the census measured; the tenure result is therefore an association among respondents and not the cost of renting. The analysis recodes tenure into three mutually exclusive categories, because the published appendix's categories overlap, which is why the tenure shares here do not match the *Data Appendix*.

[86] The census item is respondent-reported coverage of any kind (an employer plan, a marketplace plan, Medicaid, Medicare, VA, or another source), asked as a single yes/no. It is not directly comparable with the American Community Survey health-insurance coverage rate quoted in the summary, which uses the ACS multi-item HICOV construction on a probability sample of households.

answer more sharply than any of the six respondent characteristics tested. Health insurance splits the same answer the same way, so the two strongest household-security measures both separate stayers from the unsure, while primary sector and workspace access do not separate them at all.

6.3 Working in music costs money, and the widely cited figure overstates the typical case

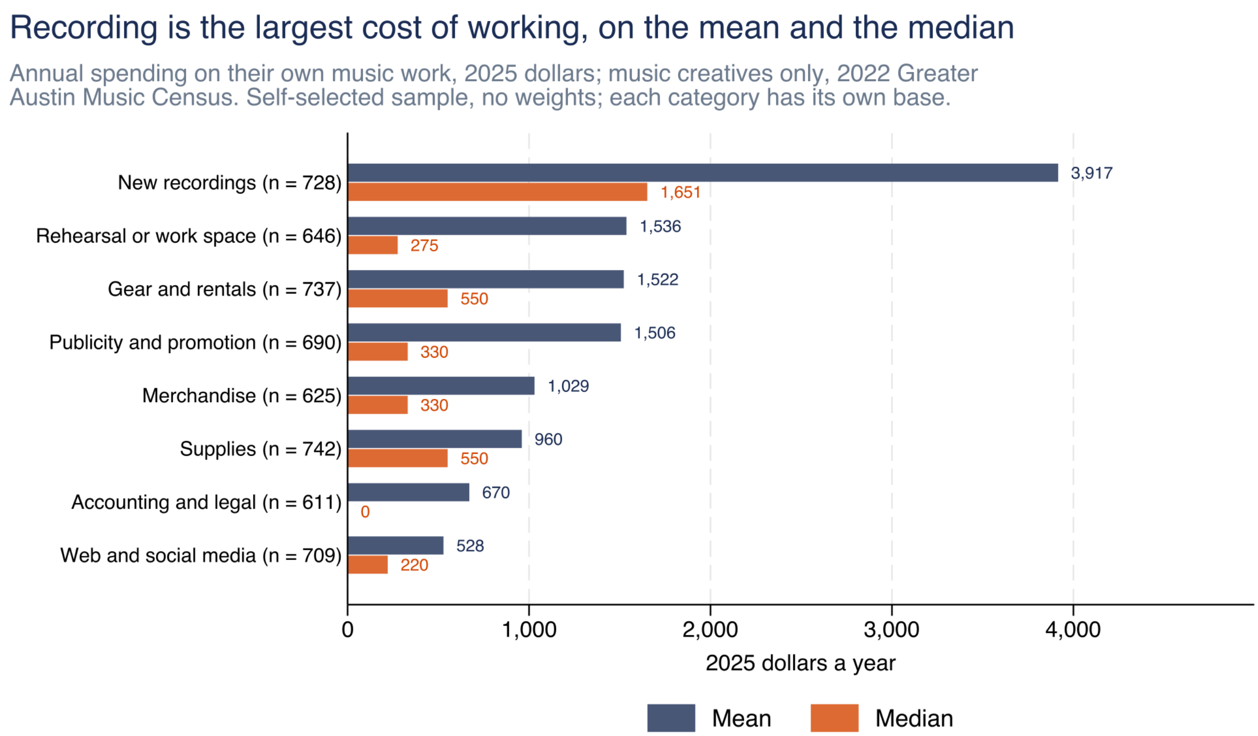

Figure 14: Annual respondent spending on their own music work, by category, music creatives only, 2025 dollars. Source: 2022 Greater Austin Music Census respondent-level file (dataset `an3p-3yqx`), converted from 2022 to 2025 dollars with the national consumer price index (CPI-U annual factor). How to read it: mean and median are shown for each category because the distribution is heavily right-skewed and the median is the better guide to a typical respondent. Caveats: each category has its own base, ranging from 611 to 742 music creatives; the census is a self-selected online sample and carries no weights.

Coverage of the 2022 census in local media and in the Sound Music Cities *Data Appendix* often cites an annual music-work spending figure of about $10,500 in 2022 dollars, worth $11,667 in 2025 prices.[87] That headline adds together eight category means computed on eight different sets of respondents, so it does not describe any actual person. Among the 501 music creatives who answered every category, the median total is $5,394 and the mean is $10,288, both in 2025 dollars, so the correctly constructed mean sits well below the widely cited figure and the median sits far below it.[88] For a single number that describes a typical respondent, prefer the median: $5,394 on the 501 complete-case music creatives, or $4,678 on the 873 who answered at least one category (with

[87] The published $10,500 headline appears in the Sound Music Cities *Data Appendix*, printed p. 46. It was widely picked up locally, including in Austin City Council briefings on the Live Music Fund and in coverage by KUT News and *Austin Monitor*. The 2022 dollar inflation factor to 2025 is the ratio of the national CPI-U all-urban annual averages from the Bureau of Labor Statistics, series identifier `CUUR0000SA0`, at `https://www.bls.gov/cpi/data.htm`; the same factor is used throughout this study.

[88] The widely cited headline is $\sum_{k=1}^{8} \bar{x}_k$, where $\bar{x}_k$ is the mean of spending category k taken over S_k, the set of respondents who answered that category. The eight sets are not the same people. The per-respondent figures quoted here are built the other way round, summing within a person first and taking the middle of those totals: $\tilde{x} = \text{median}_{i \in S}\left(\sum_{k=1}^{8} x_{ik}\right)$ over $S = \bigcap_k S_k$, the respondents who answered every category, so every dollar in the sum belongs to one person. The two constructions agree only when each category has the same respondents and the within-person total is symmetrically distributed, and neither condition holds here. Both are converted from 2022 to 2025 dollars by C_{2025}/C_{2022}, the ratio of national CPI-U annual averages, as is the published headline quoted above. The eight categories in the instrument are gear and rentals, new recordings, publicity and promotion, merchandise, rehearsal or work space, supplies, accounting and legal, and travel; the item is asked of music creatives only and does not appear on the venue-operator branch.

unanswered categories treated as zero, a deliberate lower bound because the release cannot distinguish a true zero from a blank).

These self-reported spending figures cannot be netted against the Nonemployer Statistics receipts figure quoted in Section 4.[89]

6.4 Respondents who present live music name property tax as their leading pressure

Among the 177 respondents who both present live music and completed the nine-item business-pressure ranking, 44.1% placed property tax in their top three and 20.3% ranked it their single greatest pressure, ahead of talent costs (38.4% in the top three) and labor cost and retention (35.6%).[90]

That ranking and the closure record in Section 5, where 36.1% of the 36 dated Austin venue closures cite a real-estate cause (sale, rent increase, lease expiration, or redevelopment) against 13 that cite the pandemic, both point at property costs. They do not point at the same property cost: the census item is a tax that falls on owners, and the Section 5 closure record is dominated by rent, sale, and lease-tenure disputes at what are mostly tenant venues. The two sources also diverge in one place. Talent costs rank second among presenter pressures in the census, but appear as the cause of no closure in the Section 5 record. The Comptroller receipts panel used in Section 5 has no field for what a venue pays performers, so the talent-cost item is untested here rather than contradicted.

Sections 7 and 8 turn from what these respondents report to what the city and the state actually spend on this workforce.

7 Austin's music money is small, uneven, and has never had a performance audit

Austin funds music from its Hotel Occupancy Tax, a levy that lodging guests pay on hotel and short-term-rental stays inside the city. A 2019 ordinance raised the tax and directed a fixed share of the increase to a Live Music Fund, so the money moves with hotel demand rather than with any annual council judgment about musicians.[91]

7.1 Live music receives a small share of a large tax

In fiscal 2025 the Live Music Fund received \$4.8M, or 2.90% of the city's \$164.6M in Hotel Occupancy Tax revenue.[92] The Historic Preservation Fund drew \$21.1M from the same tax, 4.42x as much as the Live Music Fund. That gap is not a departure from the 2019 ordinance's equal split. The Historic Preservation Fund also receives hotel-tax money beyond the 15 percent of the two-point increase the ordinance dedicated to each fund, and on the equal share alone the two would draw the same amount.

From fiscal 2024 to fiscal 2025, Live Music Fund revenue moved -0.89% in nominal terms and -3.49% in 2025 dollars.[93] That is one year on a series that tracks hotel demand and has swung widely since 2021, so it should not

[89] U.S. Census Bureau, Nonemployer Statistics, at https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics.html. Nonemployer Statistics is an administrative-record product built from business income-tax returns of firms with no paid employees and receipts of at least \$1,000; it reports the receipts side, before expenses, and carries no expense series. The two numbers therefore cannot be differenced. They cover different populations (music-industry nonemployer firms in the Nonemployer file, music creatives in the census), different years, and different units (businesses in one case and people in the other), and the census figure is a self-reported cost rather than a tax-return revenue line.

[90] The ranking item asked respondents who present live music, whether as a primary or a secondary activity, to rank nine business pressures from most to least pressing. The nine items were building operations and upkeep, changing audience behavior, labor cost and retention, marketing, neighborhood redevelopment, ordinances and permitting, property tax, talent costs, and unpredictable operating costs. 177 respondents completed the full ranking; that is 8 percent of the 2,227 respondents in the file and the thinnest block used in this section. This is a presenter-activity population rather than a venue census: only 77 of the 177 named venue or presenter as their primary sector, and the remaining 100 are music creatives and industry professionals who also present gigs. The Sound Music Cities *Data Appendix* slides 56–57 split operators from promoters; the promoter cell falls below this study's 50-record publication floor and is not reported here.

[91] City of Austin Ordinance No. 20190919-149, adopted 19 September 2019 and effective 30 September 2019, raised the Hotel Occupancy Tax rate from 7 to 9 percent and directed an amount equal to 15 percent of the two-point increase to the Live Music Fund, another 15 percent to Historic Preservation, and the balance largely to Convention Center expansion. Because the ordinance fixes the share rather than reappropriating each year, fund revenue tracks hotel demand. Ordinance text at https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=328565.

[92] The city's Open Budget ATX portal posts fund-level actuals for every named city fund by fiscal year; those posted actuals are the auditable primary record until each year's Annual Comprehensive Financial Report closes. Fund revenue and Hotel Occupancy Tax totals for fiscal 2025 in this section come from that portal's *Revenue Open Budget – revised* extract, Socrata dataset 5rhv-xasu, retrieved 1 August 2026 from https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/5rhv-xasu.csv. Same- year ratios need no deflation because both sides carry the same dollar base. The Open Budget series begins in fiscal 2021 and does not observe any earlier fund balance.

[93] Fiscal-year change computed from the same Open Budget revenue extract as above (dataset 5rhv-xasu). This section approximates Austin fiscal year Y by calendar year Y for deflation, because Austin fiscal years run October through September and nine of the twelve months fall in calendar Y; no quarterly deflator was available for the national consumer price index used here.

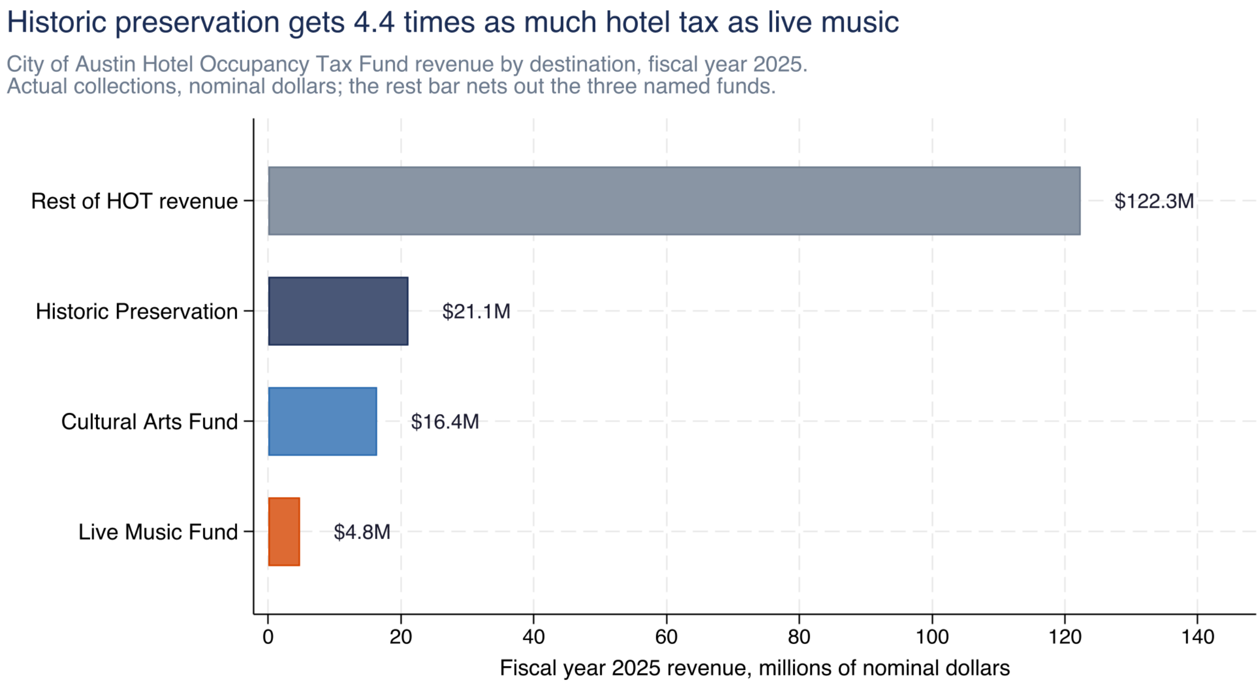

Figure 15: City of Austin Hotel Occupancy Tax revenue by destination, fiscal year 2025, nominal dollars. Source: City of Austin Open Budget ATX, *Revenue Open Budget – revised* (Socrata dataset 5rhv-xasu), fund-level actuals for fiscal 2025. How to read it: all bars share one zero-based axis, so the relative sizes are directly comparable. Caveat: the residual bar is total hotel-tax revenue minus the three named funds rather than a single program, and under the 2019 ordinance most of the residual flows to Convention Center expansion. Because every bar is same-year, nominal and real dollars give the same picture.

be read as a trend.

7.2 The fund collected for two observed years before it paid musicians

The City Council created the Live Music Fund in September 2019 and the fund did not disburse a substantial grant until fiscal 2023. By the close of fiscal 2022 the fund had accumulated $5.1M in unspent nominal money across the period when musicians' income was most disrupted.[94] Innocent explanations for the delay exist: a new fund has to write eligibility rules, procure an administrator and stand up an application process, and the pandemic disrupted all three. The timing still matters. The fund spent $4,284 in fiscal 2021 and $50,000 in fiscal 2022 against $1.5 million and $3.7 million in revenue,[95] so almost nothing left the fund during the years musicians' income was most disrupted.

Of every dollar the fund has spent through fiscal 2026, roughly 13 cents paid for something other than grants to musicians, venues and promoters: 87.10% of cumulative spending went to grants to subrecipients, 11.57% to the third-party administrator that runs the application process, and 1.33% to advertising.[96]

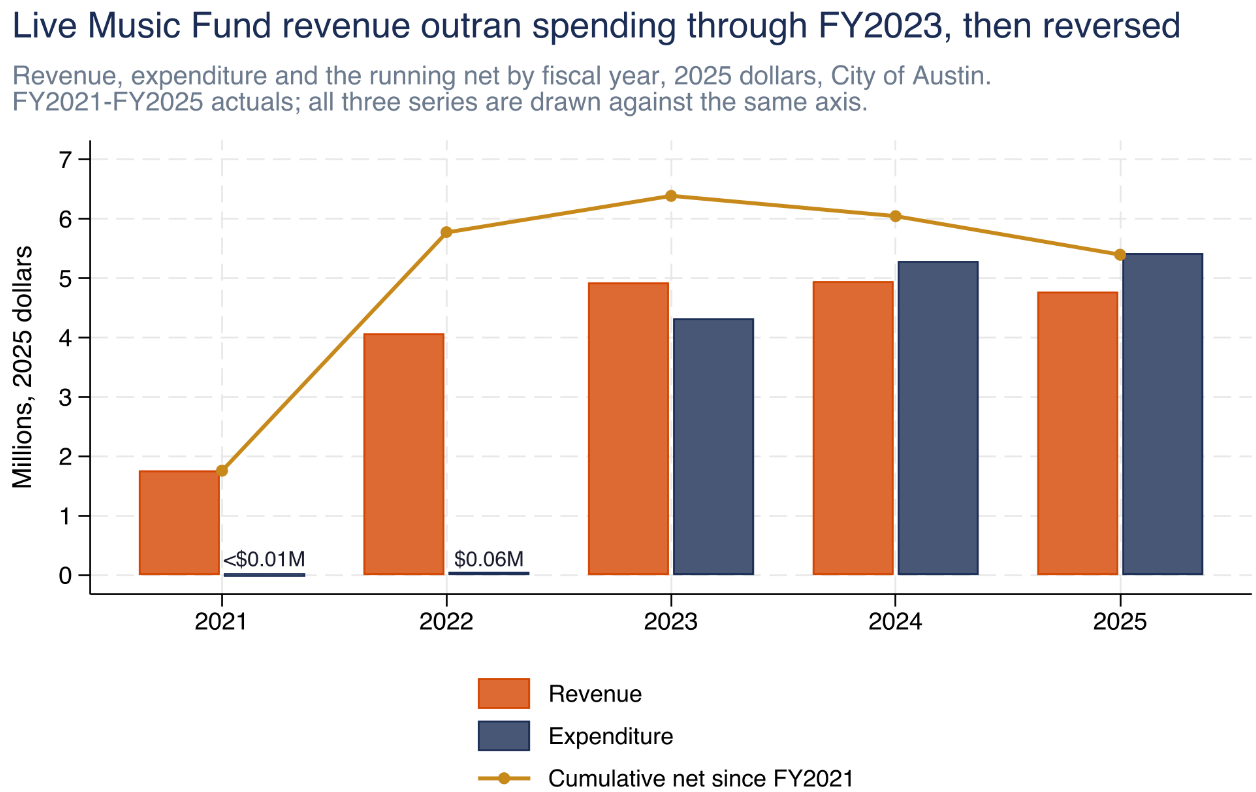

Figure 16: Live Music Fund revenue against expenditure by fiscal year, 2025 dollars, with the cumulative position on the right axis. Sources: City of Austin Open Budget ATX, *Revenue Open Budget – revised* (dataset 5rhv-xasu) and *Expense Open Budget – revised* (dataset yeeq-kk6v), Live Music Fund rows for fiscal 2021 through fiscal 2026. How to read it: bars are annual flows and the line is the running total of revenue minus expenditure. Caveat: that cumulative line is a cash-flow proxy built from fiscal 2021 forward, not an audited fund balance. It excludes any opening balance and does not reconcile with press reporting that put the fund's balance at roughly $3.2 million in September 2025, a gap that cannot be resolved without the city's audited fund-balance schedule.

7.3 What a musician could receive depended on the year they applied

From one cycle to the next, the average award and the number of recipients moved in opposite directions, and no cycle ran at all in fiscal 2025.[97]

[94]The Open Budget series begins in fiscal 2021, so fiscal 2020 collections are not in that figure. The figure is a cumulative revenue-minus-expenditure proxy built from the two Open Budget extracts (5rhv-xasu and yeeq-kk6v) rather than an audited fund balance, and it excludes any opening balance the fund carried from its 30 September 2019 creation. Figure 16 plots the same cumulative position in 2025 dollars, where it reaches a higher number for the same fiscal year. The gap against press reporting of a $3.2 million balance in September 2025 remains open pending the city's Annual Comprehensive Financial Report fund-balance schedule.

[95]Annual amounts in this sentence are from the Open Budget expense (yeeq-kk6v) and revenue (5rhv-xasu) extracts, `fund_nm = Live Music Fund`, actuals for fiscal 2021 and fiscal 2022.

[96]Object-level actuals for fiscal 2021 through fiscal 2027, summed across years, from the City of Austin Open Budget ATX expense extract (dataset yeeq-kk6v) with `fund_nm = Live Music Fund`, retrieved 1 August 2026 from https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/yeeq-kk6v.csv. The three denominated objects are Grants to Subrecipients, Consultant-Others (the fund's third-party administrator, the Long Center for the Performing Arts, from fiscal 2023 onward) and Advertising. The Open Budget expense series carries no Personnel or other object rows for this fund. Fiscal 2026 is a partial-year actual, unclosed at the time of writing, and fiscal 2027 rows are budget only. Fiscal 2026 figures for the three shares thus draw on a year that had not closed when this study was written.

[97]The primary awardee lists this section reads are the fiscal 2023 Live Music Fund Event Program Awardee List (https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/jfxwxsxktx/2023LiveMusicFundEventProgramAwardeeList.pdf?t.download=true), the fiscal 2024 Austin Live Music Fund Awardee List (https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/bpzuacfkk8/FY24-AwardeeList_Austin-Live-Music-Fund.pdf?t.download=true) and the March 2026 ACME Funding Program Award List, which covers both the fiscal 2026 Live Music Fund and the Elevate program (https://austin.widen.net/s/hhgtdnjqmn/almf_acme-2026-funding-program-award-list). The official program page (https://www.austintexas.gov/atxmusic/live-music-fund) records zero awards for fiscal 2025 and describes the cycle as deferred, with applications folded into the fiscal 2026 round. No applicant count for the fiscal 2026 Live Music Fund alone has been published; the city's fiscal 2026 cultural funding news release reports 1,606 applicants requesting more than $67 million across the four current cultural funding programs combined (Elevate, Live Music Fund, Creative Space Assistance Program and Heritage Preservation),

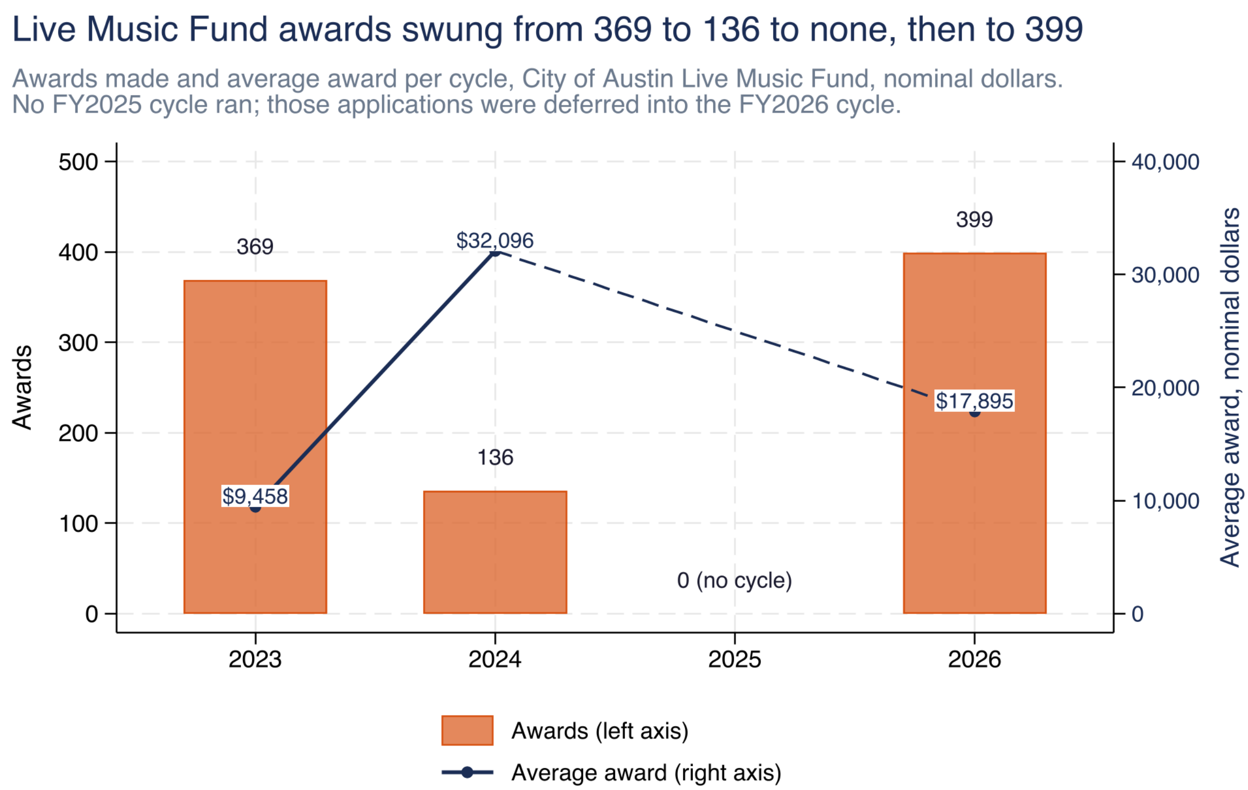

Figure 17: Live Music Fund awards and average award by cycle. Sources: the city's fiscal 2023, fiscal 2024 and fiscal 2026 awardee lists, using each document's own stated headline totals, plus the official Live Music Fund program page for the fiscal 2025 zero. How to read it: bars are the number of awards on the left axis and the line is the average award on the right axis, broken rather than interpolated at fiscal 2025 because no cycle ran that year. Caveats: the fiscal 2023 count is 369 in the awardee list PDF against 368 in press reporting, a difference that appears to be one duplicated name; the fiscal 2026 list does not reconcile with itself, so its stated headline totals are used here.

Fiscal year	Awards	Average award	Share of applicants funded
2023	369	$9,458	55.76%
2024	136	$32,096	11.85%
2025		No cycle ran	
2026	399	$17,895	Not published

For an individual musician that variation is the operative fact: the same application submitted in two different years faced a different chance of funding and a different award. Predictability is part of what makes a grant program useful for people whose income is irregular.

7.4 Demand for venue capital ran far ahead of supply at the fund's first award

Section 5 showed that Austin loses live-music capacity when rooms stop reporting and no one replaces them, which points at the cost of buildings and the security of leases. The Austin Economic Development Corporation's Iconic

https://www.austintexas.gov/communications/news/city-austin-announces-2026-cultural-funding-awards, without an individual-fund breakdown. The fiscal 2026 award list is also inconsistent with itself in three places: it names 21 venues against its own subtotal of 20; its musician and promoter rows fall $90,000 short of the stated $5,740,000; and its headline count of 399 awards does not match the sum of its two section subtotals, 399 stated vs. 397 (20+377) from the two section subtotals. The share-funded column in the table below divides press-reported award counts by press-reported applicant counts, so the numerator differs slightly from the award count shown in the same row (which is a tally of the city's own list PDF); the fiscal 2024 share also covers musician and promoter awards only, leaving out that cycle's new venue awards, while the published applicant count it divides by carries no venue-versus-nonvenue split, so the fiscal 2023 and fiscal 2024 shares are not strictly comparable.

Venue Fund is aimed at exactly that: it helps venues buy or secure their buildings.[98] At its first award in August 2023 the Iconic Venue Fund had received 45 proposals requesting more than $300M. Its selection committee had shortlisted 14 proposals and had made a single award of $1.6M to the Hole in the Wall, so the requests in hand ran to more than 187.5x the size of that single award.[99]

The imbalance is not confined to venue capital. In the 2020 Creative Space Disaster Relief round, 65 applicants requested about $3.7 million against the $1 million available, which the program page describes as nearly four times the money on offer (3.70x).[100]

7.5 No performance audit of the Live Music Fund exists

The Office of the City Auditor has published no performance audit of the Live Music Fund. Its one adjacent review, a 2024 special request on cultural arts funding, states in its own scope that it did not look at funding for music, and a search of the auditor's report index returns no music-titled audit.[101] That is a separate question from the city's annual financial audit, whose fund-balance schedule would be needed to reconcile the Live Music Fund's cash position against the press reporting cited in Figure 16.

In mid-2025, 60 Live Music Fund recipients were out of compliance with their reporting requirements, $550,000 in awards was frozen pending their final reports, and $70,000 of that had been forfeited outright.[102]

The absence of a performance audit matters more here than it would for a larger program. The Live Music Fund is small, its award rules have changed in every cycle, its administration has moved to a third party, and its cash position cannot be reconciled against public reporting using open data alone. Those are the conditions under which a periodic audit is normally expected.

The Live Music Fund is the city's main direct instrument for music, and it is one of several public levers this workforce faces. Section 8 turns to the state and federal ones: the Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program the Governor's office administers, the arts-economy aggregate the Bureau of Economic Analysis publishes at the state level, and the federal Shuttered Venue Operators Grant program that was the largest single intervention of the period.

8 Texas commits little to music, and awarded all of it in the one round it has published

Austin's fund is not the only public money aimed at this workforce, and the state's works differently. The Texas Music, Film, Television and Multimedia Office, an office in the Governor's office of Economic Development and

[98] The Iconic Venue Fund is a capital-preservation program run by the Austin Economic Development Corporation, a public non-profit created by the city, and it is distinct from the grantmaking Live Music Fund the rest of this section reads. It draws on hotel-occupancy-tax revenue and a 2018 bond package. The 2023-snapshot figures in this paragraph are from Austin Chronicle reporting on the fund's first award: Genevieve Wood, *What Hole in the Wall's Freshly Inked 20-Year Lease Means for Other At-Risk Venues*, 24 August 2023, `https://www.austinchronicle.com/music/2023-08-25/what-hole-in-the-walls-freshly-inked-20-year-lease-means-for-other-at-risk-venues/`. No primary Austin Economic Development Corporation document publishing these counts was located, and this study reports the newspaper figures as secondary.

[99] The $300 million requested figure is a stated floor rather than an exact total, so the ratio to the single award is at least the value shown. That figure is a 2023 snapshot rather than the fund's current state. City Open Budget expense data record cumulative Iconic Venue Fund grants to subrecipients of $15.3 million through fiscal 2026 (dataset yeeq-kk6v, `fund_nm = Iconic Venue Fund`), so substantially more has been awarded since; against that total the $300 million floor implies a ratio roughly an order of magnitude smaller. The Austin Economic Development Corporation has not published an updated proposal count, shortlist or recipient list. Cumulative Open Budget data also put the fund's revenue minus expenditure at -$2.6M through fiscal 2026, but that position is produced almost entirely by fiscal 2026, an incomplete year in which $2.9 million of spending is recorded against revenue that has not yet posted; summed through fiscal 2025, where the data are complete, the fund is net positive.

[100] City of Austin, Creative Space Assistance Program page, `https://www.austintexas.gov/creative-space-assistance-program`, retrieved 1 August 2026. The 2020 round funded 32 of the 65 applicants for $987,943 total, with the awardee mix running to 12 live-music venues, 11 arts nonprofits, 7 theaters, 1 museum or gallery and 1 individual artist. This 2020 round is the only Creative Space cycle for which the city has published an applicant count.

[101] City of Austin Office of the City Auditor, *Special Request: EDD Culture and Arts Funding* (October 2024), which reports on its own page 2 that "we did not look at funding for music or music disaster" relief: `https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/pifyu2e2j6/Special_Request_EDD_Culture_and_Arts_Funding_October_2024.pdf?t.download=true`. The auditor's public index of published reports at `https://www.austintexas.gov/auditor/audit-reports` carries no title matching the Live Music Fund as of 1 August 2026.

[102] Austin Monitor, *Dozens of City Music Grants Stalled Over Missing Final Reports*, 19 June 2025, `https://austinmonitor.com/stories/2025/06/dozens-of-city-music-grants-stalled-over-missing-final-reports/`, reporting a 16 June 2025 presentation to the Arts Commission. This is secondary reporting; no primary city document publishing these counts was located, and no denominator for the 60 non-compliant recipients was published alongside the count. The $550,000 figure is the hotel-tax share of $847,500 frozen citywide across 70 contracts.

Tourism, administers both the music rebate and the state's moving-image incentive under Chapter 485 of the Government Code.[103] Placing those dedications beside one another shows what the state has committed to each. This section then compares Texas with four peer states (Georgia, New York, Tennessee, Louisiana) on music money awarded, claimed or appropriated rather than merely authorised, sets the Texas arts economy beside the national aggregate, and ends with the federal pandemic relief program that was the largest single intervention of the period.

8.1 The same state office commits far more to film than to music

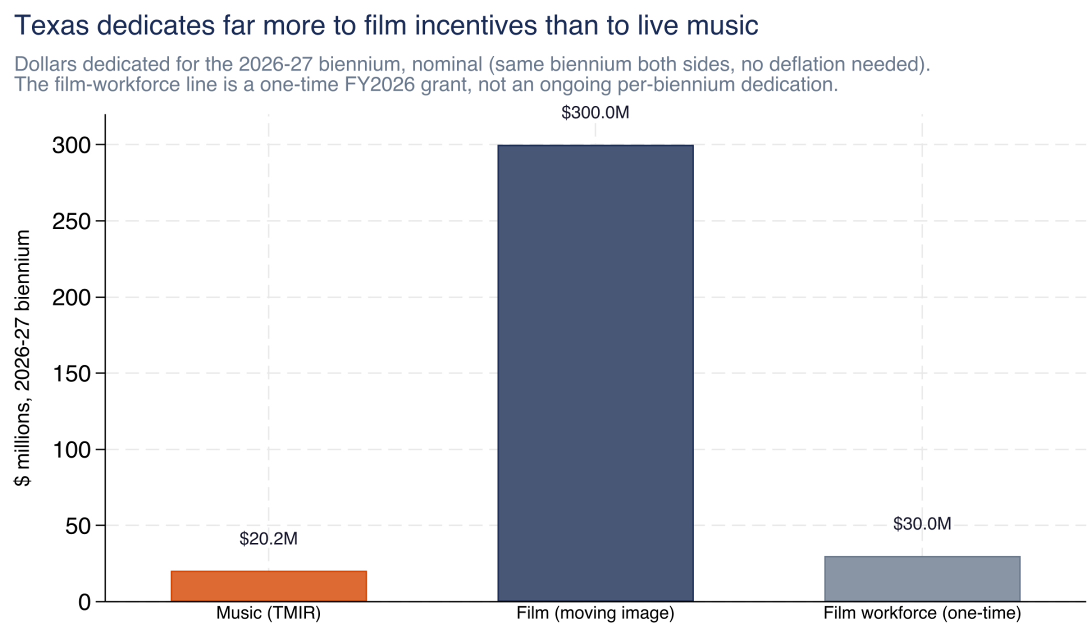

Figure 18: Texas dedications for the 2026–27 biennium, nominal dollars. Sources: General Appropriations Act riders; Senate Bill 22, 89th Legislature, 2025. How to read it: all three amounts are dedicated for fiscal 2026–27, so they are already in comparable nominal terms and no inflation adjustment is needed. Caveat: the film workforce line is a one-time fiscal 2026 grant to universities rather than an ongoing per-biennium dedication, it has no music counterpart, and it is never summed with the other two.

The 89th Texas Legislature dedicated $300.0 million to the moving-image incentive for the 2026–27 biennium through Senate Bill 22, and dedicated $20.2 million to the Texas Music Incubator Rebate over the same two years under the earlier statute that created it. The ratio between the two dedications, both nominal dollars for the same fiscal biennium, is 14.9 to 1.[104] The Texas Music Incubator Rebate, unlike its peer credits in other states, returns a portion of mixed-beverage and sales taxes that a qualifying venue or promoter has already remitted to the Comptroller, so the subsidy scales with a venue's alcohol sales rather than with what the venue pays performers. The authorising statute requires that a written artist contract exist but sets no minimum compensation.[105] The same 2025 legislative session that increased film also authorised a $30.0 million, one-time Higher Education Film Workforce Pilot Program under Rider 45 of the 2026–27 General Appropriations Act, a one-time fiscal 2026 grant to universities for film and media workforce training with no music counterpart.[106]

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[103] Government Code Chapter 485 places the Music, Film, Television and Multimedia Office inside the Governor's Economic Development and Tourism division and gives it authority to administer both incentive programs. That statutory location is why the same office serves as the state actor across the film-and-television, film-workforce, and music programs compared below.

[104] The moving-image incentive appears at Texas Tax Code section 151.801(g), added by Senate Bill 22 of the 89th Legislature (2025), which requires the Comptroller to deposit $300,000,000 per biennium into the fund and sunsets on 1 September 2035. The music rebate appears at Tax Code sections 183.023(c) and 151.801(f), added by Senate Bill 609 of the 87th Legislature (2021), which together dedicate $10,100,000 a year to the rebate account beginning with the 2024–25 biennium; Rider 39 or 40 of the General Appropriations Act appropriates that amount to the Music Office each biennium. Because both figures are nominal dollars for fiscal 2026–27, no inflation adjustment applies to their ratio. Statutory materials at `https://capitol.texas.gov/BillLookup/History.aspx?LegSess=89R&Bill=SB22` and the Comptroller's Manual of Accounts entry for the music account at `https://fmcpa.cpa.state.tx.us/fiscalmoa/fund.jsp?num=5193`.

[105] The Legislature created the rebate in Senate Bill 609 in 2021 and left it unfunded until 2023, and the first application window opened on 1 September 2023.

[106] Rider 45 restricts the $30,000,000 of General Revenue to eligible general academic teaching institutions and to film and media workforce

8.2 A statutory cap is not a measure of support

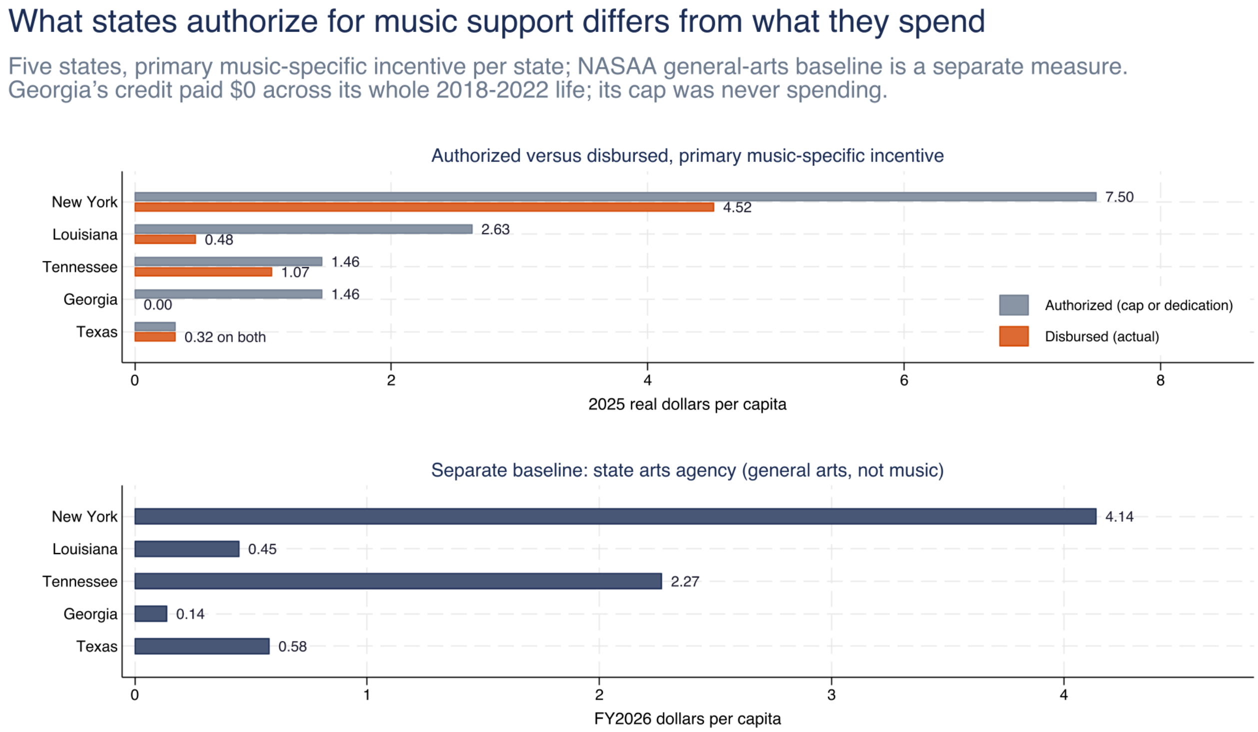

Figure 19: State music incentives per resident, authorised against actually awarded, claimed or appropriated, five states, 2025 dollars, with general state arts agency funding shown separately below. Sources: state statutes and agency reports; National Assembly of State Arts Agencies; Census Bureau population estimates for July 2025. How to read it: the upper panel shows what each state's music-specific program allows against what it paid, and the lower panel is general arts funding, a different measure that does not add to the upper one. Caveats: the New York authorised figure is a proxy derived from a budget increase rather than a flat annual cap; the Tennessee bars combine film, television and music scoring with no music-only breakout available, so they are an upper bound.

The Georgia General Assembly authorised up to $15 million a year for a music tax credit under O.C.G.A. section 48-7-40.33, and the Georgia Department of Revenue paid out nothing over the credit's five-year active life. The Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts, in a December 2023 evaluation, found that the department received six applications and approved none, because each lacked the required pre-certification from the Georgia Department of Economic Development.[107] On the statutory ceiling alone, Georgia's music support looks larger than Texas's; on dollars actually paid, Georgia sits at $0.00 per resident.

On money awarded, claimed or appropriated per resident rather than authorised, Texas is at $0.32 against New York's $4.52 and Louisiana's $0.48. Tennessee's $1.07 combines film, television and music scoring together in the Tennessee state budget's single Film and Television Incentive Fund line, and so cannot be ranked against a music-only figure. Georgia paid nothing at all. Among the states here whose figures are music-specific, Texas's dedication is the smallest per resident of those that paid anything.[108]

activities specifically, and prohibits its use for any other purpose. Registered as one-time so it is never summed with the recurring biennial moving-image or music dedications.

[107] Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts and Georgia Southern University CBAER, *Georgia Music Tax Credit: Economic and Fiscal Impact Analysis*, report dated 8 December 2023, published 14 December 2023, at https://www.audits.ga.gov/ReportSearch/download/30448. The state's published Tax Expenditure Reports listed the credit as "less than $1 million," a notation that concealed a true value of zero.

[108] The per-resident figures divide two different dollar quantities by the same population base. Authorised per resident is $a_s = A_s\, d_{y(A_s)}/N_s$ and disbursed per resident is $b_s = B_s\, d_{y(B_s)}/N_s$, where A_s is the annual amount state s may award under the statute or dedication behind its music-specific program, B_s is the amount the state actually paid or certified, $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$ carries each figure from its own nominal year to 2025 dollars using the national CPI-U, and N_s is the state's resident population on 1 July 2025 from the Census Bureau's Vintage 2025 state population totals at https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/popest/datasets/2020-2025/state/totals/NST-EST2025-ALLDATA.csv. The two figures can differ by the entire amount, because an authorisation is a ceiling written into law and a disbursement is money that left the treasury. Georgia shows the gap at its widest, with a positive ceiling and nothing paid. Where a state's authorisation is not a flat annual cap, the figure is a proxy: the New York number is the most recent one-year budget increase to

The comparison misses how differently the Texas program is built. In the one rebate round with a published total, fiscal 2026, the Music Office awarded its full annual dedication, which no peer state here did. The fiscal 2025 round total has not been published, and the first round's total is internally inconsistent, so "full spending" describes one documented round rather than a program-level record. Texas is also the only state compared here that subsidises operating music venues at all: the peer credits fund production companies mounting touring or Broadway-style shows, a different instrument aimed at a different beneficiary.[109]

8.3 Texas has a small arts economy relative to its size

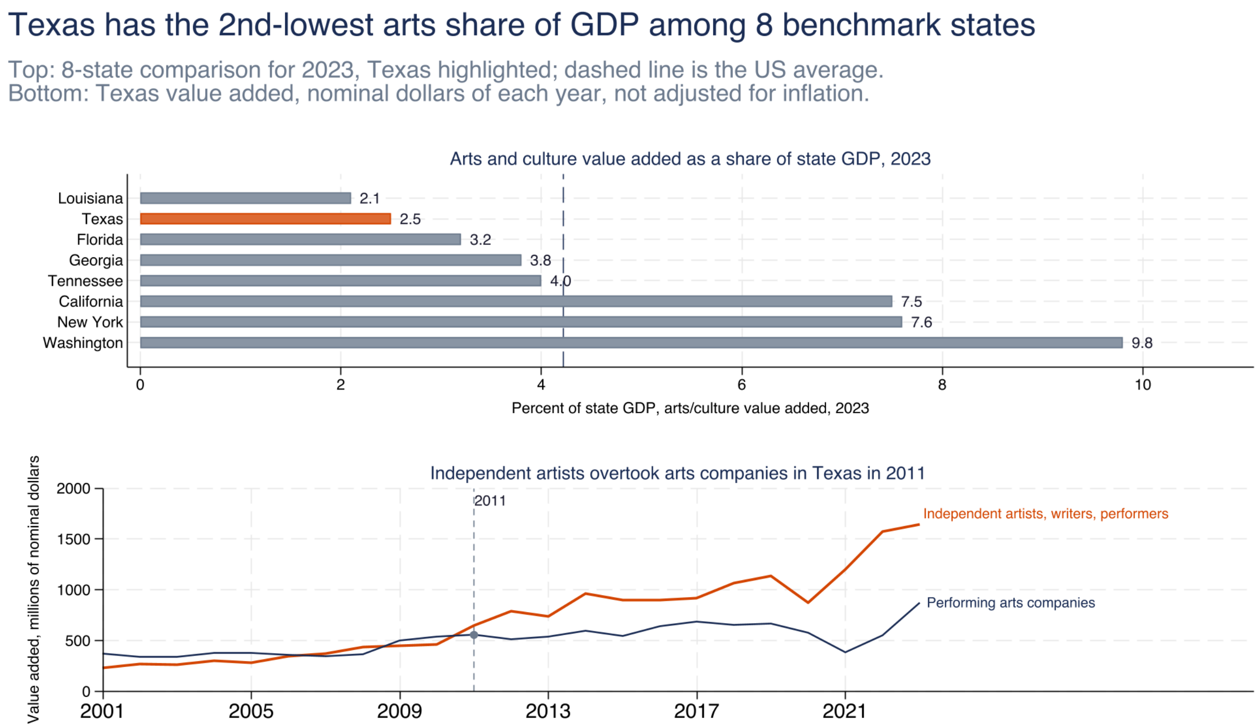

Figure 20: Arts and cultural production as a share of state economic output, eight states, 2023; and Texas value added for performing arts companies against independent artists, writers and performers, 2001–2023. Source: Bureau of Economic Analysis Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account, nominal dollars. How to read it: the upper panel compares the eight benchmark states only, not all fifty. Caveat: this account has no metro-level detail, so it says nothing about Austin specifically.

The Bureau of Economic Analysis publishes the Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account, an annual accounting series that measures the value added by a defined set of arts and cultural industries against total gross domestic product; the account is the only official U.S. statistic that isolates the economic size of the arts sector at the state level.[110] Arts and cultural production is 2.5% of Texas economic output in 2023, against 4.2% for the

a multi-year lifetime cap under Tax Law section 24-c, and the Tennessee figure combines film, television and music scoring because the Tennessee Department of Finance and Administration reports no music-only breakout at line 330.17 of the state budget document, so both are upper bounds. Three cautions apply to the second column. Only the Texas and Georgia figures are money awarded that this study could verify against agency award files; the New York, Tennessee and Louisiana figures are respectively an annualised award total, a combined-fund appropriation and a claimed credit, so the column is not a like-for-like disbursement measure. The New York figure annualises $308 million in credits awarded between August 2022 and February 2026 (three and a half years) into a one-year equivalent, against a single Texas rebate round. The Louisiana figure combines the Sound Recording Investor Tax Credit at Louisiana Revised Statute 47:6023 with the Musical and Theatrical Production Credit at R.S. 47:6034; the Sound Recording credit alone is about $0.01 per resident, well below Texas. These are accounting ratios built from published totals, not estimates, and no sampling error attaches to them. Program-page URLs and the underlying budget documents are consolidated in the technical appendix under each state name.

[109] The five-state comparison is therefore not a league table. New York's musical and theatrical production credit at Tax Law section 24-c subsidises productions; Tennessee's music-related incentive is a film-scoring subsidy under the 2018 Visual Content Modernization Act, and the Tennessee Entertainment Commission's program guidelines expressly declare music videos ineligible. Louisiana's two credits (sound recording investment and musical and theatrical production) subsidise recording sessions and touring productions respectively. Only the Texas rebate pays the operating room itself.

[110] The BEA account, generally abbreviated ACPSA, uses production categories built from the North American Industry Classification System

United States as a whole. The United States figure is the national aggregate ratio (all U.S. arts value added divided by total U.S. GDP) rather than the mean of the fifty state shares.[111] The composition inside the Texas total has also shifted. Value added by independent artists, writers and performers in Texas first overtook that of performing arts companies in 2007 (temporary, reversed), fell back behind performing arts companies for two years, then passed it for good in 2011 and has led every year since. The same movement from institutions toward individuals that Section 4 found in payroll employment appears here in output.

The Bureau of Economic Analysis posted a notice in February 2026 stating that it will no longer regularly produce the Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account, and so the April 2025 release covering 2023 is the last year available and no further annual update is scheduled.[112]

8.4 Federal relief was the largest intervention, and it was one-off

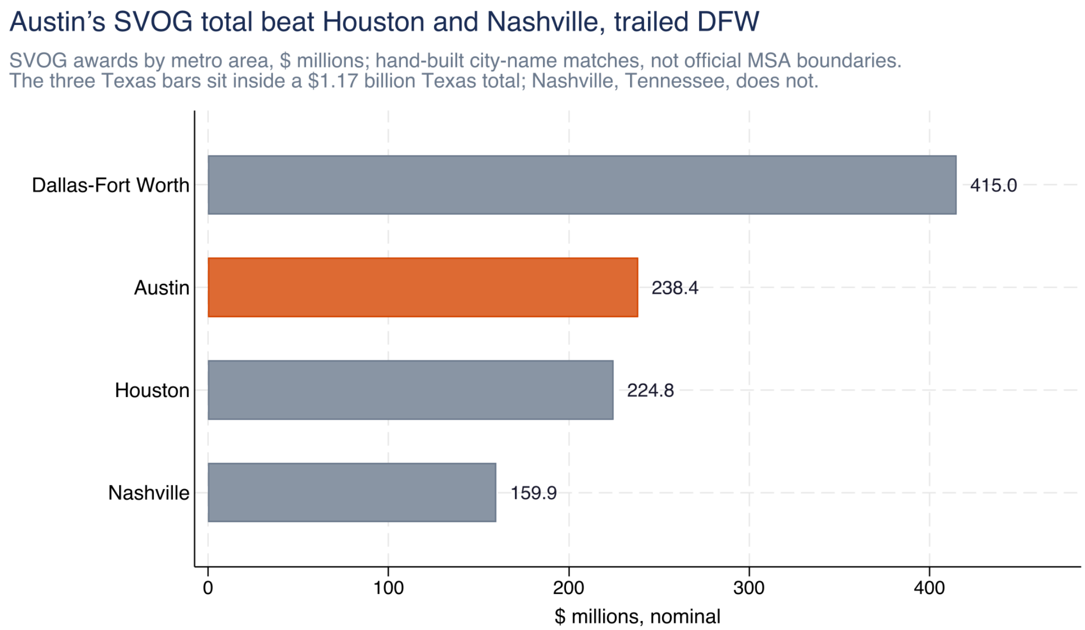

Figure 21: Shuttered Venue Operators Grant awards by metro area. Source: Small Business Administration award file, July 2022 vintage, the last published. How to read it: bars are total awarded dollars, nominal. Caveats: metro groupings are built from recipient city names rather than official metropolitan boundaries, so they are approximate and will differ from other researchers' groupings for the same metros; recipient city is the filer's mailing address, so a multi-site chain books grants for out-of-state locations to its headquarters city; the Nashville figure covers the consolidated city only while the two Texas figures use multi-place lists; and the Austin total covers every eligible entity type, of which motion picture theatre operators account for $109.8 million across 24 recipients against $104.9 million to 80 live venue operators and promoters.

Congress created the Shuttered Venue Operators Grant program in December 2020 to compensate live venue operators, promoters, theatrical producers and motion picture theatre operators for revenue lost during the pandemic closures; the Small Business Administration administered the program and published the award file used

and covers roughly 35 industries from performing arts and museums to architecture, publishing and broadcasting. Its state file at https://www.bea.gov/data/special-topics/arts-and-culture is a top-down allocation of national commodity totals to states and does not resolve below the state level, so it cannot describe Austin specifically. The 2023 estimates released on 2 April 2025 in BEA news release 25-13 are the latest available. The share it produces is the appropriate measure of an industry's size within a state economy because it deflates the industry to that state's own economic base, which lets a comparison across states control for the size of the state.

[111] The share for state s is $100 \times V_s/Y_s$, where V_s is nominal value added by arts and cultural production industries in state s and Y_s is that state's nominal total gross domestic product, both in 2023. A ratio of two same-year dollar figures needs no inflation adjustment, because deflating numerator and denominator by the same factor leaves the ratio unchanged. Among the eight benchmark states plotted (California, Florida, Georgia, Louisiana, New York, Tennessee, Texas and Washington), only Louisiana ranks lower than Texas, at 2.1%. Nationally, Texas ranks 36th of 51 (50 states + DC) across all 50 states and the District of Columbia; this ranking is taken from BEA's own release rather than re-derived here, since this study's extract holds only the eight benchmark states and does not permit an independent national ranking.

[112] BEA site text, "BEA will no longer regularly produce these statistics," February 2026, retrieved 1 August 2026 from https://www.bea.gov/data/special-topics/arts-and-culture, cross-checked against the April 2025 release (BEA news release 25-13). BEA has not ruled out a future non-regular release, so this is a discontinued schedule rather than a closed series.

here.[113] Austin-area recipients received $238.4 million in federal shuttered-venue grants, against $224.8 million for this study's Houston-area grouping, $159.9 million for Nashville and $415.0 million for Dallas-Fort Worth. The Austin and Houston figures should not be ranked against one another. Three awards inside the Austin group, together worth $16.5 million, are filed at Round Rock and Austin corporate addresses but name cinemas in Iowa, Indiana and Virginia; removing them alone puts Austin below Houston. Money was concentrated: the top ten Austin recipients received 38.8% of Austin dollars, and 5 of 152 recipients recipients reached the program's $10 million per-entity cap.[114]

The event study around those awards illustrates why relief programs resist causal evaluation. In the six months before their award, recipient venues were running about 39 percent below comparison venues on log monthly mixed-beverage receipts, with a 95 percent confidence interval that stretched from about 58 percent below to 12 percent below. The half-year before that is estimated too imprecisely to distinguish from no gap. Recipients then converged to no measurable difference from comparison venues after the award. The pre-award trough looks like the shape of a program effect, but SVOG eligibility required documenting a revenue drop, so the pre-award trough is the selection rule made visible in the data rather than an independent finding of harm.[115]

The largest single intervention in this ecosystem over the period studied was federal, one-off, and directed at venue and cinema operators rather than at musicians. Of the Austin-area total, $104.9 million went to live venue operators and promoters (80 recipients) and $109.8 million to motion picture theatre operators (24 recipients), with the remainder going to performing arts organisations, talent representatives, museums and theatrical producers.

Sections 2 through 8 have set out what the public record measures. Section 9 pairs each finding with the option it points toward and the precedent this study located, so a reader can judge the inference for themselves before Section 10 names the additions that would close the measurement gaps this analysis ran into.

9 What the data suggest

The evidence in this study points toward options rather than a program, and each row below shows the evidence behind its option so a reader can judge the inference for themselves. None of these is a recommendation about how much Austin or Texas should spend, which is a political judgment this study does not make. The table names the source behind each row in the second column and, in the third, the closest precedent this study located;

[113] The Small Business Administration award file used here, "Awards as of 07-05-2022," is the last public release SBA has posted to its open data portal at https://data.sba.gov/sites/default/files/distribution/SBA-ODA-2022-09-001/awards-as-of-7-5-22.xlsx; it holds 13,011 recipient records nationally. The program's authorising statute, section 324 of the Economic Aid to Hard-Hit Small Businesses, Nonprofits, and Venues Act (division N of the Consolidated Appropriations Act, 2021), capped awards at ten million dollars per entity and gave priority to operators reporting the deepest revenue drops. Documentation at https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/R/PDF/R46689/R46689.5.pdf and https://www.sba.gov/article/2025/01/15/new-report-shows-consequential-impacts-sba-pandemic-relief.

[114] The concentration measure is $100 \times \sum_{j=1}^{10} G_{(j)} \big/ \sum_j G_j$, where G_j is the awarded amount for recipient j in the Austin group and $G_{(1)} \geq G_{(2)} \geq \ldots$ are the same awards sorted from largest to smallest, so the numerator is the ten largest awards and the denominator is every Austin award. Award dollars are nominal and are not deflated, because all awards fall in the same program period. The Austin group is built from recipient city names rather than official metropolitan boundaries, so the denominator is this study's grouping and will differ from another researcher's using a different city list.

[115] The event study runs on half-year blocks measured from each venue's own award month:

$$\ln R_{it}^{\text{real}} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \sum_{b \neq b_0} \beta_b \left(\mathbf{1}\{\text{block}_{it} = b\} \times \text{SVOG}_i\right) + \varepsilon_{it},$$

where R_{it}^{real} is venue i's monthly receipts in 2025 dollars from the Texas Comptroller Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts dataset (naix-2893 on the Texas Open Data Portal at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893), SVOG_i is one for a matched relief recipient, $\text{block}_{it} = \lfloor (t - a_i)/6 \rfloor$ places month t in a half-year block relative to that venue's own award month a_i, clipped at nine blocks before and eight after so the end blocks hold several months for every award cohort rather than a sliver, and α_i and τ_t are venue and calendar-month fixed effects respectively. The omitted block b_0 covers 30 to 25 months before the award, which for the typical award month is the first half of 2019; the conventional base of the period just before treatment would sit in the deepest part of the pandemic and would leave every other coefficient unreadable. Venues that never received an award are assigned the base block, so they contribute to the fixed effects and the common time path rather than to any β_b. Standard errors are clustered by venue, and the largest ticketed rooms are excluded. The p-value quoted below is a joint Wald test that the block coefficients closing before January 2020 are all zero (the blocks that predate the pandemic shock for every award month in the data). The pre-pandemic trends for the two groups are not distinguishable ($p = 0.9052$), the strongest parallel-trends evidence in this study, and even so the design still cannot support a causal claim about the awards themselves. This study matched 29 of 152 Austin awards to the curated venue panel and dropped three matches as uncertain, with the reasons recorded in the SVOG venue crosswalk file. The awards all arrived within a three-month window in 2021, so relative time and calendar time are close to relabellings of one another.

every finding is developed in the section listed, and every underlying figure is registered in the numbers ledger at `03_analysis/out/canonical_numbers.csv`.

What the evidence shows	Option it points toward	Precedent or supporting evidence
Austin's own music census stopped asking respondents what they earned after its 2014 fielding, whose income questions covered calendar 2013, and no local survey has replaced the question.[116]	Consider restoring a short earnings module to the next music survey and running it on a fixed cycle. Five consistent questions asked every two years rebuild the series; consistency matters more than length.	Other cities in the same census cohort still publish musician income figures. The 2022 Austin instrument dropped the income-quantification items its 2014 predecessor asked and replaced them with an ordinal share-of-income scale that reports no dollars.
The Austin Live Music Fund received 1,013 applications in its fiscal 2024 cycle and 660 in fiscal 2023, both figures from press reporting rather than a primary tabulation, and neither cycle's applicant-level distribution has been published.[117]	Consider publishing the applicant-level distributions the Live Music Fund already gathers, in aggregate. This costs no new collection.	The Texas Legislature attached a budget rider to the state film incentive that requires the Governor's office to report film-incentive awards, recipient by recipient, to the Legislative Budget Board (the Legislature's fiscal research office) twice a year; no parallel rider covers the state music rebate, and neither program is required to publish a recipient list.[118]
Between January 2020 and mid-2026, the Austin venue tracking panel recorded more exits from its core live-music tier than it added, while the surviving rooms in that tier traded no worse than the rest of the Austin mixed-beverage market once venue-level trend and month-of-year seasonality are absorbed (Section 5).[119]	Consider directing support at room survival and replacement rather than at operating margins. Property costs and lease security are among the pressures venue operators report most often.	Austin's own Iconic Venue Fund is aimed at exactly this. At its first award in August 2023, requests ran to more than 187.5x the size of that award; the fund has awarded more since, and no updated recipient list has been published (Section 7).

[116] Titan Music Group, *The Austin Music Census: A Data-Driven Assessment of Austin's Commercial Music Economy*, published for the City of Austin Economic Development Department, June 2015, fielded through community mailing lists and industry channels in late 2014, n=3,968 self-selected online respondents, at https://austin.widen.net/content/om7zqn1qbx/pdf/Austin_Music_Census_Interactive_PDF_53115.pdf; Sound Music Cities and the City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *2022 Greater Austin Music Census*, fielded 15 July to 12 September 2022, n=2,260 self-selected online respondents, at https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-SUMMARY-REPORT-v13-optimized.pdf. The 2022 instrument replaced the 2014 income-quantification items with an ordinal share-of-income scale that reports no dollars.

[117] The applicant counts trace to *Austin Chronicle* reporting on the fund (FY2024 count published 28 March 2025); the fund's own FY2023 dashboard is a JavaScript-gated Power BI embed with no static export, and no primary applicant tabulation was located for either cycle. Development in Section 7. Both cycles' awardee lists are public: fiscal 2023 at https://austin.widen.net/content/jfxwxsxktx/pdf/2023LiveMusicFundEventProgramAwardeeList.pdf and fiscal 2024 at https://austin.widen.net/content/bpzuacfkk8/pdf/FY24-AwardeeList_Austin-Live-Music-Fund.pdf. The applicant-level submissions the fund gathers, including geography, sector and requested amount, have not been released in aggregate.

[118] Rider 40 to the Governor's office in the 2026–27 General Appropriations Act; Senate Bill 22, 89th Legislature, 2025. The parallel music-rebate statute is Senate Bill 609, 87th Legislature, 2021.

[119] The tracking panel is 114 venues curated Austin live-music rooms matched to Texas Comptroller mixed-beverage receipts (Open Data Portal dataset `naix-2893` at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893), not a census. Section 5 tabulates the exits and the two-way fixed-effects regression that supports the same-as-market finding, and the technical appendix in Section A lists the four ways the panel can and cannot be read.

What the evidence shows	Option it points toward	Precedent or supporting evidence
In the news timeline behind the venue panel, as many dated Austin live-music-room closures cite a property cause (rent increase, sale of property, redevelopment or lease expiration) as cite the pandemic, and presenters who answered the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census ranked property tax first among nine business pressures.[120]	Consider whether venue support is best delivered through property-side instruments rather than through grants.	Other states run property or occupancy relief for cultural uses, and Texas has built comparable mechanisms for other industries.
A musician applying to the Live Music Fund faced a different average award depending on which fiscal year they applied, and the fund made no awards in its fiscal 2025 cycle (Section 7).	Consider fixing award sizes and cycle timing in advance and publishing the schedule. Predictability is a design feature for people with irregular income.	The fund's own year-to-year variation is the evidence; no external model is needed.
The Texas Music Incubator Rebate returns a share of the mixed-beverage and sales taxes a qualifying venue or promoter has already remitted, so the subsidy scales with a venue's alcohol sales, and the statute requires a written artist contract but sets no floor on what the contract pays the performer.[121]	Consider whether public support intended to reach musicians should be conditioned on documented artist payments.	Georgia authorised a music tax credit at $15 million a year and paid out nothing over the program's five-year life, so a headline cap alone says nothing about what reached anyone.[122]
Among respondents to the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census who answered the three-year-retention items, housing tenure and health insurance separate who expects to still be in Austin in three years; primary sector and workspace status do not (Section 6).[123]	Consider treating musician retention as a housing question, with instruments aimed at renters.	The 2022 census respondents' cost pressure sits in housing rather than in overall living costs: the Austin metro's Regional Price Parity, the Bureau of Economic Analysis series that indexes local price levels against a national 100, sits near 100 on all items and above 100 on the housing item alone (Section 3). Any generalisation of these shares to the Austin music workforce would rest on the assumption that the self-selected sample resembles that workforce on tenure and insurance, which no source can verify.

[120] The closure counts come from a 71-row news timeline compiled by this study from *Austin Chronicle*, *Austin American-Statesman*, KUT/KUTX and industry reporting; 36 rows carry a closure year and a coded cause (13 property, 13 pandemic, 2 regulatory, 3 uncoded, 5 other), and the property share appears in the ledger as `census_closures_property_share`. The presenter ranking runs over the 2022 Greater Austin Music Census presenter-and-promoter subsample (respondents self-identified as booking or presenting live music); the census is a self-selected online sample, so the ranking describes presenters who answered rather than a probability sample of Austin presenters. Sources: news timeline at `01_evidence/08_venues_ecosystem/venue_timeline.csv`; census microdata dataset `an3p-3yqx` at https://data.austintexas.gov/.

[121] Senate Bill 609, 87th Legislature Regular Session, 2021, creating Government Code Chapter 485, Subchapter C, at https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/87R/billtext/pdf/SB00609F.pdf. Program page: Texas Music Office, Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program, at https://gov.texas.gov/music/tmir. Neither the statute nor the program guidelines specify a minimum artist compensation.

[122] Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts and Georgia Southern University CBAER, *Georgia Music Tax Credit: Economic and Fiscal Impact Analysis*, December 2023, at https://www.audits.ga.gov/ReportSearch/download/30448.

[123] The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census carries no design weights, so every share here describes respondents to a self-selected online instrument and not the Austin music workforce; no margin of error can be computed for any of them. Development, including the logit that isolates the tenure and insurance effects, is in Section 6.

What the evidence shows	Option it points toward	Precedent or supporting evidence
Federal shuttered-venue relief went to venues, cinemas and organisations rather than to individuals, and the largest city instrument for buildings (the Iconic Venue Fund) is capital support.[124]	Consider what share of support should follow the worker rather than the building, and measure it.	The Live Music Fund is the main city channel reaching individuals, and it is the smallest of the three named here. Health coverage among Austin musicians, at 90.1% (+/- 8.5 points), is close within that margin to 87.7% for all Austin workers.[125] Austin's independent nonprofit health programs for musicians reach individuals directly, though this study cannot attribute the coverage rate to them.

Cautions on reading this table. Two policy interventions this study tested left no detectable change in venue receipts: the City of Austin's 2017 extended-hours pilot on Red River (a temporary 2 a.m. closing time for a defined set of Red River rooms; the design detected no effect and rules out receipts effects larger than roughly 14 percent) and the fiscal 2024 round of Live Music Fund venue grants (Section 5). A third test found that receipts near the new downtown arena that opened in April 2022 moved no differently from receipts far from it, which is a test of proximity to the arena rather than of the arena's overall effect. None of that means those interventions failed at what they were trying to do; alcohol receipts at a venue are the wrong instrument for detecting effects on what performers are paid, and no public Austin dataset currently measures those payments directly. The largest intervention during the study period was also federal, one-off, and directed at venues and cinemas, so a local plan that assumes similar money will come again is building on an unusual year.

10 Extending this work

Better measurement would close the gaps this analysis ran into, the evidence base now assembled would support analyses this study could not run, and a small tool would let readers test the findings under their own assumptions.

Additions that would close measurement gaps

- **Add an earnings module to the next Austin music survey.** Five questions asked consistently every two years would rebuild the series that lapsed after the 2014 Austin Music Census (whose income items covered calendar 2013): gross income from music, share of total income from music, number of paid performances, whether the respondent holds non-music work, and health-coverage source.[126]
- **Request the administrative records that agencies collect but do not publish.** This study stops short in places because the agencies holding the records have not released them: applicant demographics for Austin's Live Music Fund, the recipient list for the Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program at the Governor's office, and the audited fund-balance schedule for Austin's cultural funds.[127]
- **Track paid performance slots rather than venue names.** Venue addresses recycle as one operator replaces

[124] U.S. Small Business Administration, Shuttered Venue Operators Grant awards file, awards as of 5 July 2022, at https://data.sba.gov/sites/default/files/distribution/SBA-ODA-2022-09-001/awards-as-of-7-5-22.xlsx. The program was authorised by section 324 of the Economic Aid to Hard-Hit Small Businesses, Nonprofits, and Venues Act of 2020 and its eligibility categories are venue operators, promoters, theatrical producers, performing-arts organisations, motion picture theatre operators and talent representatives, none of which is an individual worker.

[125] Both figures are from the American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year Public Use Microdata Sample for Texas (dataset released 5 March 2026 at https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/), Musicians and Singers (occupation code 2752) against all employed Austin workers aged 18–64 with any-coverage flag HICOV=1, PWGTP-weighted, margin of error at 90 percent from the 80 replicate weights; the musician cell rests on 77 unweighted person records. See Section A for the population and weighting.

[126] Both Austin music censuses are self-selected online instruments (2014 n=3,968; 2022 n=2,260), so a restored earnings series would describe respondents rather than the Austin music workforce; a probability-sample benchmark for that workforce does not exist. Sources: Titan Music Group, *The Austin Music Census*, 2015, at https://austin.widen.net/content/om7zqn1qbx/pdf/Austin_Music_Census_Interactive_PDF_53115.pdf; Sound Music Cities and the City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *2022 Greater Austin Music Census*, at https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-SUMMARY-REPORT-v13-optimized.pdf.

[127] A requester can obtain each of these through a formal public information request under the Texas Public Information Act (Texas Government Code Chapter 552, at https://statutes.capitol.texas.gov/Docs/GV/htm/GV.552.htm) or the City of Austin's equivalent process. This study filed no such requests, because the statutory response and Attorney General review windows would have delayed publication, and a follow-up round remains the most direct way to close these three gaps. Rider 40 to the Governor's office in the 2026–27 General Appropriations Act requires the office to report film-incentive awards recipient by recipient to the Legislative Budget Board (the Legislature's fiscal research office) twice a year, and no parallel rider covers the music rebate, so the rebate's recipient list stays unpublished unless someone asks for it.

another, so counting names overstates what closed. Capacity and the number of paid performance opportunities per month measure what a working musician actually faces.

- **Extend the venue panel to beer-and-wine rooms.** The Texas Comptroller's mixed-beverage tax file omits venues without a liquor permit, which removes several well-known listening rooms from the panel (Cactus Cafe, Meanwhile Brewing, the Carousel Lounge) even when they programme live music regularly.[128] A join on permit type would recover the beer-and-wine rooms. Rooms with no separable alcohol permit, and rooms folded into a hotel permit, sit outside any alcohol-tax file and would need a different source, such as ticketing or sound-permit records.

Analyses this evidence base would support

- **Link venue closures to property records.** Matching this study's closure timeline against Travis Central Appraisal District parcel and sale records would separate rent pressure from ownership transfer and redevelopment, which the news record conflates.[129]
- **Follow the cohort rather than the occupation.** Longitudinal earnings records, such as the Census Bureau's Longitudinal Employer-Household Dynamics program (LEHD, the state unemployment insurance records the Bureau assembles into a national worker panel), would show whether musicians leave music, leave Austin, or add non-music work. Those three outcomes look identical in the cross-sectional microdata used here.[130]
- **Compare Austin against a matched set of metros** on the same federal series used here, to separate a music-specific pattern from what happens to self-employed workers in any fast-growing metro.

A scenario tool for non-technical readers

This study prints one set of numbers, and readers will want to vary them. A small interactive tool with the four controls below would let a council member, a state staffer, or a reporter test how the measured trends play out under different assumptions.

Control	What the user adjusts	What updates on screen
Venue revenue trend	The annual real change in core live-music venue receipts, from continued decline through stabilisation to renewed growth	Projected count of core live-music rooms and total real receipts to 2032, with the historical series drawn behind the projection
Public support level	The Live Music Fund's share of hotel-tax revenue, and the split between musician grants and venue grants	Dollars available, grants per applicant at current award sizes, and the share of the estimated musician population reached
Housing costs	Austin market rent growth, from the recent decline through a return to the 2015 to 2023 pace	The market rent index and, separately, hours of work per month of Fair Market Rent (the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development benchmark used to set voucher payment standards) at the payroll musician wage, which covers payroll jobs only. The two rent series moved in opposite directions after 2023, as Section 3 shows, so the panel would have to display both
State program design	Whether the state rebate stays tied to alcohol tax remitted or is tied instead to documented artist payments	Illustrative redistribution across venue sizes, showing which venues gain and which lose under each rule

Whoever builds such a tool would keep it honest by drawing every default from the measured series here, by drawing projections in a different line style from observed data and labelling them assumptions, and by saying plainly that the fourth control illustrates a design tradeoff and predicts no legislative outcome. A static web page with those series embedded as a small data file is enough for the historical series, which are already registered in this study's numbers ledger at `03_analysis/out/canonical_numbers.csv`. Two controls would need

[128] The Comptroller's mixed-beverage gross-receipts file (dataset `naix-2893` on the Texas Open Data Portal, at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893) covers only holders of a mixed-beverage (liquor) permit. Rooms operating on a beer-and-wine permit are reported through a separate Comptroller tax file that a follow-up round could join to the same venue list.

[129] The Travis Central Appraisal District publishes parcel-level records at https://www.traviscad.org/, with owner name, parcel value and sale history for every real-property account in Travis County.

[130] Public LEHD tabulations are at https://lehd.ces.census.gov/; microdata access requires an approved Federal Statistical Research Data Center project.

code this study does not have: a projection rule behind the venue trend, and an illustrative redistribution model behind the state-design control, which has no measured artist-payment data to rest on. Whether or not anyone builds it, each item in this section would let a later analyst replace one of this study's inferences with a measurement.

A Technical appendix

This appendix records how to rerun the analysis, how the estimates and regressions are specified, and where the evidence runs out. Every method in this appendix names the Stata do-file that produced it, so a reader can open the file, read the code, and reproduce the number. All do-files sit in `03_analysis/stata/` and the merged number ledger sits in `03_analysis/out/canonical_numbers.csv`.

A.1 Reproducing this study

The analysis folder is self-contained: a reader can copy it to another machine and rerun it without editing a path, because every path resolves relative to the project root, which the setup file `_setup.do` locates by searching upward for a known sentinel file. Outside data files sit in `03_analysis/data/` rather than at referenced absolute paths. Rebuilding the study from raw data takes three commands, run in order from the analysis folder.

Step	Command
Run the descriptive modules	`cd 03_analysis/stata && stata-mp -b do run_all.do`
Run the quasi-experimental module	`stata-mp -b do 70_quasi_experiments.do`
Build the study	`cd ../../05_report && make`

`run_all.do` runs the seven descriptive modules that produce the figures and registered numbers in Sections 2 through 8. Those modules are, in order, `10_pums_earnings.do` for PUMS earnings, `20_wages_industry.do` for the payroll wage and industry series, `30_venues.do` for the venue panel, `40_city_money.do` for the city funds, `50_state_national.do` for the state and national comparison, `60_cost_of_living.do` for the cost-of-living series, and `80_census_microdata.do` for the 2022 music census and finishes by calling `build_numbers.do`, so the number macros need no separate command. `run_all.do` does not call the quasi-experimental module `70_quasi_experiments.do`, which is the sole source of every quantity behind the four designs in Sections 5 and 8, so that module runs separately as the second step. Because `build_numbers.do` merges whatever ledgers it finds on disk, skipping the second step produces a report that still compiles, using stale quasi-experimental numbers.

Every quantity registered in the numbers ledger is quoted through a generated macro rather than a typed figure. A small number of figures quoted from named source documents, and rounded verbal descriptions of registered quantities, are typed in place and cited where they appear. Each analysis module writes its results to its own ledger, and `build_numbers.do` merges those ledgers into the macro file the study reads. The merged ledger at `03_analysis/out/canonical_numbers.csv` lists every registered quantity with its value, its source file, and a `note` field recording the population, filter, weight and vintage behind it. A reader checking any number in this study can find it in that file and trace it to the module that produced it.

A.2 Inflation adjustment

All dollar figures are real, in 2025 dollars, converted with the U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (series CUUR0000SA0, national, all items), and every figure subtitle states the base year.[131] Three kinds of figure are flagged nominal where they appear: a ratio of two same-year dollar figures, where deflation cancels; a figure quoted as its source originally published it; and award or excluded-filing totals whose dollars all fall inside one period.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics never published a Consumer Price Index value for October 2025, because the federal funding lapse suspended collection.[132] This analysis interpolates that month from September and November and flags it in the data, so the 2025 annual average that deflates every dollar figure in this study rests on twelve months rather than eleven. The interpolation runs inside `60_cost_of_living.do`.

[131] Series documentation and monthly values at https://www.bls.gov/cpi/; this study pulls the series from the BLS Public Data API at https://api.bls.gov/publicAPI/v2/timeseries/data/.

[132] The Bureau paused the October 2025 CPI collection during the fiscal-year 2026 government shutdown; the September and November values are published as scheduled. See BLS release schedule at https://www.bls.gov/schedule/news_release/cpi.htm.

Austin has no local price index, as Section 1 notes. Deflating by the national index is the only option available, and its effect on the estimates here is unknown in sign. The one cross-sectional price comparison that does exist puts Austin's all-items Regional Price Parity at 98.1 against a national 100, which says nothing about the rate at which Austin prices moved.[133]

A.3 Survey estimates and their uncertainty

Microdata estimates, computed from individual survey records rather than from published tables, use the American Community Survey five-year Public Use Microdata Sample (PUMS) for Texas, 2020 to 2024, the newest five-year PUMS released as of retrieval.[134] Dollar variables are adjusted first by the survey's own `ADJINC` income-adjustment factor, which places five survey years on a common basis, and then by the Consumer Price Index.

Standard errors come from the Census Bureau's successive-difference replication method, the published approach for this file, which re-estimates each statistic on all 80 replicate weights (`PWGTP1` to `PWGTP80`) and takes the spread across those estimates as the error.[135] Margins of error are reported at 90 percent. The PUMS extractions and every survey estimate in this study run in `10_pums_earnings.do`.

Two population definitions are used, and each is applied to both sides of every comparison it appears in; Section A.5 defines them and names which estimates use which. This study suppresses estimates resting on fewer than 50 unweighted records, the practice the Bureau recommends. The Austin musician cell has 77 unweighted person records, which supports the headline estimates reported here and does not support any further breakdown.

A.4 Regression specifications

Conditional earnings gap. This study regresses the natural logarithm of personal earnings on an indicator for music occupations by weighted least squares, controlling for age and age squared, sex, educational attainment, usual hours worked, weeks worked and metro fixed effects, among employed Texans aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings, with standard errors from the 80 replicate weights. The coefficient is -0.290 (standard error 0.054), a difference of -25.2%. The full table sits at `03_analysis/out/tables/table_earnings_regression.csv` and the regression runs in `10_pums_earnings.do`.

Venue divergence. A two-way fixed-effects regression of the log of real monthly receipts on a core-live-music indicator interacted with the post-March-2020 period, absorbing venue and year-month fixed effects and clustering standard errors by venue, gives 0.003 (standard error 0.077, p = 0.9730) on 171724 unit-months venue-months. The event-study version replaces the single interaction with year-specific terms, omitting 2019.[136] The divergence regression runs in `30_venues.do`.

Quasi-experimental designs. Four designs appear in Sections 5 and 8: an event study around federal relief awards, a difference-in-differences on the 2017 extended-hours pilot, an event study around the 2024 venue grants, and a distance-band test around the 2022 arena opening. For the two designs with the smallest treated groups (the extended-hours pilot and the 2024 venue grants), conventional cluster-robust standard errors are unreliable, so this study uses randomization inference as the primary test: the module reassigns treatment at random across the eligible venues several thousand times, and the exact p-value is the share of those placebo estimates at least as large as the observed one. The arena and federal relief designs report Wald tests on cluster-robust standard errors instead; the arena design's reference group is six venues, so its bands are imprecisely estimated and none is individually distinguishable from zero. All four designs are descriptive: selection into treatment is not random in any of them, and the relief design in particular selects on the severity of the shock by construction. All four

[133] U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis, Regional Price Parities by Metropolitan Statistical Area, 2024 vintage, at `https://www.bea.gov/data/prices-inflation/regional-price-parities-state-and-metro-area`. The Regional Price Parity indexes the price level in a metro against a national 100 in the same year, and its own documentation says it is not a time-series measure of local inflation.

[134] U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey 2020–2024 five-year PUMS for Texas, released 5 March 2026, at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/csv_ptx.zip`. The ACS is the Bureau's ongoing household survey, and the PUMS is its individual-record release; it is the only public federal source that supports occupation-by-metro estimates for a workforce as small as Musicians and Singers because it pools the occupation across five years.

[135] U.S. Census Bureau, *PUMS Accuracy of the Data* technical document for the 2020–2024 five-year file, at `https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/tech_docs/pums/accuracy/2020-2024AccuracyPUMS.pdf`. Treating microdata records as an independent sample would understate the true standard error substantially, because the ACS is a stratified cluster sample rather than a simple random sample.

[136] A full factorial interaction under two-way fixed effects leaves the term of interest collinear and the estimator drops it, so this study constructs the interaction as an explicit product variable. Requesting 2019 as the base year is likewise not honoured when the fixed effects absorb the alternatives, so the year-by-treatment terms are built by hand with 2019 omitted. Both fixes change the coefficients, which is why they are recorded here. Pre-2019 coefficients trend upward rather than staying flat, so the parallel-paths assumption does not hold cleanly and the design is descriptive.

designs run in `70_quasi_experiments.do`. Section A.5 below gathers the specification behind each design with every symbol defined.

A.5 Every formula in one place

The footnotes at each point of use give the specification behind each estimate. This subsection gathers all of them, so a reviewer can read the methods in one sitting instead of hunting through the sections. Nothing here is new: each block names the estimator, defines every symbol, names the estimation sample and the variance assumption, and says whether the quantity is descriptive or causal. Where a quantity appears in more than one section, this appendix writes it once here.

Notation used throughout

Subscript i indexes a unit: a person in the survey blocks and a venue or permit location in the panel blocks. Subscript t indexes time: a month in the venue panel and a year elsewhere. C_y is the annual average of the national Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers in year y, and $d_y = C_{2025}/C_y$ is the factor that carries year y dollars to this study's 2025 base. w_i is a survey weight, `PWGTP` for persons and `WGTP` for households in the American Community Survey PUMS. $\mathbf{1}(\cdot)$ equals one when the condition inside holds and zero otherwise. A hat marks an estimate.

Price adjustment

Nominal dollars become real dollars by $x_y^{\text{real}} = x_y \times d_y$. The 2025 annual average uses an interpolated October, the average of September and November, because the federal funding lapse suspended collection that month. A ratio of two same-year dollar figures is left nominal on purpose, because deflating both sides by the same d_y leaves the ratio unchanged. The deflator ledger `cpi_annual.dta` is built inside `60_cost_of_living.do` from the BLS Public Data API.

Microdata dollars take an extra step first. For person i the real value is $y_i = Y_i \times (\text{ADJINC}_i/10^6) \times d_{2024}$, where Y_i is the amount as reported and ADJINC_i is the survey's own income adjustment factor, published with six implied decimals, which restates all five survey years on a common 2024 basis.[137] Housing dollars use `ADJHSG` in the same position. No year-specific deflator is merged on, because the survey factor has already removed the inflation inside the 2020 to 2024 window and a second one would remove it twice.

Weighted descriptive estimates and their uncertainty

A weighted median is $\hat{\theta}_{0.5} = \inf\{\, y : \sum_i w_i \mathbf{1}(y_i \le y) \ge 0.5 \sum_i w_i \,\}$, the smallest observed value at which accumulated weight reaches half the total, with adjacent order statistics averaged when the accumulated weight lands exactly on half. A weighted share of a group G is $\hat{p} = \sum_{i \in G} w_i a_i \big/ \sum_{i \in G} w_i$, where a_i is one when the record has the attribute being counted. Both are descriptive population estimates.

Sampling error comes from successive-difference replication (SDR), the published method for this file:

$$\widehat{\text{Var}}(\hat{\theta}) = \frac{4}{80} \sum_{r=1}^{80} \left(\hat{\theta}_r - \hat{\theta}\right)^2, \qquad \text{MOE}_{90} = 1.645 \sqrt{\widehat{\text{Var}}(\hat{\theta})},$$

where $\hat{\theta}$ uses the full weight and $\hat{\theta}_r$ the rth replicate weight, `PWGTP1` to `PWGTP80` for persons and `WGTP1` to `WGTP80` for households.[138] Deviations are taken around the full-sample estimate rather than the replicate mean, the convention Stata labels `mse`. A few replicate weight cells are slightly negative, which the Bureau permits; this study floors the weight at zero inside percentile calculations only, because a weighted percentile is undefined with negative weights. For a difference between two independent estimates the combined margin is $\text{MOE}_{A-B} = \sqrt{\text{MOE}_A^2 + \text{MOE}_B^2}$.

Two population definitions are used, and each is applied to both sides of every comparison it appears in. The employed base is Texas residents aged 18 to 64 in work (employment status `ESR` in {1,2,4,5}). The positive-earnings base adds the requirement that personal earnings exceed zero. Medians, the self-employment share, coverage rates and the regression run on the bases named in their own footnotes; the earnings-threshold shares run on the employed base, so that people reporting zero or negative earnings stay in the denominator. No estimate resting on fewer than 50 unweighted records is published. All weighted descriptive estimates run in `10_pums_earnings.do`.

[137] Documentation at https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/tech_docs/pums/2020-2024_PUMS_README.pdf (ADJINC is section 3.3 of the readme).

[138] The constant $4/80$ is fixed by the Bureau's replicate design; the derivation is in *PUMS Accuracy of the Data*, section 5, cited above.

Conditional earnings gap

$$\ln y_i = \alpha + \beta\,\text{music}_i + \gamma_1\text{age}_i + \gamma_2\text{age}_i^2 + \gamma_3\text{female}_i + \sum_{k=2}^{5}\delta_k\,\text{educ}_{ki} + \gamma_4\text{hours}_i + \gamma_5\text{weeks}_i + \sum_m \lambda_m\,\text{metro}_{mi} + \varepsilon_i$$

Every symbol appears in the footnote at the point of use in Section 2. Estimation is by weighted least squares with the person weight, over the 554,672 employed Texans aged 18 to 64 with positive earnings, with standard errors from the 80 replicate weights rather than from an independence assumption. A log-point coefficient converts to a percentage difference as $100\,(e^{\hat\beta}-1)$, and the same transformation applied to $\hat\beta \pm 1.96\,\text{se}(\hat\beta)$ gives the 95 percent interval. Two nested specifications, metro fixed effects alone and metro plus demographics, appear in the exported table beside the one quoted in the text. The estimate is a descriptive conditional difference, not the earnings cost of choosing music: hours and weeks are themselves outcomes of the occupation, so controlling for them removes part of what is being measured and pushes the coefficient toward zero. The regression runs in `10_pums_earnings.do`.

Index numbers, ratios and per-resident measures

An index rebases a series on a chosen year or month, $I_{s,t} = 100 \times X_{s,t}/X_{s,t_0}$. Three bases appear in this study, each chosen for what its figure compares: each series against its own first available year, for payroll jobs against nonemployer businesses; each metro against its own January 2015, for real rent; and every group against 2019, for venue receipts. An index carries no unit and no count, which is why two indexed panels can be compared for direction and never added together. The index constructions run in `20_wages_industry.do` (jobs against nonemployer), `60_cost_of_living.do` (metro rent) and `30_venues.do` (receipts).

An endpoint percentage change is $100\,(X_T/X_0 - 1)$, a total change across the whole span rather than an annual rate.

The hours-of-work ratio is $h_{o,y} = F_y/w_{o,y}$, monthly Fair Market Rent over the median hourly wage for occupation group o, matched within year and left in nominal dollars, because $(d_yF_y)/(d_yw_{o,y}) = F_y/w_{o,y}$. Fair Market Rent is the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development benchmark rent used to set voucher payment standards, published annually by HUD metro area at https://www.huduser.gov/portal/datasets/fmr.html. The wages come from the BLS Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics program, described below. The ratio is computed in `60_cost_of_living.do`.

The rent share of earnings is $s = 100 \times 12\bar F/\tilde y$, the annualised average Fair Market Rent over the five fiscal years the microdata pool, divided by the weighted median earnings of Austin musicians, both in 2025 dollars.

Businesses per 10,000 residents is $10^4 \times E_{c,y}/N_{c,y}$, and receipts per business is $\bar r_{c,y} = R^{\text{real}}_{c,y}/E_{c,y}$, an arithmetic mean with no distribution published behind it. Both use the Census Bureau's Nonemployer Statistics for the numerator, which reports counts of establishments with no paid employees and no covered payroll, and the Bureau's Vintage 2025 population estimates for the denominator.[139]

Per-resident state support is computed twice from the same denominator, $a_s = A_s\,d_{y(A_s)}/N_s$ for the authorised amount and $b_s = B_s\,d_{y(B_s)}/N_s$ for the amount disbursed, where N_s is resident population on 1 July 2025 from the Census Bureau's Vintage 2025 national estimates. An authorisation is a statutory ceiling and a disbursement is money that left the treasury, and the two can differ by the whole amount. Both computations run in `50_state_national.do`.

Regional Price Parity gaps are $g_m = \text{RPP}^{\text{hous}}_m - \text{RPP}^{\text{all}}_m$, and Consumer Price Index gaps are differences between two series rebased on the same year. Both are in index points and neither is a percentage. Both sit in `60_cost_of_living.do`.

Every measure in this block is an arithmetic ratio of published quantities, so none carries a sampling error of its own, though the rent share inherits the margin of error of the earnings median in its denominator.

Panel regressions on venue receipts

The curated panel of 114 venues Austin live-music rooms supplies the treated group. The comparison group in the divergence and event-study designs is every other mixed-beverage permit location in Travis County and the City of Austin, which is why those two regressions run on 171724 unit-months venue-months rather than on the

[139]Nonemployer Statistics documentation at https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics.html; Vintage 2025 state and county estimates at https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/popest.html. This branch of the analysis lives in `20_wages_industry.do`.

panel's own 16192 venue-months. The four quasi-experimental designs run inside the panel and its neighbours instead.

The venue designs below share an outcome and a fixed-effects structure. The outcome is $\ln R_{it}^{\text{real}}$, the log of venue i's mixed-beverage receipts in month t in 2025 dollars, taken from Texas Comptroller Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts (dataset `naix-2893`) at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893. α_i is a venue fixed effect absorbing everything constant about the room, and τ_t is a year-month fixed effect absorbing everything common to the market in that month. Standard errors are clustered by venue throughout, which allows one room's months to be correlated with one another and treats venues as the independent units. Zero-receipt months leave a log specification, so every log estimate describes venues conditional on trading that month. All venue regressions run in `30_venues.do` (divergence and event study) and `70_quasi_experiments.do` (federal relief, extended-hours pilot, 2024 venue grants and arena opening).

- **Divergence, core tier against the rest of the market.** $\ln R_{it}^{\text{real}} = \alpha_i + \tau_t + \beta(\text{Core}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + \varepsilon_{it}$, with Post_t equal to one from March 2020, over 171724 unit-months from January 2013 to December 2025. The comparison group is other mixed-beverage permit locations in Travis County and Austin; the panel's live-music-adjacent tier is dropped from the estimation sample rather than coded zero, because those rooms programme live music intermittently and belong to neither group.
- **Event study.** The same equation with $\sum_{y \neq 2019} \beta_y (\mathbf{1}\{\text{year}(t) = y\} \times \text{Core}_i)$ in place of the single interaction.
- **Federal relief.** Half-year blocks relative to each venue's own award month, $\text{block}_{it} = \lfloor (t - a_i)/6 \rfloor$, clipped at nine blocks before and eight after, with the block 30 to 25 months before the award omitted. A second version replaces the recipient indicator with award intensity, the award divided by mean monthly 2019 receipts at the same venue, so one unit is one month of pre-pandemic revenue. Award data come from the U.S. Small Business Administration's Shuttered Venue Operators Grant awards file (awards as of 5 July 2022) at https://data.sba.gov/sites/default/files/distribution/SBA-ODA-2022-09-001/awards-as-of-7-5-22.xlsx.
- **Extended-hours pilot.** $\text{Pilot}_i \times W_t$ over January 2015 to December 2019, with a half-year event study on a 2016 second-half base and a variant adding venue-by-month-of-year fixed effects, which absorb the seasonality the two groups do not share. W_t equals one during the pilot's operating window on Red River.
- **Venue grants.** $\text{Grant}_i \times \text{Post2024}_t$ over January 2018 to December 2025, with an annual event study on a 2023 base. The grant set comes from the City of Austin's fiscal 2024 Live Music Fund awardee list at https://austin.widen.net/content/bpzuacfkk8/pdf/FY24-AwardeeList_Austin-Live-Music-Fund.pdf.
- **Arena opening.** Three distance-band interactions with the post-April-2022 period, venues more than four miles away omitted, and the pandemic window dropped from both sides. Straight-line distance comes from the great-circle formula

  $$D = 2\rho \arcsin \sqrt{\sin^2(\Delta\phi/2) + \cos\phi_1 \cos\phi_2 \sin^2(\Delta\lambda/2)},$$

  with ϕ latitude, λ longitude, Δ the difference between venue and arena, and ρ the Earth's radius in miles.

Interactions are constructed as explicit product variables and base periods are dropped by hand throughout. Under two-way fixed effects a factorial interaction leaves the term of interest collinear and the estimator drops it, and a requested base year is not honoured once the fixed effects absorb the alternatives, which renormalises an event study onto whichever level the estimator happened to drop.

The exported venue table carries a fourth column that replaces the log with the inverse hyperbolic sine,

$$\text{asinh}(R) = \ln\bigl(R + \sqrt{R^2 + 1}\bigr),$$

which behaves like a logarithm at large values and is defined at zero, so months when a room reported no receipts stay in the sample. That column answers a different question from the log column, which conditions on trading, and its coefficient is not scale-free: rescaling the currency changes its size, so a reader cannot read it as a percentage. No number quoted in this study comes from it, and the column stays in the table because dropping zero months is the log specification's main limitation and a reader should be able to see what happens without that drop.

Joint tests reported as p-values are Wald tests. The parallel-paths checks test that the pre-treatment event-study coefficients are jointly zero, and the arena test is $H_0 : \beta_1 = \beta_2 = \beta_3$, which asks whether the pattern varies with distance at all rather than whether any single band moved.

Every venue design is descriptive. Nothing in them is randomised, no policy switches on for one group and not another at a clean date, and the relief design selects on the severity of the shock by construction.

Randomization inference

Where the treated group is small, cluster-robust standard errors understate the true sampling variability, so the exact p-value comes from permuting the treatment assignment:

$$p = \frac{1 + \#\{\, r \le R : |\hat{\beta}_r| \ge |\hat{\beta}| \,\}}{R + 1},$$

where $\hat{\beta}$ is the estimate under the assignment that actually happened, $\hat{\beta}_r$ is the estimate from refitting the same regression after reassigning treatment at random to the same number of units, drawn without replacement from an eligible pool, and R is the number of draws: 5,000 for the extended-hours pilot and 2,000 for the venue grants. Treatment dates are held fixed and only the assignment moves. Adding one to numerator and denominator counts the assignment that happened among the possibilities, which is what keeps the test exact rather than approximate.[140] The pool is restricted to venues whose filing coverage matches the treated group's, so a placebo assignment lands on the same kind of unit as the real one. The spread of the placebo estimates also bounds what the design could have detected, and the report quotes that bound where it is informative. The randomization loop runs in `70_quasi_experiments.do`.

Association tests on the 2022 census file

The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census carries no design weights, because it is a self-selected online instrument fielded through community mailing lists between 15 July and 12 September 2022 and not a probability sample, so every statistic in that section is an unweighted count over a stated denominator, $\hat{p} = 100 \times n_{\text{yes}}/n_{\text{answered}}$, and no margin of error exists for any of them.[141] The census-file estimates all run in `80_census_microdata.do`.

Independence between two survey items is tested with Pearson's chi-squared, $X^2 = \sum_j \sum_k (O_{jk} - E_{jk})^2/E_{jk}$ with $E_{jk} = R_j C_k / N$, on $(J-1)(K-1)$ degrees of freedom, where O_{jk} is the observed count in row j and column k, R_j and C_k are the row and column totals, and N is the number answering both items.

The retention regression is a logit,

$$\ln \frac{\Pr(\text{stay}_i = 1)}{1 - \Pr(\text{stay}_i = 1)} = \alpha + \sum_s \beta_s\, \text{sector}_{si} + \sum_e \gamma_e\, \text{exper}_{ei} + \sum_h \delta_h\, \text{tenure}_{hi} + \theta\, \text{insured}_i,$$

estimated by maximum likelihood on the 1,607 respondents who answered every item in the equation, with the quoted quantity the odds ratio $e^{\hat{\delta}_{\text{renter}}}$. An odds ratio is not a ratio of probabilities and sits further from one than the probability ratio does when the outcome is common, as it is here. Three nested models appear in the exported table. The logit runs in `80_census_microdata.do`.

The published spending headline and the per-respondent total are two different calculations. The headline is $\sum_{k=1}^{8} \bar{x}_k$, a sum of eight category means each taken over the respondents who answered that category. The per-respondent figure is $\tilde{x} = \text{median}_{i \in S}\bigl(\sum_{k=1}^{8} x_{ik}\bigr)$ over $S = \bigcap_k S_k$, the respondents who answered every category, so each figure in the sum belongs to one person.

Both the tests and the logit assume a simple random sample, which a self-selected online survey is not, so they describe which characteristics separate respondents from one another and support no inference to the Austin music workforce.

A.6 The venue panel

The panel matches Texas Comptroller Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts (dataset `naix-2893`) to named Austin venues by location address and taxpayer name, following venues through changes of owner and legal name, and covers 114 venues rooms monthly from January 2007 to June 2026.[142] Four limitations bound what the panel can show.

- It measures alcohol sales, not music activity, and nothing in it records what performers were paid.

[140] The derivation is in Fisher's *Design of Experiments*, 1935, chapter 2, and the small-sample properties of the adjustment are in Phipson and Smyth, "Permutation p-values should never be zero," *Statistical Applications in Genetics and Molecular Biology* 9(1), 2010.

[141] Sound Music Cities and the City of Austin Music & Entertainment Division, *2022 Greater Austin Music Census*, summary report at https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-SUMMARY-REPORT-v13-optimized.pdf; the respondent-level microdata sit on the City of Austin's open data portal as dataset `an3p-3yqx` at https://data.austintexas.gov/.

[142] Comptroller portal at https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893; the file records every mixed-beverage permit holder's monthly gross receipts, cover-charge receipts (unreliable before roughly 2022 because of a reporting change), and permit status. The matching runs in `30_venues.do` and uses a curated venue list at `01_evidence/08_venues_ecosystem/venue_match_list.csv`.

- It is curated, not a census, and over-represents nameable rooms in the central city, particularly Red River, East Austin and South Congress.
- It omits venues without a liquor permit, which removes several well-known listening rooms (Cactus Cafe, Meanwhile Brewing, Carousel Lounge, Bass Concert Hall, Central Presbyterian) from the panel.
- Festival companies file under venue-linked names. The largest such filing is more than three hundred times its venue's median month, and the ten excluded venue-months are worth $43,290,954 in nominal dollars in total.[143]

A.7 Known limitations

- **No current representative measurement of Austin musician earnings exists.** The survey estimates in this study are the best available and rest on 77 Austin records pooled over five years of the American Community Survey PUMS.
- **The federal wage survey excludes the self-employed.** The Bureau of Labor Statistics Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS) program is a semi-annual establishment survey; it records the wage of every worker on a respondent establishment's payroll and records nothing for the self-employed, who fall outside the sampling frame.[144] Self-employed workers are 72.2% (+/- 10.3 points) of Austin musicians in the ACS PUMS, so even at the low end of that margin every figure drawn from OEWS describes a minority of the occupation.
- **The 2022 Greater Austin Music Census has no design weights** and is a self-selected online sample, so its percentages describe respondents only and have no margins of error; a probability-sample benchmark for the Austin music workforce does not exist.
- **The Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account has no metro detail and will not be updated after 2023.** The Bureau of Economic Analysis announced in February 2026 that the April 2025 release is the final regular annual release.[145]
- **Metro groupings for federal Shuttered Venue Operators Grant relief** are built from recipient city names rather than official metropolitan-statistical-area boundaries and are approximate.
- **One award document does not reconcile with itself in three places**, and a second disagrees with press reporting by one award. This study uses each document's stated headline totals rather than re-tallying its line items.
- **Records the city and the state hold but do not publish**: applicant demographics for the Austin Live Music Fund, the recipient list for the Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program, and the fund's audited fund-balance schedule. Section 10 sets out how a requester could obtain them under the Texas Public Information Act (Texas Government Code Chapter 552) or the City of Austin's equivalent process.

A.8 Software

The analysis runs in Stata 19 and uses these user-written commands: `reghdfe` and `ftools` for high-dimensional fixed effects, `estout` for tables, `spmap` and `shp2dta` for the map, and `gtools`, `palettes`, `colrspace` and `grstyle` for data handling and figure styling. The project bundles all of them in `03_analysis/stata/ado/`, so no package installation is needed, and XeLaTeX typesets the document.

B References

This appendix gives the issuing body, title, and URL for every one of the 294 sources this project used, with a parenthetical note wherever a limitation matters to a claim in the report. Every source below was retrieved on 2026-08-01; dataset vintages are kept in the tables because those vary. **The complete machine-readable inventory – the same 294 entries with vintages, retrieval dates, and every limitation note in one spreadsheet – is at `03_analysis/out/source_inventory.csv`.**

Federal statistical sources

Datasets

Every dataset below was retrieved on 2026-08-01; that column is omitted from the table.

[143] Two modules apply slightly different exclusion rules, one dropping the flagged extreme filings and the other a wider set. Testing the difference showed it does not matter: the core-tier change from 2019 to 2025 is identical under both rules. The cover-charge field is separately unusable before about 2022 because of a reporting change, so this study does not use it.

[144] OEWS program documentation at https://www.bls.gov/oes/oes_ques.htm. The Bureau also does not publish an annual musician wage for any city or year because the work is too irregular to annualise from an hourly rate.

[145] BEA news release 25-13, at https://www.bea.gov/data/special-topics/arts-and-culture.

Series / dataset (vintage)	Geography & years used
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics (OEWS)* (May 2005–May 2025 annual estimates (May 2025 is the current vintage)). https://www.bls.gov/oes/tables.htm (payroll wage-and-salary employment only; excludes the self-employed; annual-wage figures not published for Musicians and Singers or Actors in most years and geographies)	Austin-Round Rock(-San Marcos) MSA, Texas, and U.S.; 8 occupations incl. Musicians and Singers (SOC 27-2042)
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: *Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages (QCEW), annual-by-industry files* (2001–2025 (2025 vintage carries no MSA-level rows)). https://www.bls.gov/cew/ (UI-covered wage-and-salary jobs only; excludes the self-employed)	Travis County, Texas, U.S., and Austin-Round Rock(-San Marcos) MSA; NAICS 71, 7111, 71113, 7115
U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics: *Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U), U.S. city average, all items (series CUUR0000SA0), via the BLS Public Data API* (monthly, January 2007–June 2026). https://api.bls.gov/publicAPI/v2/timeseries/data/ (no value was published for October 2025 because of the federal government shutdown; linearly interpolated in this project's analysis and flagged)	U.S. national; used as the deflator for Austin venue receipts and cost-of-living series
U.S. Census Bureau: *American Community Survey (ACS) Public Use Microdata Sample (PUMS), 2020–2024 5-Year* (released 2026-03-05 (newest 5-year PUMS available as of retrieval)). https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/data/pums/2024/5-Year/csv_ptx.zip (OCCP reflects a respondent's current or most recent job only; dollar values are nominal unless the ADJINC adjustment factor is applied)	Texas statewide and the Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA (5-county PUMA crosswalk); 9 creative-occupation OCCP codes
U.S. Census Bureau: *Nonemployer Statistics (NES), county and state historical datasets* (2012–2023 (2023 is the latest available; 2024 not yet released as of retrieval)). https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/nonemployer-statistics/datasets/2023/historical-datasets/nonemp23co.zip (counts establishments, not people; excludes unregistered/informal gig work)	Travis, Williamson, Hays, Bastrop, Caldwell, Harris, Dallas, Tarrant, and Bexar counties, plus Texas statewide; NAICS 711/7111/7115
U.S. Census Bureau: *ACS Table-Based Summary File, tables B25064 (median gross rent) and B25077 (median home value)* (2017–2021 and 2020–2024 5-Year estimates). https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/acs/summary_file/2024/table-based-SF/data/5YRData/acsdt5y2024-b25064.dat (this table-based format does not exist before the 2021 vintage; 5-year estimates smooth over sharp cyclical turns)	Travis, Dallas, Harris, Bexar, and Davidson counties and their MSAs
U.S. Census Bureau: *Vintage 2025 State Population Totals (NST-EST2025-ALLDATA)* (July 1, 2025 estimates). https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/popest/datasets/2020-2025/state/totals/NST-EST2025-ALLDATA.csv	All 50 states; used as the per-capita denominator for state policy comparisons
U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis: *Arts and Cultural Production Satellite Account (ACPSA)* (2023 data, released April 2, 2025 (BEA news release 25-13)). https://www.bea.gov/data/special-topics/arts-and-culture (BEA announced in February 2026 that it will no longer regularly produce ACPSA statistics; the 2023/April-2025 release is the final regular annual release)	Texas plus 7 comparison states (CA, NY, TN, GA, LA, FL, WA) and the U.S., 2001–2023 (state); U.S. industry detail, 1998–2023
U.S. Bureau of Economic Analysis: *Regional Price Parities (RPP) and Implicit Regional Price Deflators (IRPD) by MSA* (2008–2024 annual (no 2025 vintage yet released)). https://apps.bea.gov/regional/zip/MARPP.zip	Austin, Dallas-Fort Worth, Houston, San Antonio, and Nashville MSAs, plus the U.S.
U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development: *Fair Market Rents (FMR), all-years file* (FY1983–FY2026 (FY1984 is missing from HUD's own archive)). https://www.huduser.gov/portal/datasets/FMR/FMR_All_1983_2026.csv	Travis (Austin), Dallas, Harris (Houston), Bexar (San Antonio), and Davidson (Nashville) counties/HUD metro areas
U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration: *List of Apprenticeable Occupations* (cover sheet revised March 2020; current live version as of retrieval). https://www.dol.gov/sites/dolgov/files/ETA/apprenticeship/pdfs/Available_Occupations.xlsx	National, 1,441 titles; 16 arts/entertainment/media/audio titles extracted, incl. Musician (RAPIDS code 2080CB)
U.S. Small Business Administration: *Shuttered Venue Operators Grant (SVOG) awards file* ("Awards as of 07-05-2022" (the last file SBA has published to its open-data portal)). https://data.sba.gov/sites/default/files/distribution/SBA-ODA-2022-09-001/awards-as-of-7-5-22.xlsx (the commonly cited $16.25 billion appropriated figure differs from the $14.57 billion this file shows as awarded)	National (13,011 records); Texas and Austin-area subsets
U.S. Small Business Administration: *Paycheck Protection Program (PPP) FOIA loan-level data* (snapshot as of 2024-09-30; loans originated 2020–2021). https://data.sba.gov/dataset/ppp-foia (NAICS is self-reported; 722410 (drinking places) is a broad bar/tavern category not specific to live music)	Texas subset, NAICS 711130/711310/722410; Austin-area subset

Documents

Census Bureau

- **U.S. Census Bureau.** *2020 Census Tract to 2020 PUMA Relationship File.* 2020 vintage geography. https://www2.census.gov/geo/docs/maps-data/data/rel2020/2020_Census_Tract_to_2020_PUMA.txt. (used to build the Austin MSA PUMA crosswalk)
- **U.S. Census Bureau / Office of Management and Budget.** *Core-Based Statistical Area Delineation Files, 2023 vintage.* 2023 OMB delineation. https://www2.census.gov/programs-surveys/metro-micro/geographies/reference-files/2023/delineation-files/list1_2023.xlsx. (confirms the 5-county Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos MSA definition)

Reports and legislation

- **National Endowment for the Arts.** *Arts and Cultural Production, State Profile: Texas.* 2026-produced document; underlying data is the 2023 ACPSA release. https://www.arts.gov/impact/state-profiles/texas.
- **National Endowment for the Arts.** *Texas Fact Sheet.* filename dated 2025; the PDF's own footer reads "Produced 2026". https://www.arts.gov/sites/default/files/2025_texas_fact_sheet.pdf. (rounds Texas's ACPSA GDP share to "3 percent"; the underlying BEA ratio is 2.5 percent)
- **U.S. Small Business Administration, Office of Inspector General.** *Report 25-21: SBA's Oversight of Shuttered Venue Operators Grant Recipients.* July 2025. https://www.oversight.gov/sites/default/files/documents/reports/2025-07/SBA%20OIG%20Report%2025-21.pdf.
- **Congressional Research Service.** *Report R46689: SBA Shuttered Venue Operators Grant Program (SVOG).* https://www.congress.gov/crs_external_products/R/PDF/R46689/R46689.5.pdf.
- **U.S. Small Business Administration.** *New Report Shows Consequential Impacts of SBA Pandemic Relief.* January 15, 2025.

https://www.sba.gov/article/2025/01/15/new-report-shows-consequential-impacts-sba-pandemic-relief.

- **U.S. Department of Labor.** *Apprenticeship.gov, Data and Statistics.* dashboards cover FY Oct. 2014–Jul. 15, 2026. https://www.apprenticeship.gov/data-and-statistics. (dashboards are Tableau-rendered with no static export; no Texas-by-occupation cross-tab is obtainable)
- **U.S. Department of Labor.** *Registered Apprenticeship Partners Information Data System (RAPIDS), dataset listing.* https://catalog.data.gov/dataset/registered-apprenticeship-partners-information-database-system-rapids-dataset. (access level "non-public")
- **U.S. House of Representatives.** *Living Wage for Musicians Act, H.R. 7763, 118th Congress (Rep. Tlaib et al.).* introduced March 20, 2024. *URL not recorded.* (text retrieved via GovInfo; exact URL not recorded)
- **U.S. House of Representatives.** *Living Wage for Musicians Act, H.R. 5664, 119th Congress (Rep. Tlaib et al.).* reintroduced September 30, 2025. *URL not recorded.* (text retrieved via GovInfo; exact URL not recorded)

State of Texas sources

Statutes and legislation

- **Texas Legislature, 87th R.S. (2021).** *Senate Bill 609, enrolled (creates Government Code ch. 485, subch. C, the Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program).* effective September 1, 2021. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/87R/billtext/pdf/SB00609F.pdf. (the enacting statute; House Bill 2806 (86R) is a predecessor bill that died without a Senate vote)
- **Texas Legislature, 86th R.S. (2019).** *House Bill 2806, bill history.* passed the House April 24, 2019; died on the Senate intent calendar. https://capitol.texas.gov/BillLookup/History.aspx?LegSess=86R&Bill=HB2806. (not enacted; do not cite as the enacting statute for the incubator rebate)
- **Texas Legislative Budget Board.** *Fiscal Note, House Bill 2806 (86R), as introduced.* 2019. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/86R/fiscalnotes/html/HB02806I.htm.
- **Texas Legislative Budget Board.** *Fiscal Note, Senate Bill 609 (87R), as introduced.* April 6, 2021. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/87R/fiscalnotes/html/SB00609I.htm. (the engrossed/enrolled fiscal note was not available)
- **Texas Senate Research Center.** *Bill Analysis, Senate Bill 609 (87R).* 2021. https://www.lrl.texas.gov/scanned/srcBillAnalyses/87-0/SB609RPT.PDF.
- **Texas Legislature, 89th R.S. (2025).** *Senate Bill 22, enrolled (Texas moving image industry incentive fund, adds Tax Code § 151.801(g)).* effective 2025; sunsets September 1, 2035. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/89R/billtext/pdf/SB00022F.pdf. ($300 million per biennium for film, against $20.2 million per biennium for the music incubator rebate)
- **Texas Tax Code.** *§ 351.101, Use of [Municipal Hotel Occupancy] Tax Revenue.* current. https://texas.public.law/statutes/tex._tax_code_section_351.101. (third-party statute mirror; the official statutes.capitol.texas.gov deep link did not resolve; verify before publication)

General Appropriations Act

- **Texas Legislature, 89th R.S. (Senate Bill 1, 2025).** *General Appropriations Act, 2026–27 biennium.* LBB print dated September 19, 2025. https://www.lbb.texas.gov/Documents/GAA/General_Appropriations_Act_2026_2027.pdf. (Rider 40, Rider 45, Strategy C.2.1, and footnote 3)
- **Texas Legislature, 88th R.S. (House Bill 1, 2023).** *General Appropriations Act, 2024–25 biennium.* 2023. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/88R/billtext/pdf/HB00001F.pdf. (Rider 39, the first Texas Music Incubator appropriation)
- **Texas Legislature, 87th R.S. (Senate Bill 1, 2021).** *General Appropriations Act, 2022–23 biennium.* 2021. https://capitol.texas.gov/tlodocs/87R/billtext/pdf/SB00001F.pdf. (contains no Texas Music Incubator appropriation, confirmed by full-text search)

Texas Music Office

- **Texas Music Office, Office of the Governor.** *Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program (TMIR), program page.* current as of retrieval. https://gov.texas.gov/music/tmir. (sole source for the FY2026 award total ($10.1 million / 180 recipients / 60 cities))
- **Office of the Governor of Texas.** *Governor Abbott Announces Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program.* September 1, 2023. https://gov.texas.gov/news/post/governor-abbott-announces-texas-music-incubator-rebate-program.
- **Texas Music Office.** *Texas Music Incubator Rebate Program brochure and applicant checklist.* undated. https://gov.texas.gov/uploads/files/music/TMIR_Brochure.pdf. (image-based PDFs; text extraction returns nothing)
- **Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts.** *Manual of Accounts, Texas Music Incubator Account No. 5193.* Fiscal 2025 edition. https://fmcpa.cpa.state.tx.us/fiscalmoa/fund.jsp?num=5193.
- **Texas Music Office.** *Music Friendly Texas (Music Friendly Communities), program page.* current as of retrieval. https://gov.texas.gov/music/page/music-friendly-communities. (the page's headline count (92) and its own transcribed list (94 entries) disagree)
- **Texas Music Office, Office of the Governor.** *Texas Music Office homepage.* current as of retrieval. https://gov.texas.gov/music.
- **Texas Music Office (via Internet Archive).** *Texas Music Industry Directory, archived snapshots (talent, business, and radio listings).* April 2025 snapshots. http://web.archive.org/web/20250413id_/https://texasmusic.reel-scout.com/crew_directorylist_content.aspx?type=S. (the live directory (texasmusic.reel-scout.com) is Cloudflare-gated; the legacy gov.texas.gov/Apps/Music/Directory application is retired; no registration counts could be verified)
- **TXP, Inc. (for the Texas Music Office).** *The 2024 Economic Impact of Music in Texas.* January 2025 (2024 reference year). https://gov.texas.gov/uploads/files/music/TXP_TX_Music_Impact_Winter_2025.pdf. (job counts derive from TMO's own self-listed business directory; revenue ratios are anchored to the 2017 Economic Census; 2024 is the first year to include tourism)
- **Texas Music Office.** *Economic impact study index (2015, 2017, 2019, 2021, 2023, 2025 editions).* current as of retrieval. https://gov.texas.gov/music/page/economic-impact-study. (only the 2025 edition was obtained; earlier editions were not downloaded)
- **Texas Music Office.** *Tourism Commission presentation (City of Austin EDIMS document).* undated; content circa 2023. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=428363.
- **Texas Music Office.** *Facebook post, FY2026 TMIR results.* circa 2026. https://www.facebook.com/texasmusicoffice/posts/1393226669502889/.

Texas Commission on the Arts

- **Texas Commission on the Arts.** *Legislative Appropriations Request, FY2024–2025 biennium.* 2022. https://www.arts.texas.gov/wp-content/uploads/2022/07/2024-2025_LAR_TCA_2022-07-28.pdf. (baseline request only; does not reflect final enacted supplemental riders or grants)
- **Texas Commission on the Arts.** *FY26 Operating Budget.* as of October 31, 2025. https://www.arts.texas.gov/wp-content/uploads/2026/02/FY26_Operating_Budget_2025-10-31.pdf.
- **Texas Commission on the Arts.** *FY25 Operating Budget.* as of July 31, 2025. https://www.arts.texas.gov/wp-content/uploads/2025/09/FY25_Operating_Budget.pdf.
- **Texas Commission on the Arts.** *Texas Commission on the Arts homepage.* current as of retrieval. https://www.arts.texas.gov/. (no discipline-level grant breakout is published; music's share of TCA grants is not available)

Texas Comptroller data

- **Texas Comptroller of Public Accounts.** *Mixed Beverage Gross Receipts (Texas Open Data Portal, dataset naix-2893).* obligation end dates 2007-01 through 2026-08; dataset last refreshed 2026-08-01 per its own metadata. Travis County and City of Austin extract (267,708 rows retrieved; 3,802,638 rows statewide). https://data.texas.gov/dataset/Mixed-Beverage-Gross-Receipts/naix-2893. (mixed-beverage (liquor) permittees only; excludes beer-and-wine-only and non-alcohol venues)

City of Austin sources

Datasets

Every dataset below was retrieved on 2026-08-01; that column is omitted from the table.

Series / dataset (vintage)	Geography & years used
City of Austin (Open Budget ATX / Socrata): *Revenue Open Budget – revised (5rhv-xasu)* (FY2021–FY2027). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/5rhv-xasu.csv	Live Music Fund, Iconic Venue Fund, Cultural Arts Fund, Historic Preservation Fund, HOT Fund
City of Austin (Open Budget ATX / Socrata): *Expense Open Budget – revised (yeeq-kk6v)* (FY2021–FY2027). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/yeeq-kk6v.csv	same six HOT-related funds, expenditure side

(City of Austin sources, continued)

Series / dataset (vintage)	Geography & years used
City of Austin (Open Budget ATX / Socrata): *Program Budget Operating Budget vs. Expense Raw Data (g5k8-8sud)* (FY2026 Q3). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/g5k8-8sud.csv (single fiscal year only; no time series possible)	fund/department/unit/expense-object detail, incl. ACME and Music and Entertainment activity lines
City of Austin (Socrata): *Cultural Funding Awards (x6aj-qng8)* (1982–FY2023; dataset last updated 2024-02-29). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/x6aj-qng8.csv (Cultural Arts Fund only, not the Live Music Fund; FY2022 is missing entirely)	6,476 individual awards
City of Austin (Socrata): *Median Earnings of Creative Sector Occupations (2qxc-8cme)* (vintage not stated in metadata). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/2qxc-8cme.csv (verify vintage before use)	54 rows
City of Austin (Socrata): *Creative Sector Industry Codes, 2016 (mbwg-yjpy)* (2016). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/mbwg-yjpy.csv	51 rows; the City's own NAICS-based definition of the creative sector
City of Austin (Socrata): *Creative Workspaces, Performance Venues, Galleries & Museums (qxfh-ycp7)* (last refreshed 2016-11-11). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/qxfh-ycp7.csv (describes the venue stock as of roughly a decade before this project)	2,136 rows, facility inventory
City of Austin (Socrata): *Number and Percentage of Creatives Reporting Access to Affordable Creative Space (r5j2-ynwq)* (2017 Creative Space Survey). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/r5j2-ynwq.csv	266 rows, survey-derived indicator
City of Austin (Socrata): *Creative Content Incentive Program Agreements (qwjz-np8k)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/qwjz-np8k.csv	10 rows; film/creative-content incentives, not music grants
City of Austin (Socrata): *Jobs Supported, Economic Development Department (69de-ksja)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/69de-ksja.csv	27 rows
City of Austin (Socrata): *Sound Ordinance Permits (ryu3-tuin)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/ryu3-tuin.csv	6,989 rows; includes Outdoor Music Venue permits
City of Austin (Socrata): *Sound Ordinance Permits, geographic extract (g3rj-dfgm)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/g3rj-dfgm.csv	same permit universe, geocoded
City of Austin (Socrata): *CAMP Arts and Cultural Facilities, 2017 (xjsy-32ku) and 2018 (8kxv-xaqc)* (2017 and 2018). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/xjsy-32ku.csv	Cultural Arts Master Plan facility inventories
City of Austin (Socrata): *ACME Museums and Cultural Centers (w2pp-ceu8)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/w2pp-ceu8.csv	–
City of Austin (Socrata): *ACE Events (teth-r7k8)*. https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/teth-r7k8.csv	54,169 rows
City of Austin (Socrata): *2022 Austin Music Census microdata extracts: Details (an3p-3yqx) and Zip Codes (p7ky-riuq)* (fielded July–September 2022). https://data.austintexas.gov/resource/an3p-3yqx.csv	2,227 respondents by 107 variables

Documents

Ordinances and resolutions

- **City of Austin.** *Ordinance No. 20190919-149 (creates the Live Music Fund; amends City Code 11-2-7, adds 11-2-8).* adopted September 19, 2019; effective September 30, 2019. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=328565.
- **City of Austin.** *Resolution No. 20160303-019, Austin Music and Creative Ecosystem Omnibus Resolution.* adopted March 3, 2016. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=253186.
- **City of Austin, Visitor Impact Task Force.** *Visitor Impact Task Force, Final Report to Austin City Council.* June 30, 2017. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=279988.
- **City of Austin.** *Resolution No. 20160818-075 (creates the 18-member Visitor Impact Task Force).* circa 2017. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=285060. (resolution number not printed on the retrieved copy)
- **City of Austin, Music & Entertainment Division.** *Live Music Fund Event Program, proposed guidelines (draft).* dated August 16, 2021. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=365831. (draft, not adopted text)
- **City of Austin, Music Commission.** *Recommendation 20220207-3b on Live Music Fund design.* February 7, 2022. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=376727.
- **City of Austin, Music & Entertainment Division.** *Austin Live Music Fund, 2024 Program Guidelines.* 2024. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=423038.
- **City of Austin.** *Austin Live Music Fund, 2024 draft Program Guidelines.* 2024 (draft). https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=426112.
- **City of Austin, Music Commission.** *Recommendation 20250203-010, "Evolution of the Austin Live Music Fund (2025 and beyond)".* February 3, 2025. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=445601.
- **City of Austin.** *Resolution No. 20230720-123 (sets the City's musician pay rate).* adopted July 20, 2023. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=413057. (applies to City-commissioned performances only)
- **City of Austin.** *Resolution (Version 3) on live music venue preservation.* circa 2020. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=351220. (version-3 draft; resolution number not printed on the retrieved copy; the related Ordinance 20201001-052 (SAVES Fund) and Resolution 20200103-013 (Live Music Venue Preservation Fund) were not separately captured (URL not recorded for either))
- **City of Austin.** *Ordinance No. 20200423-067 (Austin Music Disaster Relief Fund, $1.5 million).* adopted April 23, 2020. *URL not recorded.* (primary PDF not captured; cited only via secondary reporting)
- **City of Austin, Law Department.** *Draft ordinance amending City Code Chapter 9-2 (Red River extended-hours pilot).* dated March 30, 2018. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=296553.

Award lists and program pages

- **City of Austin.** *Live Music Fund, FY2023 Event Program Awardee List.* 2023. https://austin.widen.net/content/jfxwxsxktx/pdf/2023LiveMusicFundEventProgramAwardeeList.pdf. (369 awards, $3,490,000 by independent line-item tally (press reports 368 awardees / $3.5 million))
- **City of Austin.** *Austin Live Music Fund, FY2024 Awardee List.* 2024. https://austin.widen.net/content/bpzuacfkk8/pdf/FY24-AwardeeList_Austin-Live-Music-Fund.pdf. (136 awards, $4,365,000 by independent line-item tally)
- **City of Austin.** *2026 ACME Funding Program Award List (Live Music Fund and Elevate).* March 2026. https://austin.widen.net/s/hhgtdnjqmn/almf_acme-2026-funding-program-award-list. (internally inconsistent totals (the venue count and the musician/promoter subtotal each disagree with the document's own line items by a small margin); cite the document's stated totals)
- **City of Austin.** *Creative Space Assistance Program, FY2019 award list.* FY2019. https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/36ruwqr9dt/FY19-CSAP-AWARDS.pdf?t.download=true.
- **City of Austin.** *Creative Space Assistance Program, FY2023 award list.* FY2023. https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/9xav5mpgtl/FY23-CSAP-AWARDS.pdf?t.download=true.
- **City of Austin.** *Creative Space Assistance Program, FY2026 award list.* FY2026. https://austin.widen.net/s/m2dzk6qcvg/csap_acme-2026-funding-program-award-list.
- **City of Austin.** *Creative Space Assistance Program, program page.* current as of retrieval. https://www.austintexas.gov/creative-space-assistance-program.
- **City of Austin.** *City of Austin Announces 2026 Cultural Funding Awards*

(news release). March 2026. https://www.austintexas.gov/communications/news/city-austin-announces-2026-cultural-funding-awards.

- **City of Austin.** *Live Music Fund program page (ATX Music)*. current as of retrieval; FY27 cycle. https://www.austintexas.gov/atxmusic/live-music-fund.
- **City of Austin, Office of Arts, Culture, Music and Entertainment (ACME).** *Funding programs overview page (Elevate, Thrive, Live Music Fund, Heritage Preservation, Nexus, CSAP)*. current as of retrieval. https://www.austintexas.gov/arts-culture/funding-programs.
- **Create Austin (Long Center for the Performing Arts).** *Austin Live Music Fund Application Breakdown*. 2024. https://createaustin.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/03/Austin-Live-Music-Fund-Application-Breakdown2.pdf.

City Auditor reports

- **City of Austin, Office of the City Auditor.** *Special Request: EDD Culture and Arts Funding*. October 2024. https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/pifyu2e2j6/Special_Request_EDD_Culture_and_Arts_Funding_October_2024.pdf?t.download=true. (scope explicitly excludes funding for music or music-disaster relief)
- **City of Austin, Office of the City Auditor.** *Cultural Arts Contract Monitoring*. September 2018. https://austin.widen.net/view/pdf/jep13duk08/Cultural_Arts_Contract_Monitoring_September_2018.pdf?t.download=true.
- **City of Austin, Office of the City Auditor.** *Audit reports index*. checked 2026-08-01. https://www.austintexas.gov/auditor/audit-reports. (no music-specific audit exists in the index)

Other states' programs and evaluations

Georgia

- **Georgia Department of Audits and Accounts (with Georgia Southern University CBAER).** *Georgia Music Tax Credit: Economic and Fiscal Impact Analysis*. report dated December 8, 2023; published December 14, 2023. https://www.audits.ga.gov/ReportSearch/download/30448. (the single most important peer-state document: zero credits were ever awarded over the credit's active life)
- **Georgia Office of Planning and Budget / Georgia Southern University Fiscal Research Center.** *Tax Expenditure Report, FY2025 edition*. FY2025 edition; Department of Revenue data as of tax year 2021. https://opb.georgia.gov/document/tax-expenditure-reports/fy-2025-tax-expenditure-report-0/download. (reports the musical credit as "(m)", less than $1 million; superseded by the DOAA finding of exactly zero)
- **Georgia Office of Planning and Budget.** *Tax Expenditure Report, FY2024 edition*. FY2024 edition; Department of Revenue data as of tax year 2020. https://open.ga.gov/openga/report/downloadFile?rid=29170.
- **Georgia Department of Revenue.** *Musical Tax Credit (program page)*. undated. https://dor.georgia.gov/musical-tax-credit. (describes the tier-1 bonus rate but not the full tier-1/tier-2 structure)
- **Georgia Department of Revenue.** *Ga. Comp. R. & Regs. R. 560-7-8-.61*. 2017, amended 2025. https://www.law.cornell.edu/regulations/georgia/Ga-Comp-R-Regs-R-560-7-8-.61. (third-party (Cornell) reproduction)
- **Georgia Department of Economic Development.** *Ga. Comp. R. & Regs. R. 159-1-2-.01*. 2017, amended 2025. https://rules.sos.ga.gov/gac/159-1-2. (official Secretary of State source)
- **Official Code of Georgia Annotated.** *O.C.G.A. § 48-7-40.33 (Georgia Music Tax Credit statute)*. *URL not recorded*. (full statutory text not retrieved (blocked on every mirror attempted); statutory substance reconstructed from the DOAA evaluation and the Department of Revenue/GDEcD rules above)

Louisiana

- **Louisiana Department of Revenue.** *Tax Exemption Budget, 2025–2026 edition*. actuals through FYE June 30, 2025; projections for FYE 2026–2027. https://dam.ldr.la.gov/publications/TEB(2025)(WEB).pdf. (primary utilization source; figures are revenue loss (credits claimed), not credits certified or the statutory cap)
- **Louisiana Department of Revenue.** *Return on Investment Analysis for Selected Louisiana Tax Incentive Programs (R-21000)*. published January 2025; analyzes FY2023. https://dam.ldr.la.gov/publications/R-21000(1_25)%20ROI%20Report%20d5%20(WEB).pdf. (neither Louisiana music credit appears; both fall below the $1 million statutory trigger for review)
- **Louisiana Legislature.** *La. R.S. 47:6023 (Sound Recording Investor Tax Credit), current text*. current, incl. 2024 Third Extraordinary Session amendments. https://www.legis.la.gov/Legis/Law.aspx?d=321887.
- **Louisiana Legislature, 2025 R.S..** *House Bill 653, enrolled (would have extended and expanded the Sound Recording Investor Tax Credit)*. enrolled June 2025. https://www.legis.la.gov/legis/ViewDocument.aspx?d=1421402. (passed 89-7 (House) and 32-5 (Senate); vetoed by the Governor June 20, 2025)
- **Louisiana Legislature.** *House Bill 653 (2025), bill status and action history*. current as of retrieval. https://www.legis.la.gov/Legis/BillInfo.aspx?s=25RS&b=HB653&sbi=y.
- **Louisiana Department of Revenue.** *2024 Third Extraordinary Session Legislative Summaries*. rev. January 2, 2025. https://dam.ldr.la.gov/miscellaneous/2024%20Tax%20Reform%20Legislative%20Summaries%20rev%201.2.25.pdf. (self-labeled "informal advice," not binding on LDR)
- **Louisiana Economic Development (Louisiana Entertainment).** *Sound Recording and Live Performance Production, program pages*. current as of retrieval; both programs closed to new applications June 30, 2025. https://www.louisianaentertainment.gov/music/sound-recording-program.
- **Louisiana Legislature.** *La. R.S. 47:6034 (Musical and Theatrical Production Tax Credit), full statutory text*. *URL not recorded*. (not retrieved; every mirror attempted returned an error. Program design reconstructed from the Tax Exemption Budget and the Louisiana Entertainment program pages)

New York

- **New York State Senate.** *N.Y. Tax Law § 24-c (New York City Musical and Theatrical Production Tax Credit)*. current. https://www.nysenate.gov/legislation/laws/TAX/24-C. (the research brief's working citation of § 24-a was wrong; § 24-a is the separate, much smaller upstate program)
- **Empire State Development.** *New York City Musical and Theatrical Production Tax Credit, program page*. current as of retrieval. https://esd.ny.gov/new-york-city-musical-and-theatrical-production-tax-credit.
- **Empire State Development.** *Program Guidelines, NYC Musical and Theatrical Production Tax Credit*. rev. July 5, 2024. https://esd.ny.gov/sites/default/files/media/document/Program-Guidelines-NYC-MT-07052024.pdf. (stale on the cap and sunset date (states $300 million and September 30, 2025); still authoritative on eligibility and equity requirements)
- **Empire State Development.** *Musical and Theatrical Tax Credit Annual Report, 2024 (upstate, § 24-a program)*. calendar year 2024; PDF authored January 23, 2025. https://www.esd.ny.gov/esd-media-center/reports/musical-and-theatrical-tax-credit-annual-report-2024. (covers only the smaller upstate program; ESD publishes no equivalent public report for the larger NYC program)
- **Justia (New York Consolidated Laws).** *N.Y. Tax Law § 24-a (Empire State Musical and Theatrical Production Credit)*. 2024 code. https://law.justia.com/codes/new-york/tax/article-1/24-a/. (blocked by Cloudflare on direct fetch; content obtained via search summary and should be treated as secondary)
- **New York State Department of Taxation and Finance.** *Annual Report on New York State Tax Expenditures, FY2027 edition, Table 8 (cross-article tax credits)*. 2026 report. https://www.tax.ny.gov/data/stats/ter/fiscal-year27/cross-article-tax-credits.htm. (primary source for actual claims by tax year)
- **New York State Department of Taxation and Finance.** *Annual Report on New York State Tax Expenditures, FY2026 edition, Table 8*. 2025 report. https://www.tax.ny.gov/data/stats/ter/fiscal-year26/cross-article-tax-credits.htm.
- **New York State Department of Taxation and Finance.** *FY2026 Executive Budget, tax expenditure proposals*. January 2025. https://www.tax.ny.gov/data/stats/ter/fiscal-year26/executive-budget-tax-expenditure-proposals.htm. (source of a disputed $1.5 million per-production cap figure that does not appear in the current statute)
- **New York State Department of Taxation and Finance.** *FY2027 Executive Budget, tax expenditure proposals*. January 2026. https://www.tax.ny.gov/data/stats/ter/fiscal-year27/executive-budget-tax-expenditure-proposals.htm.

Tennessee

- **Tennessee Entertainment Commission.** *TEC Scoring Incentive Program Guidelines*. rev. July 1, 2025. https://www.tnentertainment.com/lib/file/manager/PDFs/Guidelines_TEC_Scoring_Incentive_Program_Rev_July_1st_2025.pdf. (funded through the Visual Content Modernization Act of 2018, not the 2006 act named in the original research brief; the underlying T.C.A. section numbers were not verified)
- **Tennessee Entertainment Commission.** *Music incentives page*. current as of retrieval. https://www.tnentertainment.com/music/incentives/.
- **Tennessee Entertainment Commission.** *Complete Production Incentive Guidelines (film/TV)*. rev. July 10, 2024. https://www.createtn.com/lib/file/manager/TEC_Complete_Production_Incentive_Guidelines.pdf. (music videos are expressly ineligible; conflicts with the TEC website on the film minimum-spend threshold)
- **Tennessee Entertainment Commission.** *Film incentives page*. current as of retrieval. https://www.tnentertainment.com/film/incentives/.
- **State of Tennessee, Department of Finance and Administration.** *State Budget Document, FY2026–2027, Volume 1*. published January/February 2026. https://www.tn.gov/content/dam/tn/finance/budget/documents/budget-archive/budget-documents/2027BudgetDocumentVol1.pdf. (line 330.17 (Film and Television Incentive Fund) funds both the film and the music/scoring incentive with no breakout)
- **State of Tennessee, Department of Finance and Administration.** *State Budget Document, FY2025–2026, Volume 1*. published January/February 2025. https://www.tn.gov/content/dam/tn/finance/budget/documents/budget-archive/budget-documents/2026BudgetDocumentVol1.pdf.

Cross-state benchmarking

- **Oxford Economics.** *The Concerts and Live Entertainment Industry.* July 2021 report; 2019 reference year. *URL not recorded.* (not retrieved directly; a nine-state comparison table is reproduced in the Georgia DOAA evaluation (Table 4); Texas is not among the nine states shown there)

Surveys, studies, and industry reports

Austin Music Census and related city studies

- **Titan Music Group, LLC (for the City of Austin Economic Development Department, Music & Entertainment Division).** *The Austin Music Census: A Data-Driven Assessment of Austin's Commercial Music Economy.* fielded late 2014; published June 1, 2015; income data are pre-tax calendar 2013. https://austin.widen.net/content/om7zqn1qbx/pdf/Austin_Music_Census_Interactive_PDF_53115.pdf. (self-selected online convenience sample, n=3,968; authored by Titan Music Group, not TXP; microdata never publicly released)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *2022 Greater Austin Music Census – Summary Report.* fielded July 15–September 12, 2022; published February 2023. https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-SUMMARY-REPORT-v13-optimized.pdf. (n=2,260, self-selected; income questions were deliberately removed; image-only PDF)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *2022 Greater Austin Music Census – Data Appendix.* 2023. https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-Data-APPENDIX-v12-optimized.pdf.
- **Sound Music Cities.** *2022 Greater Austin Music Census – DEI Data Deep Dive Appendix.* 2023. https://www.austinmusiccensus.org/s/2022-Greater-Austin-Music-Census-DEI-Data-APPENDIX-v12.pdf. (image-only PDF)
- **City of Austin Economic Development Department.** *Music and Creative Ecosystem Stabilization Recommendations.* June 2016. https://austin.widen.net/content/smcazf04mu/pdf/Music_and_Creative_Ecosystem_Stabilization_Recommendations__June_2016_.pdf.
- **City of Austin.** *Building Austin's Creative Capacity – Needs Assessment.* 2016. https://austin.widen.net/content/3ukvlrtdte/pdf/BuildingAustin_sCreativeCapacity_Compilation.pdf.
- **City of Austin.** *Thriving in Place: Supporting Austin's Cultural Vitality Through Place-Based Economic Development.* January 2018. https://austin.widen.net/content/cmebuokend/pdf/ThrivinginPlaceReport_1_30_18.pdf.
- **TXP, Inc..** *The Economic Impact of Music: 2016 UPDATE.* February 2016, using 2014 data. https://austin.widen.net/content/a0case0pss/pdf/TXP-Austin-Music-Impact-Update-2016-Final.pdf. (roughly two-thirds of the headline impact rests on a tourism-attribution assumption, not a direct measurement)
- **University of Texas at Austin (Prof. Eric Drott et al.).** *Support Austin Musicians.* drafted July 2024. https://supportaustinmusicians.org/final-summary/. (approximately 60 non-random interviews; project website, no named lead author, not peer reviewed)

National surveys of musician income

- **Krueger, Alan B., and Ying Zhen, with James Reeves (Music Industry Research Association, Princeton University Survey Research Center, and MusiCares).** *Report on the MIRA Musician Survey.* embargoed until June 22, 2018; fieldwork April–June 2018. http://web.archive.org/web/20181003155850/https://img1.wsimg.com/blobby/go/53aaa2d4-793a-4400-b6c9-95d6618809f9/downloads/1cgjrbs3b_761615.pdf. (n=1,227, nonrandom, 62% recruited from MusiCares clients; themira.org now returns 403, recovered via the Internet Archive)
- **Music Industry Research Association.** *MIRA Musician Survey, questionnaire.* 2018. https://www.ehcca.com/presentations/musicianssummit1/zhen_1_handout.pdf.
- **Zhen, Ying.** *MIRA wellbeing and representativeness, conference slides.* 2018. https://cip2.gmu.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/31/2020/09/Ying-Zhen-Presentation-Slides.pdf.
- **Zhen, Ying.** *Career challenges facing musicians in the United States.* Journal of Cultural Economics, 2022. https://link.springer.com/article/10.1007/s10824-022-09442-x. (paywalled; abstract only, not independently verified beyond the citation)
- **Zhen, Ying.** *Gender and Racial Discrimination in the U.S. Music Industry.* Sage, 2023. https://journals.sagepub.com/doi/10.1177/05694345221092958. (presumed paywalled; not retrieved)
- **Future of Music Coalition (Berkman Center / Rethinking Music).** *Artist Revenue Streams: A Multi-Method Research Project.* 2011–2012 fieldwork. https://cyber.harvard.edu/sites/cyber.harvard.edu/files/Rethinking_Music_Artist_Revenue_Streams.pdf.
- **DiCola, Peter.** *Money from Music: Survey Evidence on Musicians' Revenue and Lessons About Copyright Incentives.* Arizona Law Review 55, no. 2 (2013): 301–370. https://arizonalawreview.org/pdf/55-2/55arizlrev301.pdf. (peer-reviewed version of the Future of Music Coalition survey; publishes medians (music-income median $18,000) where the project website published only means)
- **Future of Music Coalition.** *Money from Music, survey snapshot and data memos.* fielded September 6–October 28, 2011. http://web.archive.org/web/20160323201420/http://money.futureofmusic.org/survey-snapshot/. (project site (money.futureofmusic.org) no longer resolves; recovered from the Internet Archive)
- **Americans for the Arts.** *Arts & Economic Prosperity 6: The Economic and Social Impact Study of Nonprofit Arts and Culture Organizations and Their Audiences.* 2023 (study year: calendar 2022). https://nmculture.org/assets/files/reports/AEP6_NationalReport.pdf. (original host (americansforthearts.org) returns 403; obtained from a mirror. Austin, Houston, and San Antonio did not participate; Texas coverage is limited to Dallas-Fort Worth and Frisco)

Other-city music censuses

- **Sound Music Cities.** *Nashville Music Census, 2024.* 2024. https://www.greaternashvillemusiccensus.org/results. (n=4,256 (the census homepage states 4,265, an unresolved discrepancy); average, not median, income)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *New Orleans Music Census, 2024.* fieldwork May 10–June 29, 2024; report dated August 2024. https://www.nolamusiccensus.org/.
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Washington, D.C. Music Census, 2024.* fieldwork April 10–May 29, 2024; report dated October 2024. https://www.dcmusiccensus.org/s/2024-DC-Music-Census-Report-Final-10-25-24-compressed.pdf. (the only cohort city publishing gig-pay medians alongside averages)
- **Sound Music Cities / City of Sacramento Office of Arts and Culture.** *Sacramento Music Census.* fieldwork October–November 2022; published August 2023. https://www.cityofsacramento.gov/content/dam/portal/ccs/office-of-arts-and-culture/music-census/2023-August-Sacramento-Music-Census-Summary-Report-PRINT.pdf. (image-only PDF with no text layer; every figure is OCR output and should be checked against the PDF by eye)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Minneapolis Music Census, 2024.* fieldwork April 12–May 6, 2024. https://mplsartsandculture.org/2024-minneapolis-music-census.
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Cleveland Music Census.* fieldwork November 8–December 15, 2023; released August 2024. https://clevelandrocksppf.org/wp-content/uploads/2024/08/2024-Cleveland-Summary-Report-v3.pdf.
- **Sound Music Cities / Johns Hopkins 21st Century Cities Initiative.** *Baltimore Music Census, 2024.* fieldwork March 4–June 26, 2024. https://21cc.jhu.edu/wp-content/uploads/sites/64/baltimore-music-census-report.pdf. (n=576, the smallest cohort city; the Industry and Venue subgroups are roughly 35–40 respondents each)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Charlotte Music Ecosystem Study and Action Plan.* released May 6, 2019. http://web.archive.org/web/20230121011932/http://musiceverywhereclt.com/files/2019/04/2019_0425_SMC_Charlotte_Digital.pdf. (n=1,802 (766 professionals); publishes a true median (under $10,000); a different instrument from the 2025 Charlotte Music Census)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Pittsburgh Music Ecosystem Study.* released July 2018. *URL not recorded.* (report PDF not obtainable (404, no Internet Archive capture); n=1,800+ per the project announcement; no Pittsburgh income figures available)
- **Sound Music Cities.** *Multi-City Music Census Cohort: additional editions (Anchorage, Chattanooga, Columbus, Lawrence, Tulsa, NW Arkansas, Greensboro, Detroit, Charlotte 2025, and Baton Rouge).* fielded 2022–2026 across the 2023–24 and 2025–26 cohorts. https://www.soundmusiccities.com/music-census-cohort. (individual per-city report URLs were not separately captured in this pass; Anchorage and Baton Rouge exist only as Tableau dashboards, and Tulsa only as an Issuu-hosted PDF)
- **Brown, Megan (Musicians' Association of Seattle, AFM Local 76-493).** *Seattle's Working Musicians.* 2015. *URL not recorded.* (n=124; local file only, no public URL recorded; median music income $15,000/year)

HAAM (Health Alliance for Austin Musicians)

- **Health Alliance for Austin Musicians (HAAM).** *2014 Annual Impact Report.* 2014. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2014-Annual-Impact-Report.
- **HAAM.** *2015 Annual Impact Report.* 2015. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2015-Annual-Impact-Report.
- **HAAM.** *2016 Annual Impact Report.* 2016. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2016-Annual-Impact-Report.
- **HAAM.** *2017-18 Annual Impact Report.* 2017–2018. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2017-18-Annual-Impact-Report.
- **HAAM.** *2019 Annual Impact Report.* 2019. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2019-HAAM-Annual-Impact-Report.pdf. (reprints 2015 Austin Music Census figures as though current)
- **HAAM.** *2020 Annual Impact Report.* 2020. https://www.myhaam.org/s/2020-Annual-Impact-Report. (source of the food-insecurity finding (29% pre-COVID to 74% post-COVID))
- **HAAM.** *2022 Annual Impact Report.* 2022. https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5ed3d236709a614ffb385827/t/6568bc7f36a53b2bce6899af/1747062958076/2022+HAAM+Digital+Annual+Report_.pdf.
- **HAAM.** *2023 Annual Impact Report (published under the filename "HAAM-Annual-Report_2024_rev.pdf"; the cover and content are FY2023).* 2023. https://www.myhaam.org/s/HAAM-Annual-Report_2024_rev.pdf.

(cite by content year, not filename)

- **HAAM.** *2024 Annual Impact Report (published under the filename "HAAM-Annual-Report-2024_Errata.pdf").* 2024. https://www.myhaam.org/s/HAAM-Annual-Report-2024_Errata.pdf.
- **HAAM.** *2025 Annual Impact Report ("Sustaining the Sound").* 2025. https://www.myhaam.org/s/HAAM-Sustaining-the-Sound-2025_web.pdf.
- **HAAM.** *Presentations to Austin City Council (two decks).* undated. https://services.austintexas.gov/edims/document.cfm?id=382651. (image-heavy slide decks; content overlaps the annual reports)
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SIMS Foundation

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